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43000 - 53000 (J&L)
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7 Days - Nov 20
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59000 - 64000 (Ex-Mumbai)

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39000 - 49000 (Ex-Mumbai)

Nainital Mussoorie Haridwar
7 Days - Sep 25, Oct 2
39000 - 45000 (J&L)
49000 - 55000 (Ex-Mumbai)

Oman
5 Days - Nov 21
110000 - 120000 (J&L)
145000 - 155000 (Ex-Delhi)

Dubai
5 Days - Sept 21
60000 - 70000 (J&L)
95000 - 105000 (Ex-Delhi)

Sri Lanka/Nepal
5D/8D - Sept 23 / Sept 23
53000 - 63000 (J&L)
85000 - 95000 (Ex-Delhi)

Bhutan
7D/9D - Oct 25/Sept 30
64000 - 91000 (J&L)
99000 - 121000 (Ex-Delhi)

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209000 - 213000 (Ex-Delhi)

Bali
7 Days - Nov 30
107000 - 112000 (J&L)
152000 - 157000 (Ex-Delhi)

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7 Days - Nov 15
195000 - 205000 (J&L)
260000 - 270000 (Ex-Delhi)

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6 Days - Sept 27
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191000 - 200000 (Ex-Delhi)

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5 Days / Dec 13
10 Days / Dec 10
125000 - 275000 (Ex-Delhi)

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8 Days - Sept 26
180000 - 185000 (J&L)
265000 - 270000 (Ex-Delhi)

Iceland Northern Lights
9 Days - Mar 11
395000 - 405000 (J&L)
505000 - 515000 (Ex-Delhi)

Australia/New Zealand
9 Days / 10 Days-Mar 4 / Mar 2
255000 - 312000 (J&L)
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'They all died, and I lived': Survivors of Nepal flood left in stunned disbelief

The floods left a mud line of more than 650 feet

Anupreeta Das
Dhunchu (Nepal), August 28

THE SURVIVORS sat patiently, waiting for their turn to be transported to safety. Some wept. Mothers clutched their babies. Husbands grieved for the wives whose hands they could no longer hold. And some onlookers expressed guilt that they had little to grieve for.

But mostly, on Thursday, a day after a huge chunk of a glacier fell and triggered a devastating flood and mud slide in Nepal, leaving more than 300 dead and more than 1,400 others missing, people along the border with Tibet were still in disbelief at the bewildering speed with which a river's fury had upended their lives.

In a matter of minutes, a grayish brown sludge of sand and pulverized rock had appeared out of nowhere and erased the bearings of their lives. Homes, shops, schools, fields, roads and bridges were mostly



People console a woman awaiting news of her family members missing since Wednesday in Nepal. NYT

gone. "They all died, and I lived," said Dawa Lama, 45, starting to weep as he recounted how, just before 9 am on Wednesday, he had heard a thunderclap, and then felt a breeze.

Before he knew it, an enormous wave of muddy water had slammed into his home of 12 years in the border village of Tilmure, carrying away not just his belongings but also his wife and

their two daughters, 7 and 8.

"How long can I remain in hope, I don't know," Lama said. His neighbour, who had also lost family members, placed a hand on Lama's shoulder to comfort him. Hundreds of people like Lama who were rescued from the region in northern Nepal, have landed in Dhunchu, a town about 17 miles from the Tibetan border where the Nepal Army

has a search-and-rescue base.

Signs of the miles of devastation left behind were visible even from on high. A major highway that ran alongside the river and connected Nepal and Tibet had entirely disappeared into the flash flood's maw. Only its edges were left behind like bread crumbs. Forty kilometers of roads were swept away, according to the Department of Roads,

stranding nearly 2 and a half lakh Nepalis who live in the most affected districts.

The flood transformed winding riverside roads into a bleak mud flat. Bridges were washed away, including 40 suspension crossings. Phone lines and cellular towers are now down, along with electricity for the homes that survived. In many places, the river had left a mud line more than 650 feet high.

The Nepal Army's base at Dhunchu was packed with hundreds of army personnel and the survivors they had rescued. The area had no electricity or phone networks after the flash flood, so personnel were using military radio sets to communicate. The helicopters taking off or landing about every 15 minutes from two helipads ferried injured people rescued from villages and towns nearby.

Among the survivors was Bhushan Thakur, a hairdresser who said he had fled from his salon as soon as he saw the huge wall of sludge making its way toward him. Thakur, 38, said he and two others had run for their lives, leaping up the hillside. "We jumped, and jumped," he said, "otherwise, we would have died." NYT

Nepal, China resume rescue ops after flood threat eases

Torrent of rock, ice, mud & debris led to formation of new 'overflowing' lake

Reuters
Nuwakot, Beijing, August 28

NEPAL AND China resumed rescue operations that had been suspended briefly in the flood-hit Himalayas on Friday after risks from an overflowing lake were found to be manageable, easing fears of fresh devastation.

Wednesday's catastrophic flood caused by a glacier collapse killed 547 people in Nepal and 1,500 in China's Tibet, with almost 1,000 more missing in the two countries.

• New Barrier Lake Formed



A huge torrent of rock, ice, mud and debris cascaded through Himalayan mountain river systems after the collapse, and also led to the formation of a lake where water continued to

collect and rise. On Friday, the lake's reservoir had topped 2.5 million cubic metres of water, up from the estimated 1.5-2 million cubic metres recorded a day earlier, before overflowing into the Lhende Khola river and then into the Trishuli, authorities and witnesses in Nepal said.

The overflow sparked panic and warnings from authorities in Nepal, leading to rescue operations being suspended for about three hours. The risk of the lake bursting had prompted all Chinese rescue personnel and vehicles to withdraw on the Chinese side as well and stand by in a safe area, state broadcaster CCTV said.

Both resumed rescue operations after the threat eased. "By noon, as the risk posed by the upstream dammed lake was deemed manageable, res-

cue operations for the Gyirong mudslide disaster quickly resumed and were stepped up," CCTV said. Wednesday's flood ripped through villages and valleys, destroying power stations, roads and bridges along a route that links Kathmandu with Lhasa in Tibet and is popular with trekkers and pilgrims.

More than 90,000 people are estimated to be affected, the Red Cross said, adding that trucks with relief supplies were blocked after the barrier lake broke its banks. In Beijing, China's Politburo met on Friday to direct rescue work, state media reported.

Authorities must "scientifically formulate search-and-rescue plans, make every effort to search for missing people from China and abroad," the meeting chaired by President Xi Jinping said, according to Xinhua.

Drone attacks pound Kyiv for 2nd day as Russia targets key logistics

Reuters
Kyiv, August 28

RUSSIA LAUNCHED waves of drones at Ukraine's capital Kyiv and surrounding region on Friday, damaging warehouses and homes in a second consecutive day of strikes Ukrainian officials said as there was an attempt to derail life for millions of residents.

At least one person was killed outside Kyiv, said Governor Tymur Tkachenko, adding that 14 warehouse premises, 16 homes and three blocks of apartment buildings had been damaged. Frequent air raid sirens blared throughout the city Friday, a day after an hours-long missile and drone attack on Ukraine that targeted major retailers and consumer logistics in Kyiv and elsewhere.

Those strikes continued on Friday, destroying sorting



Firefighters work at a shopping mall after Russian drone strikes in Zaporizhzhia region, Ukraine, on Friday. REUTERS

centres belonging to Ukraine's top private courier Nova Poshta near Kyiv and in the northern city of Sumy, the company said. In the southeastern city of Zaporizhzhia, a Russian drone tore into major home-improvement store Epicer, wounding at least four people, Governor Ivan Fedorov said on Friday.

Ukraine's state emergency service said Russia had attacked the Kyiv region 38 times during the past 24 hours, warning residents not to approach areas where firefighters were still battling blazes. Friday's attacks appeared aimed at prolonging the snarl-up sparked by strikes a day earlier.

Trump administration seeks to restrict internships for international students

Reuters
Washington, August 28

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump's administration has issued a memo for universities that seeks to restrict issuance of certain internship work authorizations for international students as the federal government warned that colleges not complying with the regulations may lose certification to enroll foreign students.

The federal memo dated August 24 said the Student and Exchange Visitor Program, which is part of the US Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency, has "observed a rise in Curricular Practical Training (CPT) authorizations that appear to violate regulatory requirements which permit CPT only where the training is an integral part of an

established curriculum." "Failure to comply with SEVP regulations may result in an institution losing certification to enroll foreign students," the memo said.

It resulted in some schools, including the University of California, Los Angeles and the University of California, Berkeley, pausing certain applications for work authorizations for international students. "UCLA has paused certain Curricular Practical Training authorizations while it reviews recent federal guidance and determines next steps," a UCLA spokesman said.

UC Berkeley's international office said the August 24 memo was "more narrow in focus, more direct, and includes content that is more restrictive in nature."

U.S. ISSUES ADDITIONAL TARGETED IRAN-RELATED MEASURES

Iran urges other nations to reject new US sanctions

Tehran brands US sanctions as 'crime against humanity'

Reuters
Dubai, August 28

IRAN CONDEMNED the United States' new economic sanctions on Friday as "state terrorism" and said other countries were legally obliged not to implement them, while the US Treasury Department announced additional targeted Iran-related measures.

The Iranian foreign ministry's statement came as mediators stepped up efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

President Donald Trump's administration Monday warned countries to cut their business ties with Iran or face secondary sanctions as part of what it billed as an "economic D-Day," though the Treasury Department stopped short of actually imposing penalties.

The official said the proposed rule, if finalised, would withdraw Banque Misr UAE's correspondent banking access to US financial institutions. Treasury officials separately issued sanctions targeting one entity based in Hong Kong and one person linked to Iran's Bank Mellat according to a notice posted on department's website.

With the US focused on its economic pressure campaign, others have sought to revive diplomatic efforts to end the war. Qatari PM Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al



Ships in the Strait of Hormuz near beach of Bandar Abbas, on Friday. AP

US measures a "crime against humanity" that put the health and livelihood of millions of civilians at serious risk, and called on other nations and UN bodies to uphold the rule of law.

Later on Friday, a US official told Reuters the Trump administration plans to impose limits on Egypt's Banque Misr for doing business with Tehran by revoking US financial access to its branches in the UAE.

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With the US focused on its economic pressure campaign, others have sought to revive diplomatic efforts to end the war.

Qatari PM Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al

Thani said he had stressed during talks with Iranian leaders in Tehran the importance of returning to pre-war status of open shipping through the Strait. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Friday described the talks with Al Thani as "creative," and renewed his appeal to the US to stop putting military and economic pressure on his country and to resume negotiations. "Putting diplomacy back on tracks isn't impossible. It hinges on US understanding of one simple fact: pressure doesn't work," Araghchi said on X.

Mohsen Rezaei, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, said on Thursday Iran was preparing a list of conditions for reopening the Strait.

In the past Iran's conditions have included an end to the US blockade on Iranian ports, compensation and removal of sanctions. It remained unclear whether Iran intended to amend demands in a way that might be acceptable to Washington.

Airstrike kills 3 in West Bank; Israel says it targeted Hamas operative

Reuters
Jenin, August 28

ISRAEL'S MILITARY said it carried out an airstrike in the West Bank on Friday that killed a Palestinian it described as a Hamas militant operative as well as two of his accomplices, in a rare use of deadly Israeli air power in the occupied territory.

Hamas condemned the strike but did not claim the person targeted — whom the Israeli military named as Qais Bitawi — as a member. The strike targeted a car in the area of Jenin in the northern West Bank, the military and media said.

Islamic Jihad said in a statement Bitawi was a senior operative of its armed wing.

In a statement, the military said Bitawi was involved in directing, funding and executing attacks on Israeli civilians and security forces. It said he maintained ties with Hamas members in Gaza, where the group is based, as well as abroad.

The Palestine Red Crescent ambulance service said Israeli ground troops raided the site of the drone strike, briefly detained medics and prevented them from transporting those wounded or killed to hospital.

Israel's military did not provide comment on the ambulance service's statements.

Israel's 2025 operations in the northern West Bank forced thousands of Palestinians from their homes.

• BRIEFLY

NORWAY

King Harald V, whose reign bridged tradition and modernity, dies at 89



Norway's King Harald V

in the service of Norway. "King Harald found the words to bind us together when we needed it most," he added. NYT

SUDAN

8 civilians killed, several injured in drone strikes

DRONE STRIKES have killed eight civilians and wounded dozens in Sudan's Kordofan region, a rights group said Friday. Emergency Lawyers, an independent group documenting atrocities in Sudan, said a drone targeted a group of civilians travelling on Thursday in the desert town of Sowdari in North Kordofan state. As others rushed to help the victims, a second drone struck, the group said. It called for an independent investigation to determine who was responsible. AP

CONGO

Ebola spreads to two more zones. 60 now affected

THE FASTEST-growing Ebola outbreak in history has spread to two new health zones in eastern Congo, with a total of 60 now affected, according to the latest government figures published on Friday. The two new zones affected are Bena and Mangredjia in Congo's North Kivu province, where the case fatality rate is much higher than the overall rate of 48 per cent, due in part to delayed response efforts, according to Congo's Ministry of Health data. AP

• U.S. OBJECTS TO MEXICO-EU TRADE DEAL EXTENDING SPECIAL PROTECTIONS TO HUNDREDS OF EUROPEAN PRODUCTS TIED TO SPECIFIC REGIONS SUCH AS PARMIGIANO REGGIANO, FETA AND MANCHEGO

From cheddar to trade barriers: Cheese names complicate US-Mexico trade talks

Sarah Morland
& Emily Green
Mexico City, August 28

WHAT'S IN a cheese name?

That question has become a sticking point in US-Mexico trade talks, according to two Mexican government sources who spoke on condition of anonymity because, no matter how you slice it, cheese diplomacy can be delicate.

The US is objecting to Mexico's new trade deal with the European Union, which extends special protections to hundreds of European products whose names are tied to specific regions, such as Parmigiano Reggiano, feta and manchego. It also

gives the European Union legal recourse against violations.

Washington argues that the deal, signed in May, would restrict future US producers from selling cheeses in Mexico under names such as parmesan and feta. The US has long maintained those names are generic, while the EU says parmesan should be reserved for Parmigiano Reggiano from northern Italy and feta cheese from select parts of Greece.

"It's absolutely wrong what Mexico did," said Jaime Castaneda, executive vice president of the US Dairy Export Council. "The Mexican government has to make it absolutely certain that the United States and the Mex-

ican manufacturers of common cheese names will continue to be able to be in the market."

The US and Mexico are in the midst of thorny bilateral talks to secure an interim trade deal this year, while parallel discussions are ongoing to renew the US-Mexico-Canada Agreement, a linchpin of Mexico's economy. Those high-stakes negotiations have given the US leverage to push its case for what has become a billion-dollar market for US cheese exporters. And it is causing a headache for Mexican authorities.

Although the Mexico-EU treaty has been signed, Mexico has yet to complete the procedures needed for the pact to take



Imported and Mexican cheeses are displayed at a store in Mexico City

effect, while EU has, according to a European Commission spokesperson. A spokesperson for Mexico's economy ministry said

the agreement needs to be ratified by lawmakers. The European Commission told Reuters it would not be

possible to change the agreement's terms and that it had "taken note of the US actions" opposing the protections for European cheeses.

Mexico's economy ministry and the Office of the US Trade Representative did not respond to requests for comment, though the US agency has previously stated its views on the EU's Geographical Indication (GI) product protection scheme. "The US continues to seek to expand its harmful GI system within its territory and beyond," the trade office said in an April report. It said that forcing dairy producers outside the bloc to use descriptors such as "imitation feta" or "asiago-style" was costly

and unnecessary and contributes to the \$1.2 billion US cheese trade deficit with the bloc.

Mexico is among the world's top consumers of cheese, favoring domestic varieties such as stringy Oaxaca cheese, often melted on quesadillas, and queso fresco, ideal for crumbly breakfast toppings.

But cheese imports, mainly from the US, have surged since the 1980s and now make up nearly 30% of domestic consumption, driven by products like Kraft's Grated Parmesan and Walmart's Great Value Manchego, as well as the growing popularity of pizzerias in Mexico.

The US exports about \$1 bil-

lion worth of cheese to Mexico annually, while the EU's total dairy exports to the country only amount to \$200 million.

European cheese producers said the clash with the US reflects opposing agricultural values — mass production versus protected regional traditions.

"The US has always been a nation of high-volume consumption, which is precisely the opposite of what designations of origin represent," said Antonio Martinez, head of a organization that protects manchego's regional designation. The smaller scale of manchego producers in Spain gives their "charm and unique identity," he added. REUTERS



The Indian EXPRESS

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400 INDIANS ON CHINESE SIDE SAFE; 517 FOREIGN TOURISTS AMONG 1,924 STILL MISSING

Nepal toll nears 600; MEA says 320 Indians, 100 of Indian origin missing

India sends more aid, medical team, rescue crew for tunnel rescue ops

Shubhajit Roy, Divya A & Yubaraj Ghimire
New Delhi, Kathmandu, August 28

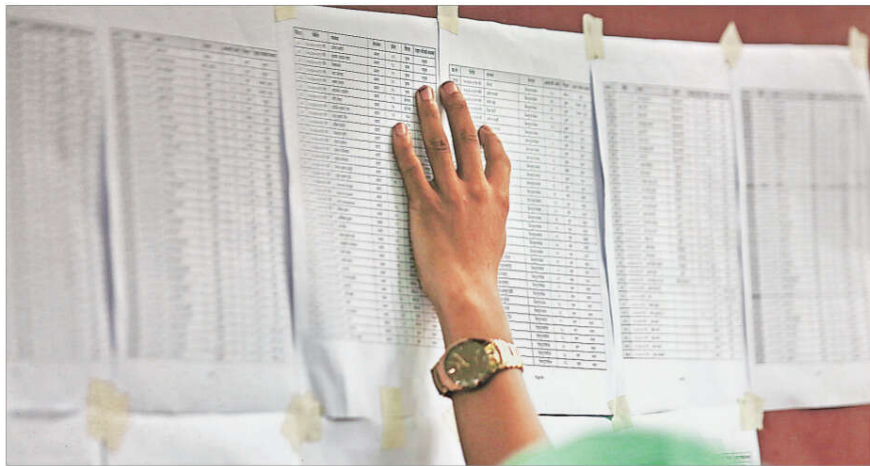
TWO DAYS after the deadly flash floods that swept through several districts of Nepal, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Friday said at least 320 Indians — up from 290 on Thursday — and over 100 people of Indian origin remained missing.

The total toll increased to 579 on Friday, with more bodies being recovered as search and rescue operations continued for the third day amid fears of fresh floods following an increase in the water level in the Bhotekoshi River area. At least 1,924 people, including 517 foreign tourists, are reported to be still missing.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said about 400 Indian nationals who were stranded on the Chinese side of the Sino-Nepal border were reported to be safe. These are pilgrims for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra. He said 149 Indian nationals who were stranded on the Chinese side had safely crossed over to Nepal.

Later in the day, India sent a third tranche of 10 tonnes of relief supplies, alongside an 11-member team of doctors and paramedics, as well as a reconnaissance crew to assess tunnel rescue operations.

"A third flight carrying 10 tonnes of humanitarian assistance has departed for Kathmandu. The assistance includes portable generator sets,"



People look for names of the survivors at Shree No. 1 Military Training Centre in Nepal's Nuwakot district, Friday. TASHI TOBYGAL

At search and rescue hub, roar of helicopters, stench of death



DEVANSH MITTAL TASHI TOBYGAL
EXPRESS IN NEPAL
Nuwakot, August 28

AT 9.02 am on Wednesday, Milan Kharil, a 32-year-old geologist engineer at the Trishuli 1 hydropower plant in Rasuwa district of Nepal's Bagmati province, called a junior colleague and told him to immediately rush to higher ground. A flood was about to hit their facility, Milan said.



A chopper brings those rescued to the military centre at Trishuli, Nepal, Friday. TASHI TOBYGAL

Twenty-four minutes later, at 9.26 am, Milan's phone transmitted its location for the last time. The cell was then at a place it would have taken more

than two hours to reach by road.

Two days later, Milan remains missing. His sister Priya Kharil, two years older than

'I tried to hold on to my wife's hand, but water current was so strong'

Devansh Mittal
Nuwakot, August 28

THEY MAY have survived the flash floods, but are haunted by the horror of Wednesday morning, when a wall of mud, rock and water took away the lives of their loved ones, and their livelihoods.

"I tried to hold on to my wife's hand, but the water current was so strong that I couldn't save her," says Shyam Lal Thapa, a 52-year-old farmer from Rasuwa district who lost his wife Gyanu. While his son is among those missing, his daughter-in-law is with him at the relief camp here. "I believe my son is alive. My daughter-



Santosh Thapa, a 29-year-old engineer, says he only survived because he overslept that day

in-law has not spoken a word since then," he says.

Shyam Lal says that for generations, his family lived off their paddy fields in the border

India seals deal to purchase Javelin anti-tank missile system from US

Shows defence ties growing deeper, more capable, more consequential: Gor

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 28

INDIA HAS finalised a deal to buy the Javelin anti-tank guided missile system from the United States. The Indian Army on Friday signed a Letter of Offer and Acceptance to buy the ordnance through the US Foreign Military Sales process.

Welcoming the decision, Washington said the "milestone" reflects the enduring partnership between the US and Indian armed forces, and opens the door for future collaboration between the defence industries.

"The landmark signature further strengthens the US-India Major Defence Partnership by demonstrating the depth of ongoing support to the Indian Army. It also opens discussions on mutually beneficial co-production and additional opportunities to strengthen the defence industrial bases of both countries," the US Embassy said in a statement.

E. EXPLAINED

What is the Javelin?



LOOKREEMARTIN.COM

The Javelin system is an advanced, "man-portable, medium-range, fire-and-forget, anti-tank guided missile. It is designed for use against a wide array of targets, including armoured vehicles and fortified positions. Besides the US Army and US Marine Corps, it has several international customers.

"This agreement reflects a defence partnership growing deeper, more capable, and more consequential," US Ambassador Sergio Gor said in a statement, adding that it "demonstrates depth of US support and creates new opportunities

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Before SC Collegium: Can Acting CJs of HCs send names for judge appointments?

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, August 28

THE CONTROVERSY over the conduct of Rajasthan High Court's Acting Chief Justice, Justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma, has revived a recurring question in the Supreme Court Collegium: how to treat recommendations for the appointment of High Court judges sent by an Acting Chief Justice of a High Court.

While Justice Sharma has been an acting Chief Justice for almost a year (since September 2025), the SC Collegium will have to consider at least four names recommended by him, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The SC Collegium, headed by CJI Surya Kant, also comprises Justices Vikram Nath, BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh and PS Narasimha.

Sources said one view within the Collegium is that names sent by an Acting CJ must not be returned only because of the official title but must be considered on merit. This view is aided by a relatively long tenure of Justice

Sharma as Acting CJ and the fact that Rajasthan is also his parent HC. It is learnt that another view cautions that accepting names from Acting Chief Justices will normalise long-term temporary tenures since there will be no apparent hurry to appoint a permanent Chief Justice.

Conventionally, Acting Chief Justices do not make recommendations for judicial appointments, given their short tenures. However, in some exceptional cases where the names are sent, the Collegium has, in the past, adopted varied approaches.

When Justice Dharmadhikari was acting CJ of Bombay HC from February 20 to March 19 in 2020, he had prepared a list of 22 names for appointment as High Court judges. He was CJ from March 20 until his retirement on April 27, 2020. Despite objections from two consultee judges, the SC Collegium headed by then CJI SA Bobde had sent 18 of the 22 recommendations to the Centre, relying on an affirmative

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE PAGE 7
WOMAN'S MESSAGE TO KIN BEFORE SHE WENT MISSING: 'TREK DONE'

Happening today

PM NARENDRA MODI will begin a two-day visit to Uzbekistan, during which he will hold delegation-level talks with President Shavkat Mirziyoyev.

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INSIDE PAGES 5, 6
KARNATAKA MINISTER B NAGENDRA QUIT AGAIN AMID ROW

BENGAL LIBRARIES TO PULL MAMATA'S BOOKS FROM SHELVES

Sonia's book: Publisher wanted Modi, RSS, China intrusion bits removed, allege Congress leaders

Manoj C G & Asad Rehman
New Delhi, August 28

SENIOR CONGRESS leaders on Friday alleged that Penguin India was pressured to remove from Sonia Gandhi's memoir "portions related to Modi, RSS, and the occupation of Indian territory by China during Modi's rule".

This came a day after *The Indian Express* first reported that Penguin Random House India

would not publish Gandhi's memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, in the country. The report said the publisher wanted certain "editorial changes and deletions" in "a part of the manuscript", but Gandhi refused. The release, scheduled for November 10, was first announced by US-based publisher Alfred A Knopf, an imprint of the Knopf Doubleday Publishing Group that is a division of Penguin

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

FCNR(B) deposits push forex reserves to all-time high of \$729 bn in August

Indicates greater ability of RBI to defend the rupee

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 28

THE RBI's concessional swap window for Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits has helped propel India's foreign exchange reserves to a record high of \$729.33 billion as on

August 21. The FCNR (B) window had been operational since June 8.

The previous all-time high was \$728.49 billion as on February 27, just a day before the US and Israel attacked Iran, kick-starting the West Asia conflict that resulted in sharply higher global energy prices following the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Since almost 85 per cent of India's crude oil needs are met through imports, the conflict

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Quick, learn your lessons before the school is commandeered for the next round of polls.

THE BIG PICTURE

DEAR SISTER, THAT MISSING PIECE OF MY PUZZLE PAGE 12

»SECOND ONLY TO WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP... FORMAT INCREDIBLY TOUGH, HAVE TO PROVE YOURSELF IN CLASSICAL, RAPID AND BLITZ'

In first for India, Praggnanandhaa stages comeback, wins Grand Chess Tour title

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, August 28

R PRAGGNANANDHAA has always had a spark of brilliance. On Friday, the 21-year-old underlined his position as one of the world's finest all-round chess players after becoming the first Indian to win the prestigious Grand Chess Tour title in St Louis, in the United States.

Praggnanandhaa mounted a remarkable comeback to defeat defending champion Fabiano Caruana 15-13 in the final, taking home a hefty \$200,000 prize and securing a guaranteed spot in next year's tour.

The Grand Chess Tour is an elite circuit spanning Classical, Rapid and Blitz events with the world's best players and a total prize pool of \$2 million. After five gruelling tournaments, which include two Classical and three Rapid and Blitz events, the top four players qualify for the GCT finals, a knockout event where the year's best compete for the title.

The tour is a test of endurance, skill and patience, demanding consistent performance across formats.

The GCT title means a lot to the Grandmaster from Chennai, so much so that he called it

second only to the World Championship. "Winning this is certainly second only to the World Championship, given the tradition and the stature of the event. The World Championship is obviously at the top, and the Grand Chess Tour is right up there as well, so winning this is amazing. The format is also incredibly tough. You have to prove yourself not just in Classical but also in Rapid and Blitz. I am happy I was able to do it here," he said.

The title is a shot in the arm for Praggnanandhaa, who missed out on winning the Candidates — a tournament held to determine the challenger to the world champion,



R Praggnanandhaa, 21, defeated Fabiano Caruana 15-13 in the final, in Saint Louis, USA, Friday. LENARNT OOTES/GRAND CHESSTOUR

who is India's D Gukesh. His sister, R Vaishali, also a grand-

master, won the women's candidates and will take on world

champion Ju Wenjun of China.

In the summit clash against Caruana, Praggnanandhaa headed into the final day with a six-point deficit, trailing 3-9 after the Classical leg, having lost the opening game and drawn the second. He turned the tide in the Rapid leg, winning both games to earn eight points and take an 11-9 lead into the final Blitz leg.

In the first Blitz game, Praggnanandhaa had winning chances but blundered in a time scramble. The position turned worse, but even Caruana failed to capitalise, and the game ended in a draw. Caruana, the 2018 World Championship challenger and the

man with the third-highest Elo rating in history (2844), struck back immediately, winning the second Blitz clash to level the score at 12-12.

The Indian wasted no time in regaining his lead, beating Caruana with the white pieces for his third win of the day. Heading into the final game, Praggnanandhaa held a 14-12 lead and needed only a draw to seal the title. He did exactly that, forcing a threefold repetition in a completely winning position to dethrone Caruana.

So what changed from last year to this year? "Mainly, what changed from last year is my Rapid and Blitz game. It's much better now, I think, and that's a

massive improvement in this format," Praggnanandhaa said.

His full-time travelling partner and trainer, Grandmaster Vaibhav Suri, revealed that the conversation around Praggnanandhaa's shorter format games had been ongoing for nearly a year. The pair consciously worked on the shortcomings.

"There was very clear evidence to us that Prag's results were trailing in shorter formats. There was one very clear area where he wasn't able to score as many wins and wasn't able to have as good performances as he was having in Classical events," Suri told *The Indian Express*.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Odisha diktat to colleges: Cut deep fried foods as world faces fuel shortage

Sujit Bisoi
Bhubaneswar, August 28

CUTTING DOWN on cooking oil and avoiding high-oil and deep-fried foods in hostels and canteens are among the instructions the Odisha government has issued to its colleges — a move aimed at reducing the economic burden amid rising global uncertainties.

The higher education department issued a letter to principals of all government and government-aided colleges on Friday, asking them to reduce oil usage in food for students.

Instructions have also been issued to avoid high-oil menu items like puris, vadas and bondas (potato chops) for breakfast, reduce deep-fried food without compromising nutrition, and promote traditional dishes like khakhra, mustard oil and groundnut oil over imported palm, sunflower and soyabean oil.

"The world has been facing repeated supply chain disruptions and crisis since the COVID pandemic. The conflict

in Ukraine also resulted in supply-side issues of food, fertiliser and fuel. The recent conflict in Iran has further exacerbated this food, fuel and fertiliser crisis," the letter read.

This comes months after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal asking Indian households to reduce cooking oil consumption by 10% to improve public health and lower the country's reliance on imports.

The move is also aimed at promoting healthier eating habits among the students and youths," said an official.

No country is immune to the economic impact of the crisis, the letter said, adding that India too is suffering its effects.

The letter also urged college authorities to ask volunteers to assist with the distribution of service Scheme (NSS) and the Youth Red Cross to organise awareness programmes on reducing oil consumption.

Odisha has over 1,000 government colleges with a total student strength of 2.87 lakh.

Cops attacked, tear gas fired: Worker's death sparks violence in Gujarat

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, August 28

A GATHERING of villagers demanding compensation for a factory worker's death in a village in Gujarat's Anand district escalated into violence, stone-pelting, and vandalism on Friday, according to police.

The police started pelting stones heavily and the situation escalated... the police released eight tear gas shells to disperse the mob. Three policemen suffered simple injuries," Vaghela said.

Windows of police vehicles and private vehicles were damaged in the violence. The stand-off ended after the company agreed to pay Rs 30 lakh in compensation, police officials said.

Additional police teams were rushed to Kalamasur from Khambhat and neighbouring areas. Personnel from the Local Crime Branch, Special Operations Group, Parole Purgash Squad and nearby police stations were deployed. Senior officers also reached the village late at night to bring the situation under control.

"Tight security has been arranged in the village as well as at the company, and night patrolling was intensified," Vaghela said.

Kishor photo with top brass of Bihar prompts CS office clarification

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 28

A DAY after a photograph showing Jan Suraj food and Bankipur MLA Prashant Kumar and Bihar's top administrative and police officials triggered questions over the nature of the meeting, the Chief Secretary's office on Friday issued a clarification saying Kishor had met the chief secretary separately in the visitors' room while another meeting involving several senior officers was already underway.

The clarification came a day after Kishor met Chief Secretary Pratyaya Amrit, following which photographs showed him in the presence of senior officials, including the Director General of Police, the Additional Director General of Police (Traffic) and the Patna Commissioner, sparking a debate on senior officials' presence in connection with a first-time MLA's constituency issues.

In a press release Friday, the chief secretary's office said Kishor had sought an appointment with a letter dated August 20 and was given time on August 27. "On 27.08.2026, another meeting was being conducted in the chamber of the Chief Secretary, in which several officers were present," it said.

According to the release, the chief secretary subsequently met Kishor in the "visitors' room" where "certain officers were already present." It also said that meetings with elected representatives have tradi-

tional been held in the visitors' room.

Meanwhile, the official account differs in emphasis from the impression created by the photograph and Kishor's own decision. How can you deny facts and censor facts?"

Gehlot added that he had not "seen or read" the manuscript and hadn't spoken to Gandhi about it.

In a statement, Penguin Random House India admitted it was not the publisher of "Belonging" in India. "Any suggestion that Penguin Random House India decided not to publish this book is entirely unfounded," the author declined editorial changes does not accurately reflect the circumstances.

"As a publisher, it is both our prerogative and our responsibility to fact check and provide authors with recommendations that are in the best interests of our books. This is a normal part of the publishing process. Throughout the relevant discussions, Penguin Random House India's position was that we remained vigilant and keen to publish the book."

"We will not comment further on confidential discussions with the author." Earlier in the day, Gehlot posted on X, "After all, what is the reason or what pressure is there that what is being published across the world cannot be published in India? Sonia Gandhi's life is an example of sacrifice and dedication. The integrity and dignity with

which she has served the country is exemplary." Former Madhya Pradesh CM Kamal Nath also weighed in on the controversy, saying the publisher's decision "is a matter of extreme concern."

"Will the publisher decide what a senior figure like Mrs Gandhi will write and what she will not? The question also arises whether the publisher is saying this on its own or if there is pressure from someone on it? Even before this, the publication of some important books has been stopped under suspicious circumstances. I consider this kind of trend a serious threat to the freedom of expression. The publication of Mrs Gandhi's autobiography should happen soon," he wrote on X.

With Penguin India out, several Indian publishers are now in the fray and HarperCollins is reported to be close to finalising the agreement to publish and distribute the book in India.

Nepal toll climbs to 579

dignity kits, food packets and water purification tablets," External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said in a post on X.

"An 11-member team of doctors, paramedics & rescue team for tunnel rescue operations is also on board. India continues to support Nepal's ongoing relief and rescue efforts," he said.

Earlier in the day, the MEA spokesperson said: "You are aware of the humanitarian assistance rendered by India so far to Nepal in the wake of the recent tragedy. More assistance is in the pipeline. Two aircraft with relief material have left, and a third tranche of relief material is expected to leave this evening."

"As requested by Nepal, we are preparing to send a tunnel rescue team, for which a rescue team is being flown in first to assess the equipment required etc. A medical team is also being sent. In addition, we have also offered Baria bridges along with their associated technical teams so that connectivity can be restored quickly in the affected parts of Nepal. One Baria bridge is already in Nepal and can be deployed for relief efforts," he said.

On Friday, 21 people from Tamil Nadu, who were among those rescued, arrived in New Delhi in the afternoon, and were received by Jaishankar. "Received a group of 21 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu who were rescued from the floods in Nepal. Was moved to hear their experience first hand. Thank the @NepalArmyHQ and Government for this rescue effort. Appreciate @IndianNepal's facilitation of their smooth return to India," Jaishankar said in a post on X.

He said the government was arranging for the return of those who have been rescued so far.

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Stench of death

Milan, continues to hope he will be found alive.

"Someone asked me the project told me that they had seen him rush out of the facility. But there is no other information," Priya said, crying quietly inside the Shree No. 1 Military Training Centre in Trishuli.

This military centre in central Nepal's Nuwakot district has been the site of police and rescue operations as Nepalese security forces scour the valleys and hills for survivors of the catastrophic flash flood that swept through districts along the country's border with Tibet.

Nepalese authorities put the official number dead at 579 on Friday evening. 1,324 people were missing, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA). Among the missing were at least 320 Indian nationals, India's Ministry of External Affairs said.

On Friday, every little helicopter landed at the camp, bringing back survivors from far-flung locations, hoisted in Priya. She would get up, expecting some news of her brother. At this camp and elsewhere on X.

"We had come to give her (the cousin) a peaceful sendoff. We were in the midst of prayers when we heard loud shouts in many voices. We saw us run up to the fourth floor of a school building next door," Chaudhary said.

"As Tharu and he rushed up, they thought others who were present at the funeral would follow them, Chaudhary said.

"But we realised that no one else from our family had come. I lost my wife, my jethani (sister-in-law), and my sasur (father-in-law) all on the same day."

The NDRRMA said all 4,541 people had been rescued so far, including 517 by air on Friday. More than 15,000 security per-

sonnel have been deployed in search and rescue operations, with 6,755 from the Nepal Army alone.

Trishuli's hills were dotted with helicopters as 16 army and private choppers ran continuous rescue and relief operations, making 99 flights throughout the day. Survivors were brought in, and supplies were loaded and unloaded in a matter of minutes. Those who were brought in were checked for injuries, and their vitals were recorded.

After that, they were asked their details, so the army could put them in the list of survivors. And then everyone was given two packets of chocolate biscuits and a bottle of water. "We are mostly seeing crush injuries, but we don't have the equipment to treat serious injuries here. So they are being airlifted to Kathmandu. We only have basic equipment to treat open injuries and wounds," an army doctor at the camp said.

A heavy stench hung over the camp. At a demarcated place near the entrance to the facility, bodies lay wrapped in blue tarpaulin.

Nearly, family members of those missing waited nearables manned by army personnel noting down details.

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With Penguin India out, several Indian publishers are now in the fray and HarperCollins is reported to be close to finalising the agreement to publish and distribute the book in India.

Higher fore reserves are indicative of the RBI having greater ability to defend the rupee. A continuously weakening rupee makes it less attractive for foreign investors to put money in India as their returns take a hit once they convert their investment into their home country currency, such as the US dollar.

With net Foreign Direct Investments (FDI) also weak on account of rising overseas in-

Following the formation of the new barrier lake near the border, Chinese authorities had informed Nepal that around 2 million cubic metres of water had accumulated in the lake, with another 3 million cubic metres potentially entering it over three days, raising concerns about a possible breach.

The lake had formed near the confluence of the Chhochen Khola and Pirepu Tsangpo rivers, which originate in Tibet and flow into Nepal as part of the Bhotokoshi river system.

However, on Friday, Nepal and China resumed rescue operations that had been suspended briefly after risks from the overflowing lake were found to be manageable.

Nearly 1,500 people were airlifted in Nepal, including about 360 from hydel projects in Rasuwa — the border district which was worst hit.

"We had been warned about the water gushing down southward towards Nepal (Rasuwa) but we chose to carry on our rescue and relief mission as we thought the widened river beds could hold additional water flow without causing damage to life and property," a senior Nepal Army officer told The Indian Express.

With AGENCIES

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Javelin missile system

for our defence industries to work together."

In a post on X earlier in the day, Govt announced that India was planning to purchase the "battle-tested Javelin anti-tank system," indicating that both countries were close to signing the deal. "This is a great step forward in the US-India defence relationship and opens the door to co-production possibilities. The engagement between our two nations is at record high levels," he said.

In May, US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth had said that Washington had committed to pursuing "co-production" of Javelin munitions with India. Terminating it as "real, tangible steps" to improve the collective readiness of our forces," he had said that such co-production, with a sophisticated frontline weapon system, deepens the bilateral defence relationship.

Buying the Javelin system has been on India's radar for the past few years.

In November last year, the US had approved a possible foreign military sale consisting of 100 FGM-148 Javelin rounds, one Javelin FGM-148 missile, 25 Javelin Lightweight Command Launch Units and related equipment at an estimated cost of \$45.7 million.

Produced by the Javelin Joint Venture, a partnership between RTX and Lockheed Martin, the Javelin is a single, man-portable, fire-and-forget, medium-range, anti-tank weapon.

In military terms, "fire-and-

forget guidance" means soldiers don't have to remain exposed after the missile is launched, while "man-portable" means that it can be carried by soldiers. That combination makes it particularly lethal.

The Javelin is designed for use against a wide array of targets, including armoured vehicles and fortified positions, and is used by the US Army and the Marines. It also has several international customers -- including Ukraine in its ongoing war with Russia.

Over the past few years, India has become a significant market for the US in terms of military procurements. Last October, India and the US signed the "framework for the US-India major defence partnership," signalling stable ties in the defence sector.

The Javelin system is part of a broader range of purchases -- including 216 M982A1 Excalibur tactical projectiles -- made or initiated in recent times. India is also planning to buy six more Boeing P-8I maritime patrol and anti-submarine warfare aircraft.

Earlier this year, the US approved the possible sale of support services and equipment for Apache helicopters at an estimated cost of \$198.2 million.

Last year, India also signed a Letter of Offer and Acceptance for support for its fleet of MH-60R helicopters for a period of five years. That deal was worth \$799.5 crore. In October 2024, a deal was inked for 31 MQ-9B High Altitude Long Endurance drones.

Before SC Collegium

response from a third consultant judge. However, the Centre returned the names, underlining the reservations by the consultant judges. Justices AM Khanwilkar and DY Chandrachud — both former Bombay High Court judges consulted under procedure — had objected in writing that no chief justice could properly vet 22 candidates, each requiring consultation with the Bar, in so short a tenure, and urged that the list go back to then sitting Chief Justice Dipankar Datta. The third consultant judge, Justice BR Gavai, had disagreed, noting Justice Dharmadhikari had served on the Bombay High Court since 2004 and knew the Bar well. The names were later returned to the Bombay HC, and fresh lists were drawn.

In another instance in 2022, the Centre had raised objections over at least 12 names sent by then Rajasthan HC Chief Justice Akil Kureshi on the grounds that they were made during the fad of his tenure. However, the SC Collegium then, headed by CJI Chandrachud had sought to know if there were specific objections against any name, based on intelligence inputs, but it did

not receive a response. Subsequently, the Centre cleared 8 of the 12 names.

Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta, previously a Rajasthan High Court judge, wrote three letters to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on August 2, 10 and 17 seeking Sharma's replacement by a chief justice from outside the state. The letters, which allege manipulation of case listings, threaten to follow judicial dissent to the CJI, and misuse of administrative powers.

CJI Surya Kant responded on August 26 that allegations against a sitting judge could not be adjudicated through the media and must go through institutional channels. Justice Sharma has headed the Rajasthan High Court in an acting capacity since late September 2025 — a tenure Mehta's letters termed as "unusually long." He was a Rajasthan High Court judge from 2016, moved to Patna in 2022, and after the collegium declined his 2023 request to return on health grounds, was sent instead to the Punjab and Haryana High Court. A 2025 resolution brought him back to Rajasthan.

While he was high at the 2026 Candidates for a potential all-India World Championship final clash against compatriot D G Prasad, the 30-year-old had cold outed in Cyprus in his second Candidates appearance. However, he stepped up after that disappointment, embarking on a magical run that saw him become the first Indian to win the Norway Chess title, beating Magnus Carlsen twice in the same event.

Chess title

Suri said that since the frequency of Rapid and Blitz events was low and 2026 being Candidates year, Praggnanandhaa's natural focus was on the Classical format. However, shorter time formats always remained an area of improvement.

"We knew that this is an area where we have to clearly improve. And we have been making small little steps in this area in terms of deciding opening directions, where Pragm was able to feel a little easier, play a little faster... positions that he'd

be able to put some pressure on his opponents," Suri said.

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FCNR(B) deposits

and the resultant rise in prices has pushed up the country's import bill, exerting further pressure on the rupee. The rupee was already under intense stress due to large foreign fund outflows from domestic financial markets.

According to data released by the RBI on Friday, fore reserves rose by \$12.42 billion in the week ended August 21. Last week, the RBI had said that FCNR(B) deposits of \$65.4 billion had come in as of August 21 since the window opened in June. At the end of May, the total amount of FCNR(B) deposits outstanding was \$34.04 billion.

Under this FCNR (B) scheme, the central bank bears the full exchange rate risk of the NRI bank deposits — money is deposited in the foreign cur-

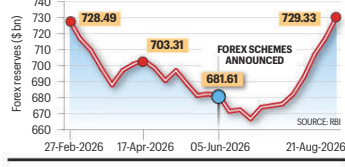
rency and not in rupees. This cushion allowed banks to offer interest rates as high as 7.4 per cent. NRIs have also poured in money into these deposits by taking advantage of the leverage offered by banks, which lets them make returns of as much as 15 per cent, by borrowing money at lower interest rates and then depositing it at the high FCNR(B) deposit rates on offer.

Building fore reserves is an important signal to foreign investors, who have been pulling money out of Indian stock markets in droves: \$19 billion in 2025 and \$24 billion in the first five months of 2026. This has led to the rupee tumbling sharply and nearly touching the 97-poor-dollar mark in mid-May. It is currently down 8.1 per cent from a year ago.

Higher fore reserves are indicative of the RBI having greater ability to defend the rupee. A continuously weakening rupee makes it less attractive for foreign investors to put money in India as their returns take a hit once they convert their investment into their home country currency, such as the US dollar.

With net Foreign Direct Investments (FDI) also weak on account of rising overseas in-

Forex reserves skyrocket on NRI deposits



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GREATER NOIDA WEST: SECURITY AGENCY FILES POLICE COMPLAINT

No regrets, did nothing wrong: Woman seen abusing society guards in viral clip

Yesha Kumar alleges she is being targeted because 'people don't like a bold woman'

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, August 28



Amrapali Centurian Park Terrace Homes in Greater Noida West.

A DAY after a video of a woman allegedly abusing, threatening, and using casteist slurs against security guards at a housing society in Greater Noida West went viral, the woman told *The Indian Express* that she had "no regrets" and was "not sorry" for the alleged incident or her behaviour.

The woman, 45-year-old Yesha Kumar, described the incident as a "bad dream" that she wanted to forget. She said she lived alone in the society and believed that she was being targeted by some people in the complex.

A security supervisor at Amrapali Centurian Park Terrace Homes, where the incident in the video occurred early on Tuesday, has filed a complaint with police.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* at her residence, Kumar

said the incident in the purported video began in the early hours of August 25, after she placed an order for food on the quick commerce app Zepto.

"I had placed an order around 2.30 am. But the security guards did not allow the delivery man inside the society. I had had several drinks at the time, and I did not want to go down, but they insisted that I come to the gate to fetch my order," she said.

In the purported video, which is 4 minutes and 52 seconds long, Kumar is heard shouting at the guards, using expletives in Hindi, and threatening to kill a guard.

"Teri koi aukat nahi hai mere aage (You have no standing in front of me)," she is heard saying. She also purportedly says

she would make the guards clean her shoes, threatens to hit them with her slippers, and appears to aim a kick at one of the guards.

"I accept that I was drunk and angry, but I am not sorry for anything," Kumar told *The Indian Express* on Friday. "I will not apologise because I did not do anything wrong," she said.

Kumar alleged that other residents and the management of the society were targeting her because she was a single woman who lived alone.

My electricity was cut without notice. They don't allow maid to come to my house. I belong to an educated family; you can ask anyone about my background," she said.

"I have never troubled anyone in the society. What I do in-

side my house is my business and no one has the right to interfere or say anything about that," she said.

"They call me crazy, but I am not crazy. I will continue living here. I have invested in this house. A woman has the right to live alone and be herself. But people don't like a bold woman," she said. Kumar claimed she had studied at Lady Shri Ram College for Women, and had worked as a model. She said she is now involved in "events", and has a clothing brand.

In a written complaint to police, the security agency said that the guards stopped the Zepto delivery partner at Gate No. 2 of the society, and sought permission from the resident before letting him in.

According to the complaint, permission was not granted, following which the delivery executive called the resident and informed her that he was waiting at the gate. The woman then came to the gate and began to abuse the guards and attempted to physically assault them.

Amit Sharma, the security supervisor who was present during the incident, told *The Indian Express*: "She kept on abusing and would not listen. When I tried to call the police,

she slapped me. I pushed her away and asked her not to get physical. My phone fell from my hand and the screen cracked."

Sharma alleged the woman had tried to humiliate the guards by calling them "poor" and subjecting them to inappropriate and casteist remarks.

"We may be poor, but at least we are trying to earn a living. Some of us also come from decent backgrounds and own property. We want her to apologise to all the guards," he said.

In his complaint to police, Bhanu Pratap, another security supervisor at the society, said: "We request that the matter be taken seriously, thoroughly investigated, and appropriate legal action be taken against the woman... We also request compensation for the damaged mobile phone belonging to our security supervisor (Amit Sharma)."

The complaint has named nine security guards and supervisors who were allegedly subjected to abusive and inappropriate behaviour by the woman. Police officers said proceedings have been initiated against Kumar under Sections 170, 126 and 135 of the BNS, which deal with preventive actions. No FIR had been registered until late on Friday evening.

Jamia suspends 4 students over protest against spot admission 'irregularities'

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 28

JAMIA MILLIA Islamia (JMI) has suspended four students and barred them from entering the campus following protests over alleged irregularities in the university's 2026-27 spot admission process, with student body National Students' Union of India (NSUI) demanding that the disciplinary action be withdrawn and the administration hold an open dialogue with the protesters.

The disciplinary notices issued by the university identified those suspended as JMI's NSUI office-bearers Dhruv Chauhan, Tabrez Afsar and Ebin Basil. The fourth is a stu-

dent named Mohd. Jasim. The NSUI is the student wing of the Congress.

The protests were triggered by allegations that candidates lower down the waiting lists had been admitted while students with higher ranks were denied seats.

Students have also questioned the decision to conduct offline spot admissions this year, on the basis of which vacant seats were allotted and merit and waiting lists were published.

The university, however, has rejected the allegations, describing them as baseless. It has maintained that its admission process is transparent. The JMI's admission portal shows

that it has issued notices for offline spot registration for the 2026-27 session in July and August. The disciplinary action has particularly focused on the conduct of the protesters and their interaction with JMI officials.

According to the order, the university alleged that protesters blocked access to the billing counter and the girls' common room, put up material on walls and continued the sit-in despite repeated directions from the proctorial department to disperse.

It also alleged that some outsiders and former students participated in the gathering and that politically motivated slogans were raised.

'It's his duty to fight for us...': Evicted slum-dwellers near PM's residence seek Rahul's help for rehabilitation

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 28

THREE DAYS after the Delhi High Court paved the way for evicting people living in three slum clusters near the Prime Minister's residence, Lok Kalyan Marg, a group of women residents of these slums asked Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi to intervene to ensure their "dignified rehabilitation".

In a representation submitted to the Congress party's office on Friday, the slum-dwellers said, "We are not opposed to development or any government initiative. We only want our families to be rehabilitated in a place where we can continue our jobs, our children's education, and live our normal lives with dignity." Around half a dozen women, accompanied by their children, arrived at the Congress office at 24 Akbar Road on Friday morning hoping to meet Rahul. They were unable to meet him, but they said they would keep trying.

"We were told an appointment was needed to meet him. We have requested an appointment, but we have not had a response yet. We will be here again tomorrow," a woman who gave her name as Firdos said.

The government initiated action last October to evict residents from three slum clusters — B R Camp, DID Camp and Masjid Camp — in the neighbourhood of the Prime Min-



Residents of BR Camp, Masjid Camp and DID Colony hold rakhs outside the AICC headquarters to seek Rahul Gandhi's intervention on Friday. (above) Cross painted on houses marked for demolition at Bhai Ram Camp slum cluster near PM's official residence in New Delhi. PRAVEEN KHANNA/TASHI TOBGOVAL

ister's residence, pointing to their location "adjoining military installations", and the need to strengthen defence infrastructure. In court, the government emphasized that "in the current global security situation, which involves increased threats and the risk of conflict or war-like conditions, the presence of unauthorized structures

in this sensitive area creates serious risks to national security, public safety, and the protection of vital installations".

Many residents of the camps have, however, resisted moving to their allotted accommodation in Savda Ghevra in remote Outer Delhi, almost 45 km from where they have lived for the past 70-odd years. While about

400 families have agreed to move, almost 300 families continue to protest.

On August 25, the Delhi High Court ruled that the government's eviction order was not illegal. It constituted a committee headed by a retired district court judge and comprising senior government officials to monitor the rehabilitation of the slum-dwellers, who had complained of the absence of basic amenities in their new area, and to ensure their right to live with dignity. Firdos, however, wondered how fair it was to have a "committee meant for the welfare of slum-dwellers without a single representative from among us". The slum-dwellers are now demanding rehabilitation in situ, and an assurance that they would not be evicted without suitable rehabilitation.

Outside the Congress office, slum-dweller Shaista Khan said, "We are hoping that Rahul Gandhi takes up our issue. He has been elected [to Lok Sabha] by the people, and it is his duty to fight for us. We are also planning to approach the Supreme Court against the verdict of the Delhi HC." A woman who said she had been standing outside the Congress office for three hours from around 9.30 am complained: "When Sheila Dikshit was CM, her doors were always open. Here, we have not even been assured of an appointment [to meet Rahul]."

61-km road along Najafgarh drain to reduce snarls

New Delhi: To reduce traffic congestion, the Delhi government plans to hire a private consultant to construct an approximately 61-kilometre elevated corridor along the Najafgarh drain, connecting Wazirabad to North Delhi, officials said on Friday. The government announced the project in February this year. Now, the PWD plans to hire a consultant to conduct a feasibility study. PTI

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mosquito-free homes. Disease-free lives.

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Prevent Mosquito Breeding

Non-compliance of the said advice will lead to the legal action as per the provisions under relevant sections of the New Delhi Municipal Council (Malaria and other Mosquito borne diseases) bye-laws 2007

Scrub, dry and change water of Cooler weekly.

Water in container for birds must be changed weekly.

Don't let water collect around home. Put petrol in accumulated water.

Keep the lid of water tank closed. Don't let water tank overflow.

Don't let water collect near construction sites.

Don't keep cups, tyres, containers, etc around your home in the open.

NDCM 311
NDCM 311 App

PUBLIC HEALTH DEPARTMENT
NEW DELHI MUNICIPAL COUNCIL
TO BE THE GLOBAL BENCHMARK FOR A CAPITAL CITY

For more information, contact
15333
AN NDCM 311 Helpline Number
on WhatsApp, Telegram, Facebook, Email, and other social media platforms.

Yoga, health camps for elderly: All under one roof in first-of-its-kind Delhi govt initiative

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 28

FROM INDOOR games, stirring discussions, celebrations to mark social events to yoga, health camps and meditation sessions and retreats, the Delhi government is set to come up with centres where elderly citizens living in the Capital can spend their leisurely hours. Under the government's 'Vayo Anand' scheme, officials said, community centres may be used for the first-of-its-kind initiative. Private operators running such centres within the city can avail funding.

Describing the initiative, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday said, "Elderly citizens of Delhi are an invaluable asset to society and ensuring their dignity, health, active lifestyle and social engagement is a priority of the government."

The objective of the scheme, she added, is to provide elderly citizens with a safe space close to their homes where they can spend time with people of their age, participate in recreational



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta with homeless children on Raksha Bandhan. EXPRESS

and health-related activities, and lead an active social life to beat loneliness. "Our government is committed to strengthening such arrangements in the interest of senior citizens so that they can have a better environment for a healthy life," she said.

The recreational centres, according to the government, will provide the elderly citizens with facilities such as indoor games, including carrom and ludo; seating arrangements; fans, coolers; televisions and

computers. An official explained, "Yoga, meditation sessions, monthly medical camps and first-aid kits — the centres are going to create a first-of-its-kind aesthetic recreational centres for elderly persons... The government will provide

financial assistance to organisations running such recreational centres."

Newspapers, magazines and books will also be kept at the centres so that senior citizens can make full use of their leisure time, said officials.

SHIVAJI UNIVERSITY, KOLHAPUR

Notification for Ph.D. Admission 2026-27

Online applications are invited from eligible candidates for admission to Ph.D. Programme. For more details the candidate may visit university website: <https://www.unishivaji.ac.in> under "Ph.D. Admission 2026-27". For detailed information & online application visit the link below: <https://eukapps.unishivaji.ac.in/phd-entrance/#login>

Important Dates:

- Commencement of online application: Available on university website from 29 August, 2026 from 12:00 noon to 19 September, 2026 till 12:00 midnight.
- Detailed Notification is available on university website: <https://www.unishivaji.ac.in/admission/PhD-Admission-2026-2027>
- The entrance exam schedule and the Hall Ticket will be made available in the student's personal login.

Date: 29/08/2026
Place: Kolhapur

Dr. V. N. Shinde
Registrar

BEWARE!

ANY PROMISE OF BIG RETURNS MAY ACTUALLY BE A TRAP!!

REMEMBER

- Any scheme offering double or triple of principal amount in a short period could be a trap
- Anyone paying interest rate higher than RBI guidelines can be a fraud
- Invest only in registered NBFC or banks following RBI guidelines
- Transaction must be made by cheque against proper receipt only (Don't accept hand written rough receipt)

CHECK

- The details of Chit Fund Committee being run, its duration, amounts Involved, number of members from the Registrar of Chit Fund
- The registration of Company/Committee and its financial documents (online) from the Registrar of Companies/Chit Fund and other details from its office
- Whether passbooks with relevant entries are being maintained and margin money is being deposited with Registrar Chit Funds,
- The past performance/criminal record of the company and credibility of its management

Terms & conditions of the offer/MOU carefully before making investment

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Economic Offences Wing, PS Mandir Marg Complex, Mandir Marg, New Delhi-110001
Email ID: dcp-eow-dl@nic.in

(09/09/2026)

Delhi couple held over alleged Pak espionage links; police trace trail to Instagram

Couple 'tasked' with arranging Indian SIM cards for use by ISI-linked men

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 28

THE DELHI Police Special Cell said on Friday that it has arrested a city-based couple for alleged links to a Pakistan-based espionage network.

Police said Sahil (25), a Delhi lawyer's assistant, married Sameera (21), a Noida call centre employee in 2024. Sameera was allegedly in contact with a Pakistani 'agent' on Instagram. She put Sahil in touch with him as well. The 'agent', police claimed, told the duo that there was money to be made.

According to police, the two met each other through a family friend. "They exchanged numbers and kept talking. By 2024, they confessed their love and decided to get married. Then, Sameera allegedly told Sahil about a Pakistani man on Instagram she talks to," an officer said.

"The Pakistani 'agent' introduced Sahil and Sameera to a Pakistani intelligence operative (PIO). Gradually, the PIO convinced them to work for the PIO network," said DCP (Special Cell) Nara Chaitanya.

Police said the couple was allegedly tasked with arranging Indian SIM cards for use by ISI-linked men to engage Indians. "In 2024 and 2025, Sahil and Sameera sent eight Indian SIM cards to Pakistan via Dubai for which they were paid Rs 30,000 by Pakistani handlers. WhatsApp accounts were activated on these numbers in Pakistan... These accounts were used by PIOs to approach Indians to collect sensitive information," said the DCP. Police said with the help of the accounts, PIOs joined Indian WhatsApp groups and approached Indians.

Police also alleged that the couple would receive cantonment areas in India and look for names of Army personnel who

have been court-martialed or were facing cases with the Army Tribunal. They were allegedly also told to "recruit" operatives like them.

The Special Cell claimed it got a tip-off about certain WhatsApp numbers being used from Pakistan to get in touch with people in Delhi. Police said it had received information about the alleged network operating in Delhi-NCR and developed the intelligence before identifying its local members.

They traced the source of the SIM cards, which led them to Sahil. He was arrested from his house in Nizamuddin.

"Based on information provided by Sahil, we arrested his wife. We are tracking other people they might have recruited," said an officer.

Police said Sameera allegedly played a key role in procuring and providing the Indian SIM cards to the Pakistan-based operatives. "Incriminating conversations, including WhatsApp chats between Sahil, Sameera and Pakistani handlers were found during forensic analysis of their mobile phones. Pakistan-based handlers usually coordinate with over-ground workers/sleeper cells through encrypted communication platforms," said the DCP.

Police said they recovered two mobile phones allegedly used in the conspiracy. Forensic examination of the devices allegedly revealed chats and other incriminating conversations between the couple and their Pakistani handlers. Sahil, who completed his BA from Indira Gandhi National Open University, had worked with a lawyer while planning to pursue an LLB but had been unemployed since June 2025. Sameera, a BA graduate who completed her Class 12 in Delhi, was working at a call centre.

Underground reservoirs, injection wells in plan to curb waterlogging in Gurgaon

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 28

•THE BLUEPRINT

GURGAON is looking underground to tackle its perennial waterlogging problem with the state government pitching two technological fixes — high-capacity rainwater injection wells and underground storage reservoirs.

The proposals were a key highlight of Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini's briefing to Prime Minister Narendra Modi during their meeting in Delhi on Thursday after groundwater was initiated earlier this week by the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) and technical experts in a bid to overhaul the city's drainage network. Experts, however, cautioned that the technology will work only if underlying drainage and ecological problems are addressed.

How it will work

The technical framework relies on setting up specialised injection wells with a rapid absorption capacity ranging between 48 and 80 litres per second (LPS), MCG officials said.

An injection well is a sub-surface structure that pushes



filtered rainwater deep into underground rock layers. In highly concretised cities where water cannot soak naturally into the soil, these high-capacity wells are meant to quickly drain flooded roads and bypass dense underground. These will be paired with high-volume underground storage tanks to

capture flash surface runoff immediately from the carriageways before forcing it directly into deeper aquifer layers.

During a review meeting with IIT Gandhinagar professors Udit Bhatia and Vivek Kapadia on Tuesday, MCG commissioner Pradeep Dahiya called for a one-year deadline

to complete the installations. He stated that the cumulative capacity of the tanks and injection wells should be engineered to absorb three times the volume of expected peak rainfall.

Officials said the system will also incorporate a Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) network linked di-

rectly to the Central Ground Water Board to monitor hydrological absorption and groundwater recharge in real time.

A joint team comprising the IIT professors, MCG Additional Commissioner Yash Jaluka, and GMDA Executive Engineer Amit Godara Wednesday carried out ground inspections in Sectors 46 and 47 to begin finalising tank locations and assess sub-surface conditions.

Expert speak

Former municipal engineers and urban experts, however, cautioned that technological blueprints will yield results only if structural execution and baseline ecological factors are addressed simultaneously. "The two plans (of the MCG) will work only if they are properly budgeted for and monitored," said C Bisoini, retired Executive Engineer of the MCG.

"But in my view, what Gurgaon needs are also some old-school solutions — making ponds and reservoirs in parks, and removing encroachments from drains."

Expressing stronger skepticism, city-based sustainability and water recharge expert Sunil Pachar said, "...In my ex-

perience, such wells and tanks are usually poorly designed."

He added, "The root cause nobody understands is increased concretisation and the fact that the natural 78-metre slope from the Aravallis down to Najafgarh is being blocked," Pachar added. "What might work for the Southern Peripheral Road will not work for the Dwarka Expressway; the city is unique," he said.

Govt response

Defending the administration's emergency response, CM Saini noted that Gurgaon received the second-highest rainfall in Haryana this season after Yamunaganj, including a concentrated 230 mm deluge between August 6 and 8.

He said the government has targeted 99 waterlogging points, installing recharge wells that have injected approximately 13,000 metric litres of storm runoff into the ground.

For better long-term regional drainage, Saini said Japanese firm Nippon Koei has been engaged to conduct a topographical survey to channel surplus runoff from Gurgaon's low-lying areas through Nuh into the Yamuna basin.

ROAD CAVED IN ON AUGUST 25

IFFCO Chowk service road repair still on, may take 3-4 days

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 28

REPAIR WORK on a key service road near IFFCO Chowk on the Delhi-Gurgaon Expressway, which caved in earlier this week amid heavy rain, is expected to take another three to four days, officials said on Friday.

The cave-in occurred on Tuesday around 3 pm, and opened up a 10-foot sinkhole on the service road, which connects traffic between Delhi and Jaipur, after an ageing 1,000-mm-diameter master sewer line collapsed beneath the carriageway.

The cave-in had initially affected water supply in several parts of the Millennium City and also hit traffic movement near the arterial stretch to neighbourhoods. While water supply is-

sues were addressed, traffic disruptions still continue.

Officials from the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) said that repair work commenced after the site was dewatered and sewage flow was diverted. The civic agency, officials said, is now working on repairing the sewer line before the stretch can be handed over for reconstruction of the road to the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI).

"Sewage water has been diverted to an alternate manhole and the area was completely dewatered by Wednesday night. The pipeline repair then began," GMDA spokesperson Neha Sharma told *The Indian Express*.

Sharma added, "Across a 100-metre stretch, Machine



The road that caved in near IFFCO Chowk, Friday. ABHIMANYU HAZARIKA

Wound Spiral Lining (MWSL) work for pipeline rehabilitation is being taken up. This will improve the strength, lifespan, and load-bearing capacity of the pipeline. It will take another three-four days to complete the repair."

According to officials,

MWSL is a trenchless rehabilitation method that constructs a new, structural polyvinyl chloride pipe inside the damaged sewer line from existing access points. The technique eliminates the need for extensive open excavation across the critical corridor while reinfor-

ing the underground conduit against future soil erosion and structural failure.

Traffic diversions

Once the GMDA concludes the underground structural repairs, the NHAI will undertake the restoration and resurfacing of the damaged road stretch, said officials.

With the damaged service lane cordoned off, traffic diversions continue near the spot, slowing down the vehicular movement along the Expressway service corridor and towards the flyover.

Traffic police and highway marshals have advised commuters headed towards Manesar and interior sectors to use alternate service lanes and the Signature Tower junction to bypass the bottleneck.

Crucial transit node

The IFFCO Chowk junction is among the most critical transport arteries in Gurgaon and the National Capital Region (NCR). Situated on the Delhi-Gurgaon Expressway (NH-48), it serves as a primary gateway linking South Delhi and the Indira Gandhi International Airport with Gurgaon's industrial belt, Manesar, and Jaipur.

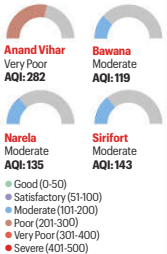
The junction also functions as a major intersection connecting the expressway to Mehrauli-Gurgaon MCO Road, Old Gurgaon, and Sector 29 commercial hubs. Beyond vehicular traffic, IFFCO Chowk is a key station on the Delhi Metro's Yellow Line and serves as an intercity bus boarding point for thousands of daily passengers travelling across Haryana and Rajasthan.

•Skywatch

Forecast: August 29, 2026
No rain; partly cloudy sky
MAX: 35-37
2.5°C above normal
MIN: 25-27
1.4°C below normal

• Sunrise: 5:58 AM (August 30)
• Sunset: 6:46 PM (August 29)
• Moonrise: 7:24 PM (August 29)
• Moonset: 7:48 AM (August 30)

•AQI Tracker



Man electrocuted

New Delhi: A 28-year-old pedestrian was electrocuted in Surajmal Vihar in Delhi after a small section of the road near an electricity pole reportedly caved in, trapping him up to his waist and bringing him into contact with a live wire, police said on Friday. The incident took place on Thursday when Sandeep, a caregiver, was returning home. According to the preliminary enquiry, Sandeep was crossing road 58 when the unpaved road caved in and he fell into a nearly three-foot-deep pit. PIT

DAY 5 OF PROTEST AFTER MSc STUDENT DIED BY SUICIDE

'Significant escalation' during late night protest, says IIT, warns students of disciplinary action

Sophiya Mathew

New Delhi, August 28

IIT DELHI Director Rangan Banerjee on Friday warned of disciplinary action against students as protests over the alleged suicide of 31-year-old MSc student Rishikesh Kumar entered their fifth day, accusing protesters of "significant escalation" and using "unsavoury, humiliating and threatening language" during a late night demonstration on Thursday.

In an official communication to students, Banerjee said that despite several steps taken by the institute following discussions with student representatives, the situation had escalated significantly on Thursday night.

"From 10.30 pm to 12.30 am, a group of protesters extended their agitation into the campus roads that despite several steps taken by the institute following discussions with student representatives, the situation had escalated significantly on Thursday night."

"Such behaviour compromises the safety, privacy, and peace of faculty members and their families, including young children and elderly dependents. The institute will take disciplinary actions against individuals disrupting the peaceful functioning of the campus including residential areas, classes, academic and other activities," he added.

Banerjee said the administration had already acted on several concerns raised by students.

"The External Inquiry committee has started functioning. The Institute support for the



The late night protest on Thursday. SOPHIYA MATHEW

family from the Benevolent fund has been approved and the separate fund with voluntary contributions from faculty, students and staff has been created. The External Ombudsman will be appointed next week," he said.

Sealed gate

The warning came after a tense night on the campus, with hundreds of students marching towards the main gate around midnight. As heavy barricades were dragged across the entrance, students, staff and delivery workers were left stranded outside. A line of security guards formed a human blockade.

The demonstration had begun as a small vigil at the SAC Lawns at dusk. By midnight, it had swelled to hundreds of students. The protesters moved in unison towards the perimeter, their faces deliberately shielded from cameras, holding cardboard placards aloft and chanting — "Justice for Rishikesh."

"Please let us in, we are students. What wrong have we done? This is our home," a student pleaded with security guards, only to be met with silence.

A guard eventually responded: "Let this protest end." According to protesting students *The Indian Express* spoke to, the late night march was held because their academic schedules did not allow them to gather earlier.

'Terrified of repression'

Journalists waited for students to speak on camera, but no one came forward. Then a PhD student shouted: "No video bite. We will release a statement. Please understand."

A scholar, speaking to *The Indian Express* away from the protest, said students were "terrified of administrative retribution." "That's why they were speaking with their backs turned to recording lenses."

"Undergraduates in their final year fear placement de-

barment. PhD scholars risk having their thesis submissions and degrees stalled for years... Everyone enters IIT with high hopes. It is a dream. But after becoming a student here, those dreams are shattered... every single day, we find ourselves in the midst of more stress," the scholar added.

Stricter checks

Once the protest ended, security guards opened a side gate while continuing to restrict entry through the main gate.

"Who's this? Show hard-copy," a guard said, demanding physical identity cards from those waiting to enter.

A PhD student said the stricter checks were unprecedented. "Honestly, they used to just let friends walk right onto campus, but now they are making us carry physical ID cards... which has literally never happened before."

In a separate communication on Friday, the institute's head of security wrote: "All are requested to use the gate cautiously while entering or exiting the premises."

Next move

As the protest entered its fifth day on Friday, students braced for the possibility that the mobilisation could lose momentum during the upcoming holidays.

This is the institute's longest sustained demonstration since April 1990 — the last time a protest of this magnitude shook the campus.

"With Rakhi and the week-end approaching, we knew people would be travelling or

taking time off. We wanted to give this everything we had before the campus emptied out," a student said.

"The protestors who have been here constantly are rather tired. But as long as somebody keeps showing up, and the protest does not die down completely, it has the potential to come back even stronger once these holidays end," an internal message circulated among students said.

Later in the day, a group of students gathered to debate the risks of uncoordinated media interactions.

"It is dangerous to go in front of the media untrained and emotional, as words can easily get twisted," read a message circulated internally, citing an earlier clip in which a student's criticism was misattributed.

"We need a designated team to speak on behalf of the students," it added.

The demands

Kumar allegedly died by suicide last Saturday after jumping from the sixth floor of a building on campus. The Delhi Police has registered an FIR for abetment of suicide against unknown persons.

Students have sought an independent inquiry into the death, the resignation of the Dean, Associate Dean (Student Welfare), Associate Dean (Hostel Management) and Head of the Physics Department, and at least Rs 1 crore in compensation for his family.

They have maintained that Kumar's death was the eighth suicide on campus in the last 30 months.

WEST DELHI MURDER

'Muskan's killer declared intent on Insta live', cops say verifying video

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 28

TWENTY-SIX-YEAR-OLD Imran, who was arrested late Thursday for the murder of 21-year-old content creator Muskan Sharma, allegedly went live on Instagram an hour before he arrived at her West Delhi home, and threatened to murder her, police said.

"He allegedly started by saying that he would die by suicide and then claimed that he would kill Muskan," said an officer. They are trying to verify the authenticity of the purported Instagram live, said police.

Imran was arrested following an exchange of fire with police in Rajouri Garden. Police had found him moving around the area on foot around 11.15 pm. "The police team disclosed its identity and repeatedly asked him to surrender. Instead, he suddenly took out a pistol and opened fire towards a building on campus. The Delhi Police has registered an FIR for abetment of suicide against unknown persons."

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(POCSO) Act case in 2018 involving a minor. The case, registered at Tilak Nagar police station, included charges under IPC sections relating to causing hurt, wrongful restraint, assault on a woman with intent to outrage her modesty, stalking and insulting her modesty, besides Section 8 of the POCSO Act.

"There is also a culpable homicide case against him where he allegedly beat a woman with a cement slab," said an officer. The case was registered in 2021, again at Tilak Nagar police station.

Further, police said Imran's Instagram profile allegedly shows him appearing in a reel post in December 2019 in which a friend was seen flashing a gun. An officer said they would examine whether an Arms Act case can be registered in connection to the post.

Police said Imran and Muskan met at Seven Zone gym, where he worked as a trainer. Over the last two months, Imran allegedly attempted suicide and became addicted to drugs. His behaviour towards Muskan also allegedly became abusive, prompting her to approach police on July 18, though she did not file a formal complaint.

Imran subsequently got admitted to a de-addiction centre but was released on July 30 after he allegedly harmed himself there, police said. On August 20, he allegedly confronted Muskan over his suspicion that she was talking to another man. She was killed on August 26.

Govt eases export SOP to help local defence firms tap global market

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 28

THE GOVERNMENT has introduced reforms aimed at reducing procedural requirements to help the Indian defence industry easy access to the global market. In a statement Friday, the Ministry of Defence said it has simplified the defence export standard operating procedure (SOP) and the open general export licence (OGEL) framework.

These reforms will facilitate quicker access to international markets, allowing Indian defence companies to respond more effectively to global business opportunities, while ensuring that national security considerations are fully protected.

Under the amended SOP, stakeholder consultation has been dispensed with for exports of non-lethal defence items to most destinations, while appropriate safeguards have been retained for sensitive countries.

Moreover, stakeholder consultation has been dispensed for exports of all items for international tenders and exhibitions, enabling Indian companies to showcase their products and pursue international opportunities more expeditiously.

According to the ministry, the open general export licence is a standing one-time export authorisation that enables eligible exporters to self-generate export authorisations for

multiple consignments of specified defence items, without seeking a separate authorisation for each consignment. It stated the three existing export licence SOPs covering major platforms and equipment, parts and components, and intra-company transfer of technology have been consolidated into unified SOP, providing exporters with a common and simpler framework.

Additionally, OGEL validity has been increased from two to three years, reducing frequency of renewals and associated compliance requirements, and OGEL coverage has been expanded from 40 to all countries, except negative/sensitive nations and those facing UN Security Council sanctions or arms embargoes. The range of items covered under OGEL has been expanded, providing greater flexibility to eligible exporters.

"The revised framework also permits civil-end-use exports of specified parts and components of small-calibre arms and protective equipment, further broadening legitimate international business opportunities," the statement noted.

According to the statement, the reforms move India's defence export regime towards a more comprehensive and facilitation-based system, reducing routine procedural requirements while retaining safeguards for sensitive items, technologies and destinations.

Weeks after reinduction, Karnataka minister B Nagendra quits Cabinet

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 28

BAREILY 25 days after he was inducted into the DK Shivakumar Cabinet for a second time, the Minister for Planning and Statistics, B Nagendra, announced his resignation here on Friday. This comes in the wake of the BJP's sustained campaign for his exit over a CBI chargesheet in a case of alleged corruption.

Nagendra, whose resignation had been on the cards since the BJP disrupted a two-week Monsoon Session and forced its early adjournment on August 24, said at a press conference here that he was quitting on his own to "prevent embarrassment for the party and its leaders".

"I will be submitting my resignation to the Chief Minister. The BJP has painted me guilty because I belong to a backward tribal community and have approached the Governor for my prosecution. I would not like to cause embarrassment to my party and leaders and have decided to submit my resignation on my own," Nagendra said.

The exit of the Ballari Rural MLA comes even as Governor Thawarchand Gehlot accorded sanction for the prosecution of the minister by the CBI in connection with a case of alleged misappropriation of funds of the state Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation when Nagendra was the ST Welfare min-

ister in 2023-24.

"I am resigning out of respect for the constitutional office of the Governor, which has granted sanction for my prosecution. The sanction has been granted selectively even as the sanction for prosecution of leaders of the Opposition has not been granted for over three years in some cases," said the Congress leader.

Nagendra also suggested that he is considering resigning as the Ballari Rural MLA. "I will also soon resign as the MLA and I challenge all the people who sought my exit to come to the court of the people and defeat me in an election," he said.

The sanction accorded for the prosecution of the Congress MLA by the Governor and a BJP proposal to embark on a 170-km padayatra from September 1 in the backward Raichur and Ballari districts — where the Congress enjoys good support — to demand Nagendra's resignation seen as forcing the Congress party's hand in seeking his exit from the Cabinet.

Reacting to the resignation, Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar said the minister had submitted the resignation and a final decision would be made Saturday.

"He has submitted resignation to prevent embarrassment to the party. I will discuss with the senior leaders and party high command and take a decision (to accept or reject)," Shivakumar said. "BJP is levelling false



Karnataka Minister B Nagendra breaks down as he announces his resignation from the state Cabinet in Bengaluru, Friday.

allegations. Nagendra has won twice against BJP senior leaders. He has submitted resignation twice over same issue. The government has not succumbed to opposition pressure," he added.

Leader of Opposition in the Karnataka Assembly, R Ashoka, told reporters in New Delhi that the resignation marked the first setback for the Shivakumar government. "Our struggle, and the struggle of our workers, resulted in this government losing its first wicket in the form of Nagendra's resignation," Ashoka said, adding, "This government headed by Shivakumar has not even completed three months. Nagendra has not even completed 25 or 26 days as a minister, and al-

ready one wicket has fallen. Going forward, there will only be more wickets falling."

Ashoka said he would consult party leaders and state president B Y Vijayendra on the proposed padayatra. He said the BJP would continue its agitation on issues concerning people, farmers and the poor. Nagendra had previously resigned as the ST Welfare minister in the Cabinet of former CM Siddaramaiah in 2024 after the diversion of Rs 94.73 crore of funds from an ST Development Corporation bank to multiple private accounts.

Although a Karnataka Police Special Investigation Team (SIT) did not find links between Nagendra and the fund diversion scam, the CBI recently filed a corruption chargesheet against the Congress leader for being an alleged beneficiary of contracts worth Rs 13.95 crore given through the ST Development Corporation during his tenure.

The Congress inducted Nagendra into the Shivakumar Cabinet on August 3 and defied BJP demands for his resignation by stating that there was no evidence to link the Ballari leader to the alleged corruption.

"Various investigative agencies, including the CBI, have conducted investigations. So far, no documents have been received that directly show Nagendra to be guilty. In this context, he said, it would not be appropriate to disrupt the proceedings of

the House without holding a debate," Shivakumar said on August 24 in the state legislature.

The indications of Nagendra's exit became apparent after Shivakumar spoke to the minister on August 26 and obtained an assurance that Nagendra would resign on his own, it is learnt. Shivakumar carried the assurance to New Delhi on August 27, where he met the Congress leadership and said that "Nagendra is willing to make any sacrifice for the party".

The resignation of Nagendra, who is from the Valmiki Nayak tribal community, is likely to allow the Congress to make changes in the state Cabinet and induct two to three new ministers, including a vacant post for women. Annappa Tukaram, a first-time woman MLA who is also from Ballari and also belongs to the Valmiki Nayak community, is seen as a likely replacement for Nagendra.

The exit of Nagendra could also allow the entry of Siddaramaiah's candidate and Byadagi MLA Basavaraj Shivapadgar, or senior Bengaluru MLA M Krishnappa, who has been angry over his exclusion. Nagendra was inducted into Siddaramaiah-led Cabinet for the first time in May 2023, given that he is a four-time MLA from Ballari. In the 2023 polls, he defeated BJP's foremost Valmiki Nayak leader and former minister B Sreeramulu. — WITH PTI INPUTS

'Time to end threat culture at JU':
Suvendu at Vande Mataram event

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, August 28

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said Friday it is time to end the "threat culture" at Jadavpur University, and once again vowed to restore nationalism inside and outside the campus.

The CM's remarks came while addressing a programme outside JU campus where 'Vande Mataram' was sung by 10,000 people. The CM had called for the event after ABVP-SFI clashes at JU last week, in what he said was a bid to "strengthen the spirit of nationalism" at the university. "There is a threat culture at Jadavpur University, and it is time to end it," Adhikari said.

He accused previous TMC and Left governments of undermining "nationalism" and the state's traditions. He alleged JU had long been influenced by communists who, according to him, had distanced students from Independence Day, Republic Day, Indian and Bengali traditions and the country's cultural heritage. "In their homes, you would never find pictures of Tagore, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay or Ishwar Chandra Vidyaasagar," he claimed.

The CM also criticised the TMC, alleging the party had reached an understanding with sections of students for electoral gains. He said, "There was only one dividend. During polls they would say, 'No vote to BJP, no vote to Narendra Modi'. Mamata who lost to me twice, would reap the benefit. That is why this force was kept alive here."

Adhikari slammed university students for allegedly taking out protest marches against Operation Sindoor. He said before raising slogans for Kashmir or Palestine's freedom, students should seek the freedom of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.

"Are you raising slogans like 'Kashmir magaye azaad' and 'Free Palestine'? Why? Before talking about Palestine, write 'Free PK'. Remember, we will definitely take back Pakistan-occupied Kashmir," Adhikari said.

Centre appoints key officials in NTA amid NEET paper leak row

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 28

THE CENTRE on Friday appointed officials to key posts in National Testing Agency (NTA), which has been facing flak for its role in the alleged NEET paper leak and other concerns.

Anshuman Sharma, a 2005-batch Indian Revenue Service (Income Tax) officer, was appointed as Joint Secretary in the NTA for a tenure of five years, an order issued by the Personnel Ministry said.

Sathya S. Ravi Kumar Singh and Prasanna Venkatesh V have been appointed as directors in the examination body. Sathya is an IRS (Income Tax) officer, Singh belongs to the Indian Police Service and Prasanna is an Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer.

Amrit Samdaria, a 2016-batch Indian Revenue Service (Customs and Indirect Taxes) officer, has been selected for appointment as joint director in the NTA, another order issued on August 27 by the Personnel Ministry said.

The move assumes significance as the Centre has recently announced a comprehensive overhaul of the examination system at the NTA, including implementing a four-tier paper-checking process, removing 600 experts, and onboarding domain specialists, among other changes. The move followed a row over the NEET paper leak, that led to resignation of Dhanendra Pradhan as the Education Minister last month.



Rakhi with the PM

Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacts with school students during the Raksha Bandhan celebrations, in New Delhi on Friday.

'Our position no different from the BJP's': Ruhullah's swipe at NC's statehood stance

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, August 28

AFTER MONTHS of an ongoing rift with the National Conference, the party's Srinagar MP Aga Ruhullah Mehdi on Friday challenged the party leadership, stating that in asking for statehood, its position now "is no different from that of the BJP's."

In his first direct communication to the party president, Ruhullah wrote to Dr Farooq Abdullah and released the letter via social media. On August 25, speaking to reporters in Srinagar, Abdullah had said, "How long will you be a slave? You have to stand on your feet sometimes.

When will you stand?"

Referring to this statement, Ruhullah said, "I must confess, those words resonated deeply with me. They captured a frustration many of us in Jammu-Kashmir feel: that even while asking for what is rightfully ours, we are expected to assume a posture of supplication before the BJP. May I then, with all the humility I can muster, ask: why should you object when I ask the very same questions?"

Taking a swipe at the party's repeated assertions on demanding restoration of statehood from the Centre, the MP also stated by accepting statehood as the "outer limit of our political

horizon", they are "legitimising and normalising the constitutional assault of August 2019, while signalling the BJP's political settlement for J&K is acceptable to us." "In doing so, he added: "We also risk surrendering the constitutional protections that are indispensable to our people, given our unique geo-political reality, culture, traditions, and fragile environment."

Ruhullah has criticised his party for its stance on statehood and Article 370 for over a year. In December 2024, he participated in a protest outside CM Omar Abdullah's residence alongside students demanding rationalisation of reservation in J&K.

not reacted to Oram's statement. A popular tribal face in the country, Oram is a six-time MP from Sundargarh who first won Lok Sabha polls in 1998. In his second term as an MP in 1999, Oram was assigned to head the tribal affairs ministry in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government. He was re-elected into the cabinet in 2014, when Narendra Modi became prime minister, and once again in 2024.

Born into a poor tribal family in Kendudih village in Odisha's Sundargarh district, Oram completed his diploma in electrical engineering in 1982 and was employed at Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited before entering politics. Oram was elected to the state assembly in 1989 before being elected as an MP.

Since he began contesting the general election in Odisha, he has lost the Sundargarh seat only once — in 2009 to former Odisha chief minister and Congress candidate Hemananda Biswal.

attempting to destabilise him. "I am satisfied with whatever position, responsibility and respect the party has accorded me over the years but I condemn such attempts," he added.

The senior leader, who previously announced he would not contest any more direct elections, also reversed that stance, saying he would contest again. "I challenge those working against me to face me politically. You will see what will be their condition," said the Union minister, adding he would "finish" those trying to "destabilise him".

Oram's statement came a day after Rourkela police arrested Prakash Paswan, his representative, who had booked rooms at Circuit House for seven persons who were recently arrested with arms and ammunition by the police.

Claiming that he had given his blood and sweat for the party, Oram alleged leaders who joined the BJP from other parties were



Union Tribal Affairs Minister Jai Oram

"cut off their hands and throw them away".

Oram said one of the key figures of the Odisha BJP party since its inception in the state, said he had conveyed the matter to BJP's general secretary (organisation) Manas Mohanty. "If the matter is not resolved at the state level and justice is not done, I will also flag it before the central leadership," he said.

Without taking names, the Union minister warned that if anyone tried to damage his reputation, he had the strength to



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Condolence Call

SAMA JWADI PARTY Lok Sabha member Iqra Choudhary was in Shamli on Friday to pay condolences and show solidarity with the family of singer Ankit Balian, who was shot dead on Wednesday. Choudhary called Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav and then passed on the phone to Balian's father. Choudhary is keen to have promised support and assistance to the bereaved family. Incidentally, all this transpired in the presence of Aam Aadmi Party Rajya Sabha member Sanjay Singh, who is seated next to Balian's father. Choudhary is also planning a press conference soon on the singer's murder, sources said.

Capital Huddle

THE BJP is likely to hold a daylong huddle on Saturday to discuss the contours of its planned outreach to the Gen Z and youth community. The meeting, to be chaired by BJP president Nitin Nambani at the BJP headquarters in the capital, is expected to be attended by a slew of young leaders, comprising MPs and party leaders from across the country.

India, Kuwait hold inaugural key dialogue in Delhi to bolster defence ties

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 28

INDIA AND Kuwait on Friday held a key dialogue on Friday held a key dialogue agreed to bolster bilateral defence cooperation across a wide range of areas, including training, military exercises, industry, and research and development. The inaugural meeting of the India-Kuwait Joint Defence Committee was held in New Delhi.

The first meeting of the Joint Defence Committee marked an important step towards operationalising the objectives outlined in the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Defence Cooperation between the two countries, signed during the visit of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Kuwait in December 2024, the defence ministry said in a statement.

● THE DISPUTE UNITES PUNJABIS IN A HEARTBEAT. IN A SONG RELEASED AFTER HIS DEATH, RAPPER SIDHU MOOSEWALA SANG: "PAANI CHHADO, TIBKA NAHIN DINDE (FORGET ABOUT WATER, WE WON'T GIVE A DROP)"

The SYL canal saga: Why Punjab won't yield, and Haryana cannot let go



NORTHERN LIGHTS

BY MANRAJ GREWAL SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON POLITICS AND POWER SHIFTS IN PUNJAB, HARYANA AND HIMACHAL PRADESH

"ONCE THE heart opens, the door also opens." Chief Justice of India Surya Kant reportedly made this remark recently while hearing the ongoing 30-year-old Satluj-Yamuna Link (SYL) canal case, after Attorney General R Venkataramani told the three-member Bench that Punjab and Haryana "speak in a joint voice... They have

West Bengal libraries to pull Mamata's books from shelves

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 28

ONCE MANDATORY in state-run libraries, books written by former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee are set to be pulled from shelves. Gouri Shankar Ghosh, the Minister for Mass Education Extension and Library Services, told *The Indian Express* that "unnecessary books by Mamata Banerjee, such as *Epang-Opong*, *Jhapan*, will no longer remain in libraries".

"A sort of dictatorship was there under the previous government. Any books by the former chief minister that do not contribute to students' learning will be removed from library shelves," Ghosh said, adding that books that contribute to knowledge, intellectual development and "nationalist thought" would be prioritised.

"We will also modernise libraries and provide adequate staff. We are also thinking of setting up free libraries across the state," Ghosh said. When the Trinamool Congress government was in power, school and public libraries were supposed to display books authored by Banerjee.

In 2025, the government distributed a comprehensive list of approved literature to more than 2,000 government-aided schools, with a Rs 1 lakh grant to buy the books. The education department had selected 19 specific titles authored by Banerjee, including *Palabi*, *Ma*, *Upaladhi*, *Chalo Jai*, *Patheer Sathi*, *Crocodile Island*, and her poetry collection, *Kabita Bitan*.



TMC chief Mamata Banerjee addresses supporters during the Foundation Day rally of the party's youth wing in Kolkata on Friday. Abhishek was among the senior party leaders present. PARTHA PAUL

20 rebel TMC MPs will be disqualified: Mamata

Banerjee has written more than 100 books, many of which were unveiled at the International Kolkata Book Fair. The latest development follows a controversy over Ghosh's claim that 19 books Banerjee borrowed from the state assembly library have yet to be returned. The books include 18 volumes of *Rabindra Rachanabali* (the collected works of Rabindranath Tagore) and a copy of the anthology, *Sanchayita*. The minister said that library rules apply equally to all citizens and warned of potential "legal action" if the books are not officially deposited. Banerjee said the books are not at her personal residence but in the Chief Minister's official chamber at the Assembly.

Kolkata: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee asserted on Friday that "it was just a matter of time" before the 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs who defected to the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCP) face official disqualification. Her statement comes days after the Lok Sabha Secretariat issued notices to the rebel MPs seeking their response within seven days on petitions filed by TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee seeking their disqualification under the anti-defection law. Addressing a rally in Kolkata to mark the foundation day of the Trinamool Chhatra Parishad (TMCP), the student wing of the TMC, the former CM said, "We already got a signal. Now it is just a matter of time. In the meantime, you (rebel MPs) eat milk-ice and fish for some days." The Mamata-led party as well as the rebel TMC faction had applied to hold a rally of TMCP's foundation day at Mayo Road. The Calcutta High Court, however, directed the Mamata faction to hold its rally at Cathedral Road and the rebel faction at Rani Rashmoni Road. ENS

Abhishek, Derek booked over 'illegal signboard'

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 28

THE KOLKATA police have booked Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction leaders Abhishek Banerjee and Derek O'Brien and others in connection with Thursday's ruckus during the dismantling of an alleged illegal signboard erected at the party office on Camac Street in Central Kolkata.

"Three cases have been filed, and 13 people have been arrested. Investigation is on," Kunal Agarwal, Additional Commissioner, Kolkata police, said on Friday.

According to the police, the TMC leaders and workers have been booked for rioting, unlawful assembly, carrying deadly weapons, voluntarily causing hurt to a public servant on duty, using force against women, and criminal intimidation.

Comotion ensued at Banerjee's Camac Street office in Kolkata when a team of municipal corporation officials, accompanied by a huge contingent of police personnel, removed the party's signboard atop the office building. The police said they sent a team to accompany the Kolkata Municipal Corporation officials to the spot on Thursday following a request for police assistance to execute the order to remove the unauthorised signboard atop the TMC party office on Camac Street.

'Sonia Gandhi-led NAC was a Dimagi Naxal takeover': RSS-linked weekly

Deepthim Tivary
New Delhi, August 28

A DAY after Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged the nation to identify and isolate "Dimagi Naxals" in his Independence Day speech, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju had clarified that the remark was not directed at Opposition leaders but at those who reject the Constitution. The RSS-linked weekly *Organiser*, however, has now expanded the definition to include the UPA-era National Advisory Council (NAC).

In its latest issue, the weekly has sought to link a series of recent public protests to what it has labelled a larger campaign targeting Hinduism.

"This precisely is the reason why agitations ranging from farmers to students eventually turn against Hindu civilizational identity," *Organiser* editor Prafulla Ketkar wrote in an editorial published on August 24.

The editorial alleged that "Dimagi Naxals" (loosely translated as people with a Maoist mentality) operate secretly in cities and create multiple "frontal organisations" in the name of students, women, labourers, farmers, Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and "so-called minorities".

"The National Advisory Council of the Sonia Gandhi-led UPA Government was a classic takeover of the Dimagi Naxals of governance. Their idea of penetrating the bureaucracy, policy machinery, legal system, academia, media, and NGOs is part of the 'revolutionary strategy'," Ketkar wrote.

The NAC was set up in 2004 to advise the UPA government on policy matters and its recommendations helped shape, among other things, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, the Right to In-

This precisely is the reason why agitations ranging from farmers to students eventually turn against Hindu civilizational identity"

PRAFULLA KETKAR, EDITOR, *ORGANISER*, WROTE IN AN EDITORIAL PUBLISHED ON AUG 24

formation Act, the National e-Health Mission, the Mid-Day Meal Scheme, the Jawahar Nehrui Urban Renewal Mission and the National Rehabilitation Policy. The Council, led by Gandhi, consisted of academics, civil society activists, and technical experts. Gandhi served as the NAC chairperson from 2004 till May 2006, when she resigned from both the Council and the Lok Sabha amid the issue-of-profit controversy. She resumed the leadership of the reconstituted NAC in 2010.

Ketkar argued that "Dimagi Naxals" do not carry guns but operate through labels such as "eminent historians or intellectuals, award-winning literary figures, legal luminaries, human rights activists, independent journalists, celebrity actors or actresses, and environmentalists".

"Civil society is their tool of resistance to Constitutional Democracy... Subversion of democracy through democratic means is their classic style," said the editorial. According to the editorial, "Dimagi Naxals" are highly educated and may raise genuine issues, but it alleged that they use their intellect for "destructive purposes". It also alleged that big technology companies support their activities.

SIR shocker: 3,400 voter forms found at photocopy shop, 5 BLOs suspended

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 28

A CONTROVERSY erupted in Kharghar of Navi Mumbai after bundles of enumeration forms from the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in the Panel were found at a photocopy shop. The administration found as many as 3,400 SIR forms lying at the photocopy shop, prompting the authorities to register a case.

Raigad District Collector Kishan Jawale suspended five Booth Level Officers (BLOs), pending disciplinary proceedings, and said on Friday that a case has been registered against one Suraj Patil under the Representation of the People Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

After the discovery of the SIR forms, Balesh Bhokane, an officer-bearer of the Shiv Sena (UBT), demanded to know how these forms filled out by general voters reached private individuals. He alleged that officers-bearers of the BJP youth wing were connected to this incident. Jawale rushed to the office of Sub-Divisional Officer Pawan Chandak on Friday.

The matter came to light after complainants stated that photocopying of SIR applications was underway at a xerox center in Sector 19, Kharghar, and that a youth named Suraj Patil was in unauthorised possession of these forms.

The inspection revealed that the SIR forms found at the shop belonged to 11 polling stations. Majority of these applications were from five polling stations, while only single copies were from six stations.

In Baba Bakala, a Punjab election battle in miniature

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Amritsar, August 28

IT IS a small, historic town and a major centre of pilgrimage for Sikhs that turns into a major political battleground annually during the Rakhar Punia festival. On Friday, Baba Bakala in Amritsar district — where Guru Tegh Bahadur was revealed to be the ninth Sikh Guru — transformed into the site of the tensions and contradictions that animate Punjab politics today, as all the major parties held parallel conferences months before the Assembly elections next year.

Congress

In the faction-ridden state Congress, state Congress president Amrinder Singh Brar was conspicuous by his absence. For weeks, Warring and former CM Sukhinder Singh Randhawa appeared to launch a veiled attack at the absent Warring, saying Punjab requires leaders of courage and accountability rather than those who barter political interests for personal gains.

Aam Aadmi Party

At the ruling party's gathering, Bhagwant Singh Mann targeted political rivals and highlighted his administration's developmental and welfare initiatives. The CM announced



Union Agriculture Minister Shri Singh Chouhan with Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini and other leaders. RANA SIBRANJIT SINGH

the authority of the Sri Akal Takht Sahib, the highest seat of authority in Sikhism. While Channi targeted Mann, his ally and former Deputy CM Sukhinder Singh Randhawa appeared to launch a veiled attack at the absent Warring, saying Punjab requires leaders of courage and accountability rather than those who barter political interests for personal gains.

The CM also accused the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) of committing "unpardonable historical sins", referencing the incidents of sacrilege that occurred during the SAD-BJP government's tenure. The Akali leadership had "compromised its political dignity" by "begging for an alliance" with the BJP,

the immediate disbursement of Rs 181 crore in three-month instalments directly into the bank accounts of 5.3 lakh additional women beneficiaries under the flagship Mawad-Dheeyan Sakti Yojna, reinforcing the government's commitment to women's empowerment and financial inclusion.

The CM also accused the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) of committing "unpardonable historical sins", referencing the incidents of sacrilege that occurred during the SAD-BJP government's tenure. The Akali leadership had "compromised its political dignity" by "begging for an alliance" with the BJP,

which was responsible for the deaths of farmers during the protests against the now-repealed farm laws, he alleged. The BJP, he added, would never find a foothold in Punjab.

Mann also dismissed the Congress, saying it lacks a coherent vision for the state's progress and was solely driven by power.

BJP

The BJP's conference was the first-ever held on its own in Baba Bakala. Heavyweight party leaders from the Centre and the state addressed the event. Union Agriculture Minister Shri Singh Chouhan, who spearheaded the party's rally, assured the farming community that national trade pacts, whether with the US, the UK, or European nations, would safeguard the country's agricultural interests.

Taking digs at AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann, Chouhan challenged them to account for their governance failures, specifically questioning why the AAP government opted out of the PM Fasal Bima Yojna, a central welfare scheme that, he said, could have shielded Punjab's farmers from devastating crop losses during recent floods.

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini — whom the

party has deployed in Punjab for the past several months with an eye on the elections — urged voters to evaluate the Mann government based on what it had delivered. The BJP's conference was attended by senior leaders such as national vice-president Manpreet Singh Badal, former Union Minister Ravneet Singh Bittu, national general secretary Tarun Chugh, and former state BJP president Sunil Jakhar.

Shiromani Akali Dal

SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal, whose hold over the Panthic vote is under pressure, launched an offensive against "anti-Panth stooges of agencies". He accused them of attempting to weaken his party and "drag Punjab back into the turbulent and dark era of the 1980s".

Badal's chief aim was the Shiromani Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) breakaway group that is trying to erode the Badals' Panthic vote bank. Badal targeted jailed MP Amrinder Singh, whose father is one of the members accused of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, saying he was trying to emulate Khalistan militant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale.

Badal also accused the CM and his family of corruption, claiming he had "concrete evidence" against Mann.

Punjab to share waters with it. "We are one. I appeal to our common brother to share water with us." This year, Haryana earmarked Rs 100 crore for the canal.

But there is another piece of this story that deserves attention.

The Ravi-Beas Waters Tribunal was set up in 1986 to resolve water claims. Commonly known as the Eradi Tribunal after its first chairman, Justice V Balakrishna Eradi, it was in Punjab this summer for fresh field inspections. The present three-member tribunal, headed by retired Supreme Court judge Justice Vineet Saran, with Justices P Naveen Rao and Sumant Shyam as members, visited sites to examine river inflows, canal outflows, hydraulic structures, and the shortage of canal water in Punjab's border districts.

Interacting with the tribu-

nal, CM Bhagwant Mann and officials reiterated that Punjab faces severe groundwater depletion and an acute shortage of canal water. The state, they said, had no surplus water for Haryana or Rajasthan. They also maintained that only Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, and Jammu and Kashmir fall within the actual basin area of the Ravi and the Beas.

At one point, the tribunal, whose task is to establish whether the water assumed to be available under the 1981 agreement still exists, but whatever its findings, the tribunal cannot build the canal or make Punjab accept a settlement its people consider damaging. For that, the two states will have to thrash out a solution. With compassion. Whether it is possible in the charged poll season is anyone's guess.

(MANRAJ GREWAL, SHARMA IS NATIONAL EDITOR, NORTH, THE INDIAN EXPRESS)



Family members console one another; locals take refuge on a hillside after a fresh warning of a possible surge in the water level was sounded; and a child at the army's rescue and relief command centre at Trishuli in Navakot district, Nepal, on Friday. TASHI TOBOYAL



RELATIVES OF THOSE WHO WENT MISSING IN NEPAL CLING TO LAST WORDS EXCHANGED BEFORE FLASH FLOODS STRUCK

Phones fall silent, long wait for families

'Just finished the trek': Woman's message to kin before she went missing

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 28

THE LAST MESSAGES Swati Bagrecha sent home were meant to reassure her family in Madhya Pradesh.

The 50-year-old told that the immigration process was underway and that the group was about to reach Nepal. The journey back had been tiring, the internet connection was poor, and she was going to sleep, she said. They were expected to reach Nepal late that night. She had an early flight to catch the next morning. She would text then.

"She was going to sleep and wouldn't be able to talk because of connectivity issues along the route, and they were scheduled to reach Nepal late at night. She messaged that she would only be able to text the next day, as she had an early flight out. That was the last message," Swati's sister Dr Smita Bagrecha said.



50-year-old Swati Bagrecha was at the immigration office, her family said, when the building was swept away. She was supposed to catch return flight on Aug 26

Swati is one of 320 Indians still unaccounted for after flash floods swept Tibet and Nepal. The death toll from the flash floods in Nepal and Tibet has climbed to 579, while 1924 remain missing. Around 3,742 people have been rescued so far. During a media briefing, the Ministry of External Affairs confirmed that 400 Indians on the Chinese side are safe. In addition to the 320 Indians still missing, more than 100 people of Indian origin also remain unaccounted for. Swati is the younger daughter of Dr K C Bagrecha, a retired Chief Medical and Health Officer of Vidisha, and grew up in the Madhya Pradesh town before moving abroad. She has been living in Toronto, Canada, with her husband and had returned

to India this month before setting out for the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. An engineer by profession, she had come to India with the intention of undertaking the pilgrimage and left her daughter with relatives in Vidisha while she travelled with the 77-member group.

For most of the trip, Swati kept in touch with her family from different points along the route. Direct calls were difficult because of the terrain and connectivity, so WhatsApp messages became the thread connecting her to home.

Swati had reached Kathmandu on August 14 and spent two days there. They travelled through several stops before reaching Mansarovar, where they spent two days. On the return journey, the group stopped at several locations. She was to catch a flight on August 26, after her trek ended.

"Earlier that morning, she dropped a message that the immigration process was underway and they were about to reach Nepal, and there has been no contact since then," her father, Dr K C Bagrecha, said.

Then came the news that turned an ordinary delay in communication into a family's worst fear.

According to Bagrecha, the pilgrims were inside an immigration hall when the disaster struck. The family has contacted the Indian, Nepali and Canadian embassies and sought help through government and administrative channels. On Friday, Vidisha BJP MLA Mukesh Tandon visited the family and assured them that efforts were being made through the relevant agencies to trace Swati.

"We are trying to contact the Nepal embassy for any word of her...we are trying our best to help the family out and track their daughter," Vidisha MLA Tandon said.

Throughout the journey, Swati's main means of contacting her family was through text messages. One of those was a perfectly ordinary message, yet it is one the family is now holding on to. To that text, sent to her father from Bittu — Swati's nickname at home — was sent at 7:43 am.

"Just finished the trek," it said. For Devki Adhikari, the chilling call was brief and came at 9:30 am on Thursday. In it, she could hear her family in Bhopal telling them about the flash floods in Nepal and that they were seeking higher ground.

"They tried taking shelter at a house... They said, 'The house is half submerged. We will not survive now. Take care of our children,' Devki recalls her family saying.

Brothers Krishna-Radhika Khanal and Ramchandra-Bhavati Khanal Adhikari and their families were part of a group of 29 people who had gone to Gosainkund pilgrimages in Nepal for Sawan Purnima. They were an extended family spread across neighbouring households and localities.

None of the 29 in that group has since been traceable. "The line remained connected, but the voices stopped," he says.



A woman looks on as she waits with others at the army's rescue and relief command centre at Trishuli in Nepal's Navakot district on Friday. TASHI TOBOYAL

No word from Thane couple on first trip to Nepal, kin await clarity

Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, August 28

EVEN AS rescue efforts entered the third day in the flood-ravaged areas along the Nepal-Tibet border, families of pilgrims from Maharashtra remained without information about their loved ones, with several still untraceable.

Among those whose whereabouts remain unknown are Thane-based Aparna and Sameer Joshi, who had travelled to the region for the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra. Sameer's brother Sachin Joshi said the family last heard from him on August 26, when he sent them a photograph at around 7:30 am. "His last WhatsApp status was about around that time," said Sachin.

Both Aparna and Sameer work in the services sector and, according to relatives, had been looking forward to the trip, their first visit to Nepal. Their family has since received multiple calls from the office of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis and Richa Tours and Travels, the tour operator through which they had travelled, but these have offered little clarity.

According to the Maharashtra disaster management department, over 290 tourists



Sameer and Aparna Joshi

from the state remain stranded in the country. Of these, more than 60 Maharashtra tourists were part of the Kailash-Mansarovar trek organised by Hills and Trails, the Mumbai-based partner of Nepalese agency Richa Tours and Travels and are untraceable.

"So far, 395 people from Maharashtra have been confirmed to be stuck in Nepal. Of these, 105 are on their way back to India, while our control room has established contact with the remaining 290 people, who are safe but stranded in different parts of Nepal," a state government official said.

From the Hills and Trails cohort, Thane-based retired IT consultants Rekha and Satish Patankar are also among those

missing. According to Satish's brother Sanjay, the couple had gone for immigration at around 8:30 am before communication with the family stopped. The couple had told their family they expected to cross the border the following day.

Sanjay said the family learnt about the floods in Nepal early Wednesday afternoon, but the gravity of the situation became apparent only later. "Initially, it did not strike us. However, as reports of missing tourists from Timure began pouring in, we started frantically reaching out to my brother and local authorities," he told *The Indian Express*. Their children, Apoorva and Ankur Patankar, who are based in the US, have been trying to seek help in locating their parents.

"The operator informed us that the entire area has been ravaged by floods... There is very little hope at this moment." As the wait continues, families of the missing have turned to social media platforms, including Instagram and Facebook, to circulate missing posters and seek information. A WhatsApp group comprising families and acquaintances of 27 missing members of the Hills and Trails group is also actively sharing information and coordinating efforts.

Hope they are in no-network zone, says 82-year-old mother in Surat



Parash Patel and his wife Jyoti are among the 23 missing from Gujarat

Kamal Saiyed & Aditi Raja
Surat, Vadodara, August 28

SUSHILABEN PATEL, 82, is unsure whether her son, daughter and daughter-in-law are missing or in an 'out-of-network' zone. She hopes it is the latter. Holding their photos in a frame, she has been praying hard since August 26, when her daughter Meenaxi Ramani last called to say that they had cleared immigration for the Kailash Mansarovar journey and would be out of reach.

After that, she watched the videos of the devastating flash floods in Nepal. Her son Parash Patel, 58, his wife Jyoti, 54, and Meenaxi, 61 are among the 23 people with roots in Gujarat who are missing.

According to a list compiled by the State Emergency Operation Centre on Friday, of the 23 missing, 18 are NRIs from the US, Canada, Australia and New Zealand. Many of them were travelling to Kailash Mansarovar through the Gyirong route.

Sushilaben last met her son and daughter-in-law on her husband Natvarlal's death anniversary last year. Parash is settled in Florida, US and has a son Rushabh, who is in college. Meenaxi, her eldest of four children, lives in Mumbai.

"...On the morning of August 26, I last spoke to Meenaxi and she told me, 'We have cleared immigration to go to Mansarovar, and from now on mobile network will not be available.'"

Like the Patels, several families in Gujarat and abroad are now stuck in an agonising wait for a phone call. Some of those now listed as missing spoke to their families minutes before the flash floods swept through parts of Nepal, damaging roads and disrupting communication in the mountainous region.

● RACE AGAINST TIME: EVEN AS TOUR AGENCY MANAGER, OFFICIALS HINT AT SLIM CHANCES OF THEIR PARENTS' SURVIVAL, ARATRIKA AND SANKHADEEP REFUSE TO GIVE UP

British couple with Kolkata roots missing, children plan Nepal trip

Press Trust of India
Kolkata, August 28

ON A PILGRIMAGE to Kailash Mansarovar, a British couple with Kolkata roots have been missing for the past four days following devastating flash floods in Nepal, leaving their family here anxiously awaiting news of their whereabouts.

Anil Kar (56) and his wife Sanjukta Kar (50) reached Kathmandu from New Delhi on August 18 and were last traced to Timure, near the Nepal-Tibet border.

Left desperate for any word about them, the couple's children — Aratrika Kar and her brother Sankhaadeep — have set off for Kolkata to be with their maternal grandfather in Garia, the eastern fringes of Kolkata.

"We may travel to Nepal," she said. The 24-year-old doctor working at a hospital in Wales told PTT over the phone that she had spoken to her parents last

Tuesday, a day before an ice-rock landslide blocked a river in the Himalayan nation and triggered the flash flood.

But that mother-daughter conversation was cut short.

"I have been trying to get in touch with them, but could not get through to them. I spoke to her (mother) on Tuesday, but the call got disconnected, after which she texted me," Aratrika said.

She said her parents were part of an eight-day trek to Kailash Mansarovar, arranged by a tour agency. The group comprised 31 people, including tourists from Australia, the UK, New Zealand, South Africa and Malaysia. Aratrika said, "They called us over video and Messenger (an online communication platform) after reaching there. But due to connectivity issues, the calls were getting dropped. My mother sent a text to my grandfather on Tuesday that they were 15 kilometres from the checkpoint (on the



Sanjukta Kar (left) and Anil Kar (right)

Nepal-Tibet border)."

The tour agency later informed the family that the couple had been waiting at the checkpoint. Aratrika said they had contacted the British authorities and were directed to their embassy in Kathmandu.

"The embassy could not provide us with any information, only that teams were monitoring the situation and would get back to us if there was anything to report." Aratrika even contacted the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) but received no information.

Back in Kolkata, each passing day has deepened the family's worry. Anil Kar's sister Jhuma Majumdar, who lives in Behala, said the family was struggling to cope with the uncertainty.

"They had uploaded photos around 8:10 am on August 26. Their location was in Timure. We have been dialling both of their numbers, but there has been no response.

We tried to contact the Nepal Consulate here, but they also could not help us," said the couple's brother-in-law, Saikat Sen.

Sujay Wasti, the manager of Kathmandu-based 'Kailash Journeys' that had arranged the tour, said they had not been able to reach the affected area because access was restricted and rescue operations were being handled by defence personnel.

"We have no clue... it seems that survival chances are minimal. It's four days now, and I think the bodies have already floated downstream and entered India," he said.

On the couple's survival chances, Joint Secretary and Chief District Officer of the Kathmandu District Administration Office Eshor Raj Poudel said, "It's remote. Even spotting the couple is next to impossible. They must have been swept away."

For the Kar siblings, however, the search remains a race against time as they cling to hope of hearing from their parents.



The Indian EXPRESS

— FOUNDED BY —

RAMNATH GOENKA

— IN 1932 —

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Policy mistakes, not ethanol, behind sugar price rise

SUGAR HAS always been a political commodity in India. It has become more so with the rise in retail prices — from an average of Rs 45 to Rs 65 per kg within a month — that is being blamed on the ethanol-blended petrol programme. The truth is more complex — and bitter. Only 275 per cent of ethanol supplied by distilleries oil marketing companies in 2025-26 is being produced from sugarcane juice and molasses; the balance is coming from cereal grains. Also, the estimated 3 million tonnes (mt) of sugar diverted for making ethanol would be hardly a tenth of the 309 mt gross production during the year ended September 2026. The preceding four sugar years had also seen diversions of 3.5 mt, 2.4 mt, 4.3 mt and 3.6 mt respectively, but without causing price spikes. Ethanol per se clearly isn't the villain here.

The current price spiral has more to do with sugar output itself turning out much lower — from an initial 34.4 mt gross projection made at the start of crushing in November. The shortfall of 3.5 mt should have been anticipated much earlier — at least by February, when mills in Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra were struggling to get cane and even shutting down crushing operations. The government was late to react. It banned exports in mid-May. When ex-factory prices started really soaring from July, it defended its ban by pointing to concerns over energy yields and production prospects for the upcoming 2026-27 sugar year, too, it went into overdrive. A stock limit of 400 tonnes, along with the condition of not holding any sugar beyond 30 days, was imposed on all dealers. Mills were further, as part of a stock verification exercise, directed to furnish details of all bulk consumers to whom they had sold 500 tonnes or more. These knee-jerk panic actions only added fuel to the fire.

The simple thing the government should have done is keep the import doors open. Based on the exports, the tariff on both raw and white sugar imports could have been slashed from 100 per cent to zero by April, when most mills had stopped crushing. The sugar industry is a classic story of controls — the government deciding everything from the pricing of cane to how much yield all mills can sell in the open market during a particular month — that are destined to fail. This sugar crisis is a result of the government neither investing in market intelligence nor allowing market forces to do the job of balancing supply and demand. In short, a policy failure.

Need to break Manipur's cycle of reprisal

MORE THAN three years after the Meitei-Kuki clashes plunged Manipur into a prolonged conflict, a political settlement between the two communities remains out of reach. The state now faces a deepening Kuki-Naga fault line. The killing of four Naga civilians this week in Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi district perpetuates the disturbing cycle of violence. It comes after the murder of Kuki-Thadou church pastors in May, which was followed by retaliatory abductions on both sides; a month later, the bodies of six Naga men were recovered. Other episodes of killings and houses being set ablaze have kept the state on edge. The state government must immediately identify the perpetrators of the recent violence and arrest them. But it will need to do much more to break the chain of violence.

The growing difficulty in ensuring the peaceful co-existence of communities is evident in the blockades imposed by Meitei, Kuki and Naga groups, which have turned Manipur's roads and highways into contested spaces. The blockades disrupt supplies, raise the cost of food and fuel, and restrict access to healthcare. Kangpokpi district — between Naga-dominated Imphal district to the north and the Meitei-dominated valley districts to the south — is the worst affected. Recent RTI data has revealed that more than 700 internally displaced people have died in relief camps. Security forces have had very little success in ensuring the safe movement of convoys carrying essential supplies.

The return of a state government, led by Yumnam Khemchand Singh, in February, after almost a year of President's Rule, had offered hopes of reconciliation. That the government led by a Meitei chief minister, with deputy CMs from the Kuki and Naga communities, has so far found little success in pulling the state back from the brink shows how deeply the divisions have hardened. Political representation alone cannot resolve the conflict when the communities remain socially segregated. Dialogue and a sustained political process, in which all communities have a stake and civil society leaders are empowered, are the only ways forward. Every claim over land and identity cannot be resolved overnight; the immediate goal must be to establish a framework in which people can safely move, trade and live as neighbours. The disarming of militant groups and crackdown on extremist elements, too, must be pursued with equal urgency.

Fifth place and plenty to build on

AFIFTH place may not carry the sheen of a medal. But India has returned from the Women's Hockey World Cup in the Netherlands and Belgium with something almost as significant: Proof that the team is among the game's best again. The team's best finish since 1974 came after a disastrous four-year stretch in which the promise of fourth place at the Tokyo Olympics gave way to missed opportunities and poor results. The team failed to qualify for the Paris Olympics, lost its Pro League status and was beaten by China in the Asia Cup final last year. Against that backdrop, holding China, England and Australia, losing only once in six matches and then beating world No. 5 Germany 3-1 marks a remarkable turnaround.

In three weeks, India will travel to Japan for the Asian Games with a legitimate shot at their first-ever gold. China remain the team to beat, but the World Cup showed that the gap between the two isn't insurmountable. India matched them in their group-stage draw and, with a defence that stood firm against some of the world's strongest attacks and a young generation gaining confidence, the team has every reason to believe it can overturn last year's Asia Cup disappointment.

Hockey India cannot, however, afford to treat this as a feel-good moment. Reports that the Women's Hockey India League could be in trouble are particularly alarming, with captain Savita Punia publicly urging authorities to ensure its continuation. The women have now shown twice — first at the Tokyo Olympics and now again at the World Cup — that they can go toe-to-toe with the best. The task now is to ensure that support grows.

Economy weathered West Asia shock. Now, reform for sustained growth

THE MACRO news over the next week will elicit some cheer. The final tally on the subsidised FCNR flows, a stop-gap measure to buy time on the external front, is expected to be impressive. More importantly, India's GDP growth for last quarter continued as high as 8 per cent, bucking fears the economy was dented by the Middle East conflict. Strong high-frequency data — autos, credit, exports and corporate earnings — have been presaging this outcome for a while.

Three factors explain the pick-up and resilience through the conflict.

First, policymakers executed a joint fiscal-monetary-regulatory stimulus in 2025. Direct taxes were cut in February, GST was rationalised in September, policy rates were cut effectively by 150 basis points accompanied by some regulatory easing in the financial sector.

Second, non-oil exports have begun to accelerate, likely underpinned by the near 15 per cent depreciation of the real effective exchange rate since 2025, a reduction in US tariffs and resilient global growth.

Third, the policy response to the Middle East conflict was swift and nimble. India scurried to diversify energy imports — crude from Russia, LNG from the US and Oman — to prevent domestic shortages. Paradoxically, India imported 17 per cent more energy than normal last quarter. Further, the fisc absorbed the bulk of the oil price shock to insulate the private sector, though this will increase fiscal pressures.

The good news: Growth has been relatively unaffected by the conflict. The cautionary warning: There is no room for complacency because much of the recent pick-up is cyclical, induced by tax and interest-rate cuts and fuelled by strong

credit. At some point these impulses will wane, and growth rates will be shaped by the structural underpinnings of the economy.

Perhaps the most important barometer of long-term growth is the investment rate. Here the news is more sobering. Fixed investment remains at its decadal average of 32 per cent of GDP and has not lifted in recent years. This is despite rising public investment and real estate capex, because corporate capex continues to languish around 10-11 per cent of GDP. Balance sheets of the top 1,000 listed companies reveal there was no discernible pick-up in corporate capex in 2025-26. The imperative for corporate capex to lift is only increasing because both real estate and public investment have begun to slow. Central capex underpinned the post-Covid recovery, growing 30 per cent between 2020 and 2023, but then slowed to 11 per cent in 2024 and just 1.6 per cent in 2025, as last year's tax cuts cannibalised fiscal space. With the fisc absorbing the bulk of the oil shock, central capex will be under pressure again this year. Meanwhile, cash transfers on demand pose a clear and present danger to state capex, which is now growing below nominal GDP.

What then will it take for corporate capex to broaden and deepen? Quite simply, more demand visibility. With capacity utilisation stuck in the 75-76 per cent range over the last decade, and ever-increasing Chinese overcapacity flooding the world, including India, it's understandable why corporates remain cautious. Only strong, sustained consumption and export demand will shake them out of their stupor. It was 16 per cent export growth between 2023 and 2024 that crowded in private capex. In contrast, post-pandemic private consumption and



SAJID Z CHINO

exports grew at just about 5 per cent, before last year's stimulus.

What's needed is for consumption and export growth rates to rise more structurally. The former is inextricably linked to the employment challenge. White-collar jobs created through GCCs and service exports have been key to urban consumption. But the AI writing is on the wall. Service export growth (in nominal dollars) has halved to 8 per cent over the last year from 16 per cent the previous four years. Total employment across the major IT firms has been flat. To be sure, PLFS data show India's employment rate is rising, but a significant fraction of the new jobs are "self-employed" vis-à-vis "salaried-jobs" even though, encouragingly, the mix has improved in 2025. Sectorally, the share of the population working in agriculture, though reducing, is still higher than pre-pandemic levels.

For now, consumption is being fuelled by credit. Armed with healthy balance sheets, NBFC lending to households is growing at 20 per cent and the momentum of banks' unsecured personal lending has risen to 25 per cent. This comes on the back of a sharp increase in household leverage in recent years. For this not to backfire in the coming years, accelerating household incomes are the key.

The challenge, however, is more fundamental: How can labour be made a more attractive factor of production vis-à-vis capital in a world of increased automation and AI? India's capital-labour ratio has been rising for more than two decades. Bending this curve should be our top policy priority. The challenges are new but the constraints are old: Ramping up education, skilling, health,

What's needed is for consumption and export growth rates to rise more structurally. The former is inextricably linked to the employment challenge

rationalising labour laws, which

push up the cost of labour, directing scarce fiscal resources to labour-intensive sectors.

Exports will need to complement private consumption. India's goods exports have declined from 77 per cent of GDP a decade ago to 11 per cent. Policymakers must be commended for not succumbing to export pessimism and signing a slew of FTAs, beginning to rationalise tariffs and QCOs and allowing the exchange rate to depreciate. But for India's exports to become more structurally competitive, factors of production will have to become much more enabling, tariffs and non-tariff barriers rationalised more decisively, and stifling overregulation slashed more holistically.

Boosting consumption and investment more structurally is the key to a sustained private capex cycle. In turn, private capex is the key to crowding in FDI and stabilising the balance of payments.

A strong cyclical pick-up and a raft of capital inflows is unambiguously good news. But these should be thought of as a means, not an end. They provide a bridge over troubled global waters. They buy India time to address the structural underpinnings of the economy. The good news: Corporate and financial sector balance sheets are clean, infrastructure is being ramped up and agriculture is in a sustained surplus. If we can boost demand structurally, the next growth cycle could be a long one.

But in a world where AI is sucking up capital, white-collar jobs are threatened, trade is getting more fragmented and weaponised, and the global order has broken down, the ask is only getting more daunting. The clock is ticking and there is no time to waste.

The writer is head of Asia Economics at J.P. Morgan

To Zohran Mamdani: The RSS chief you may not know



SRIRAM PANCHU

DEAR MR Mamdani, I'm writing this in response to your comments about Mohan Bhagwat, the head of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. I understand where your antipathy to Mr Bhagwat comes from. His organisation has long been regarded as the one pivotal body opposed to Muslims in India.

However, there are a couple of things about him that you need to know. I am a secular and liberal Indian. I was one of the three mediators tasked with mediating the Ayodhya-Babri Masjid-Ram Janmabhoomi dispute in 2019. It reached a crisis point when, in 1949, Hindu zealots sneaked in and put an idol of Ram Lalla inside the mosque. The other flashpoint was 1992, when a mob scaled the barriers and, within hours, brought down the mosque.

This was arguably India's biggest communal conflict. You may not have followed the outcome of the dispute, but very briefly, there was an agreement between most of the significant stakeholders, which led to an outcome that enabled India to close this dispute without a single loss of life.

While the actual result came through a controversial court ruling, it was predicated on the feeling amongst large sections of Muslims that it was in their interests to reach a settlement whereby they were protected for all other places of worship and, based on that, they could contemplate giving up the contentious site of the Babri Masjid.

However, it was also necessary for India's Hindus to step up and avoid jubilation and celebration and allow the moment in history to pass virtually unnoticed. To a large extent, this was because of Bhagwat and his insistence that there should be no celebration or jubilation, which would be irksome to the other side.

Bhagwat also said that the RSS was in this matter only for the Ram Mandir, and that it was not interested in going after any other place of worship. This was a balm for the Muslim mind, especially since the Vishva Hindu Parishad had made no secret about the fact that it had a long list of mosques in different parts of the country and was prepared to go after each one of them. Bhagwat's statement was no doubt meant to dampen that organisation, which has since tempered its activity in this regard.

One more piece of information. There

was litigation concerning the Gyanvapi Mosque in Varanasi. BJP zealots made much of the fact that an object resembling a *shivling* had been discovered on the mosque premises. They were using this to agitate for the return of the mosque to the Hindu fold, claiming that it had indeed been a temple. The case went up to the Supreme Court. It came before D Y Chandrachud, then a puisne judge of the Court. Chandrachud was one of the judges who had delivered the judgment in the Babri Masjid case. In that judgment, the Court had said that the Places of Worship (Special Protection) Act, 1992 embodied the virtues of secularism and was therefore part of the Basic Structure of the Constitution. The Act provided that the character of all places of worship, as of 1947, had to be respected and could not be forcibly changed.

When the Gyanvapi case came before him, all that Chandrachud had to do was reaffirm his judgment in the Ram Mandir case and put a lid on the controversy forever. Instead, he remarked that it was still open to the Court to see whether the place was a mosque or a temple. This was in stark violation of the prescription of the Act. It was a recipe for continuing communal turmoil.

It was Bhagwat who stepped in the next day with a remark that one cannot go looking for shivlings in every mosque.

It was a strange turn of events. The senior judge of the country, soon to be Chief Justice, pitched a disharmonious line, while the head of the RSS was rooting for harmony.

Bhagwat has, since then, made other statements that speak to his recognition of the importance of harmony between India's different communities. For him, harmony is a rooted necessity for India. It comes from the Indian scriptures and teachings. For others, it comes from constitutional prescriptions. What is important is that the beliefs held, articulated, and maintained.

Mr Mamdani, while I do understand your antipathy towards the RSS, I would like you, please, to take note of some of these aspects pertaining to Mr Bhagwat.

It would be good for you, and for him, to have a conversation while he's in your country.

The writer is a senior advocate and mediator



C UDAY BHASKAR

In India-China diplomacy, wariness is the only normal

FOR 24 hours, India and China did what they do best — spoke separately. On August 25, after NSA Ajit Doval met Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing for the 25th Round of Special Representatives (SR) talks, the Indian embassy posted on X that both sides "reviewed bilateral ties and discussed ways to further expand cooperation and maintain stability". Beijing's version was warmer: The two had "comprehensive, in-depth, friendly and candid" discussions; China-India ties now had "global and strategic significance".

The absence of a joint statement led to speculation that consensus on how to frame contentious issues remained elusive. But on August 26, an identical eight-point joint consensus was released, first by New Delhi and later by Beijing. It included a push for an "Early and Substantial Harvest" on boundary delimitation, two new military meeting points, two new border hotlines, an Expert-Level Mechanism on trans-border rivers, facilitation of the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra, resumption of border trade and the next SR round in India in 2027. This delay is perhaps the clearest expression of what defines the India-China relationship today: Deeply embedded wariness. A joint statement after SR talks is rare. This time, the text was agreed within 18 hours, which signals political intent at the highest level ahead of a packed fortnight: The SCO summit in Bishkek and the BRICS summit in Delhi on September 12. But the language shows how complex this task is.

"Early and Substantial Harvest" was coined in 2024 and 2025 to denote progress on delimitation, mapping where the border is, without prejudice to final settlement under the 2005 Agreement on Political Parameters. Agreeing to two additional hotlines and meeting points in the Eastern (Arunachal Pradesh) and Middle (Himachal and Uttarakhand) sectors is significant. Until now, the only functional hotline was in the Western sector, Ladakh. For Beijing to accept new military CBMs in the Eastern sector, which it claims as South Tibet, would have required internal clearance. That is why the joint text says "improving understanding of LAC in appropriate areas" and "promptly address situations through existing diplomatic and military channels to avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation". In the joint statement, both sides avoided the word Tibet/Xizang, referring only to "Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra" and "border trade through three passes". When they sign jointly, they omit the contentious noun and keep the dual mountain-lake names — Kailash and Gang Rinpoche, Mansarovar and Yamayun Tso.

China has said it "supports India in hosting a successful BRICS summit", but remains evasive regarding President Xi Jinping's participation. It is calibrated tactical ambiguity. India has to accept this given its vulnerability on the trade-economic front and the Donald Trump-triggered geopolitical turbulence. Doval's visit has led to a debt outcome, wherein Delhi can highlight difficult bilateral issues while nurturing BRICS as a multipolar platform.

The 24-hour gap between separate and joint statements is that definition in miniature. Separate texts for domestic optics, agree together after overnight vetting by the top leadership and choose words so carefully even a mountain has two names. Wariness is not the failure of diplomacy. In India-China ties, it is the method.

The writer is director, Society for Policy Studies, New Delhi

40 YEARS AGO

August 29, 1986



Ershad steps down

BANGLADESH PRESIDENT Lt Gen Hussain Muhammad Ershad turned civilian amid speculations that he will run for the presidency in October. His army career came to an end when he appointed Major General Atiqur Rahman as the new chief of army staff. Ershad will continue as chief martial law administrator and commander-in-chief.

Loan scheme for urban poor

THREE LAKH people are expected to benefit

from the scheme under the self-employment programme for the urban poor in the current financial year. It will be operative from September 1. The self-employed urban poor with a family income of less than Rs 600 a month will be eligible for a loan of up to Rs 5,000.

Libya calls for UN probe

LIBYA HAS renewed its call for a UN-appointed investigation of US accusations that Col Muammar Gaddafi is planning fresh terrorist attacks against American

targets. In a letter to the UN Secretary General, Javier Perez de Cuellar Libya envoy Ali Treki has voiced his government's willingness to accept an investigation instituted by the Security Council or a World Court decision.

India dismayed at Zia's charge

INDIA NOTED with "deep dismay" the allegation made by President Zia-ul-Haq of Pakistan that New Delhi was aiding the opposition movement against his government led by Benazir Bhutto.

Problem with ethanol blending isn't sugar — it's reliance on grains; the way forward



HARISH DAMODARAN

INDIA'S ETHANOL blended petrol (EBP) programme was initiated primarily to benefit the sugar industry. For mills confronting stagnant sugar consumption demand amid rising production, ethanol created an additional revenue stream to enable them to make timely payments to cane farmers.

Till 2017-18, all ethanol supplied to oil marketing companies (OMC) came from "C-heavy" molasses — a thick, dark brown final byproduct of cane-juice processing, containing sucrose that mills cannot further economically recover as sugar after three rounds of boiling and crystallisation. From the 2018-19 supply year, mills started producing ethanol from the intermediate-stage "B-heavy" molasses and also directly from whole sugarcane juice syrup. With less sucrose getting crystallised and recovered as sugar, mills could use more of it for fermenting into ethanol. They were incentivised to do so by the Narendra Modi government paying more for ethanol made from B-heavy molasses and direct cane juice/syrup than from the normal C-heavy route. The result: Between 2013-14 and 2018-19, ethanol supplies to OMCs rose from 38 crore to 190 crore litres. So did the all-India average ethanol blending in petrol, from 1.6 per cent to 4.9 per cent.

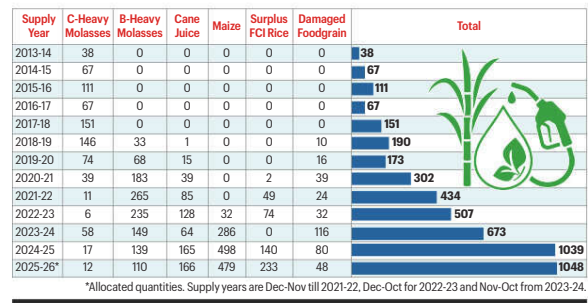
The real change, however, happened when cereal grains began being used as ethanol feedstock. The process here involved first milling the grains into flour, extracting starch and breaking it down to simple sugars, followed by fermentation, distillation and dehydration to 99.9 per cent pure alcohol or ethanol suitable for blending with petrol. Initially, the sugar mills themselves installed multi-feedstock distilleries to run on molasses and juice/syrup during the crushing period (November-April) and on grains in the off-season (May-October), when cane wasn't available. Over time, though, exclusively grain-based ethanol distilleries sprang up across the country. These used either maize or rice, which included surplus and old/broken/damaged grains (FCI) as well as the open market.

In 2023-24, the total ethanol supply of 673 crore litres helped achieve an average 14.6 per cent blending level in petrol. Moreover, grain-based feedstock contributed 402 crore litres or 59.7 per cent. From being an alternative, off-season feedstock for distilleries attached to sugar mills, grains thus emerged as the mainstay of the EBP programme — a case of the tail wagging the dog.

For the current supply year ending October 2026, the OMCs have allocated about 1,048.3 crore litres of ethanol among various distilleries. Out of this quantity, just sufficient to meet a 20 per cent national blending target — 120 crore — is as much as 75.8 per cent or 72.5 per cent is from grains and only the balance 288.5 crore (27.5 per cent) from sugarcane-based feedstock. Given the high sugar prices today and September-ending stocks projected at a 17-year low, it is unlikely that the government will allow any ethanol production from direct cane juice or B-heavy molasses in the coming 2026-27 supply year.

Mills would be forced to recover the maximum possible sugar from cane juice, limiting the scope for making ethanol only from the non-crystallisable sucrose in C-heavy molasses. It will ensure no "diversion" of sugar through the B-heavy and cane juice routes. This diver-

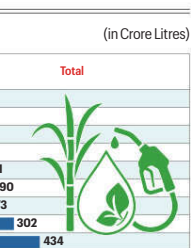
ETHANOL SUPPLY BY FEEDSTOCK



gence amounted to 2.2 million tonnes (mt) in 2020-21 and 3.6 mt, 4.3 mt, 2.4 mt, 3.5 mt and 3 mt in the subsequent five sugar years (October-September). The 3 mt constituted roughly a tenth of India's estimated gross sugar output of 30.9 mt in 2025-26. Simply put, we are heading into a scenario where the EBP programme will be almost exclusively fuelled by grains — the opposite of what it was till 2017-18. The accompanying table shows that even in 2022-23, the year when the average blending ratio crossed 10 per cent, sugarcane-based feedstock supplied over 83 per cent of ethanol. From there, we have now moved to the tail not merely wagging, but taking full control over the dog. While E10 petrol has become E20, the government has already notified standards for E22, E25, E27 and E30 fuel blends. The push for it is basically coming from the distillers, who have set up an aggregate ethanol production capacity of nearly 2,000 crore litres, as against 421 crore in 2014 and the present annual offtake of 1,050 crore litres by OMCs.

It raises the question: Is there enough feedstock to fuel these ambitious targets? In 2026-27, it's not just sugarcane; even maize availability may present challenges, as El Niño gathers strength and with its effects expected to last through the first half of next year. That

From being an alternative, off-season feedstock for distilleries attached to sugar mills, grains emerged as the mainstay of the EBP programme — a case of the tail wagging the dog



leaves only rice — more so, the stocks lying in FCI godowns.

For 2025-26, the Modi government allocated 5.2 mt of surplus FCI rice to ethanol distilleries, which was raised to 7.2 mt in July. At 450-460 litres of ethanol production from every tonne of rice, the 7.2 mt would give 325-330 crore litres. With no sugar diversion and a possible tightening of maize supplies too, the only way to sustain even E20 that requires 1,050 crore litres of ethanol would be to earmark further quantities of FCI rice.

That could be very difficult to justify, not least because rice is a water-guzzling crop. Worse, FCI rice is being sold to ethanol distilleries at Rs 23.2 per kg, with the auction reserve price set even lower at Rs 21/kg for rice with 100 per cent broken grains. For comparison, the all-India modal or most-quoted retail market price for normal rice is Rs 40/kg and Rs 30/kg for broken rice, as per the latest Department of Consumer Affairs data.

Recall the EBP programme's original purpose: It was intended to help sugarcane growers by improving the liquidity of mills. The programme, likewise, provided an additional demand source for maize farmers whose produce was hitherto going mostly for poultry and livestock feed manufacturing. With ethanol, wholesale market prices of maize in India went up from Rs 13.8-17.8 per kg in 2021 to Rs 22.1-24.5 range in 2024. There are two things the government could do.

First, discourage ethanol supplies from standalone grain-based distilleries, especially those significantly reliant on FCI rice. That party must end. Distillers should explore alternative, less water-consuming crops such as bajra and jowar. Their grains contain 58-62 per cent recoverable starch and can give 390-400 litres of ethanol from every tonne, the same as maize. Let millet farmers benefit from higher realisations like maize growers have.

Second, setting blending targets and trying to achieve them ahead of time. The EBP programme was successful even with 10-15 per cent blending and there's no need for posthaste. The government's chief economic adviser V Anantha Nageswaran, in an article for this newspaper, has even suggested going back to E10. He's probably making a virtue out of today's reality.

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Do we really need a definition for 'dimagi Naxal'?



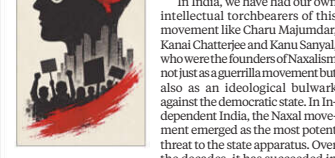
RAM RAJYA BY RAM MADHAV

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi has an enviable knack of getting under the skin of his adversaries. In his address from the Red Fort ramparts on Independence Day, he said that while his government had succeeded in eliminating armed Naxals, "We need to identify these 'dimagi' Naxals, isolate them, and bring the youth together for a developed country."

His "dimagi Naxals" invocation became the proverbial cat among the pigeons. There was indignation in certain sections. Their discomfiture was further compounded by the commentaries of the overzealous supporters of the government on social media. Congress leader P Chidambaram was the first to betray this unease. "I am proud to be a 'dimagi Naxal', he declared on X, inviting catcalls and criticism. Congress is the party of 'dimagi' Naxals. The Editors Guild jumped in, complaining about the portrayal of some journalists as 'dimagi' Naxals. All in all, the PM's phrase seems to have rattled a section of Lytens' elite.

A certain amount of ambiguity that allows polemics to gain is harmless and enjoyable. In the past, too, expressions like "urban Naxals" and "Khan Market Gang" were invoked, eliciting heated debates. While no one defined what exactly those references meant, wise people drew their conclusions.

My intention is also not to explain the PM meant, but only to provide the context. Maoism or Naxalism is not just a militant programme. It is a well-developed ideology that spawned several movements across a number of countries. Mao had himself championed it in China while the Sino-Soviet rift in the 1950s and '60s led to the emergence of this major theoretical tradition, soon absorbed by revolutionary theorists, poets, philosophers, and eventually, insurgent groups. In Cuba, Che Guevara led this Maoist ideology of guerrilla warfare while leaders like Chairman Gonzalo in Peru and Jose Maria Sison in the Philippines led it in their countries. In our own neighbourhood, Pushpa Kamal Dahal "Prachanda" ran a Maoist war through his "Prachanda Path", which was a theoretical fusion of protracted people's war with urban mass uprisings.



In India, we have had our own intellectual torchbearers of this movement like Charu Majumdar, Kanai Chatterjee and Kanu Sanyal, who were the founders of Naxalism not just as a guerrilla movement but also as an ideological bulwark against the democratic state. In Independent India, the Naxal movement emerged as the most potent threat to the state apparatus. Over the decades, it has succeeded in building a strong overground movement with the help of academics, journalists, authors and other public intellectuals. While the armed Naxal cadre indulged in ruthless and senseless violence across rural and tribal areas, the urban civil support system provided the intellectual shield for their actions.

It is interesting to recall what the Union Home Ministry of the UPA government told the Supreme Court in 2013 in the *Kishore Samrises* *Union/India* matter. "The ideologues and supporters of the CPI (Maoist) Party in cities and towns have undertaken a concerted and systematic propaganda against the state to malign it through disinformation," it said, crucially adding that "these ideologues... are in many ways more dangerous than the cadres of the 'People's Liberation Guerrilla Army'." The affidavit also stated that the Maoist strategy "is to mobilise certain targeted sections of the population, especially the urban population, through the 'mass organisations'." These mass organisations operate "under the garb of human rights NGOs" and are "generally manned by ideologues, who include academics and activists," the UPA government contended.

Whether the Modi government defined who the 'dimagi' Naxals are or not, the UPA government's affidavit took pains to do that categorically by telling the apex court that the ideological line these forces profess is "to overthrow the democratically elected parliamentary form of government in India through a combination of armed insurrection, mass mobilisation of certain sections of the society and tactical partnerships."

Looking around, we see this mindset continuing to appear in various forms even today, in the allusive call of a senior opposition leader in the wake of the Gen Z revolt in Nepal or the remarks by an intellectual on the future of democracy in India.

Where is the need to define "dimagi Naxals"?

The writer is president, India Foundation and national vice-president, BJP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Cooperation essential

RECENT DISASTERS in Nepal and Tibet have further underscored the risks facing the wider Himalayan region ('Himalaya needs shared early-warning system', IE, August 28). The events have triggered renewed calls for greater caution in large-scale infrastructure developments, particularly hydropower projects located in fragile mountain valleys. The concern is about whether the cumulative risks of intensive development are being adequately assessed in a region already exposed to earthquakes, landslides, flash floods, cloudbursts, extreme rainfall and glacial hazards. Another central concern is the role of local and indigenous communities in decisions concerning major infrastructure projects.

Manu Somare, via email

THE DISASTER underlines the need for countries sharing the Himalayan region to cooperate more closely. Floods and landslides do not recognise national borders, and timely information can save lives downstream. India, Nepal and China should establish reliable systems for sharing weather, river and glacier data. Early warnings must also reach vulnerable communities quickly.

BA Neboba, Perundurai

Strengthen demand

INDIA'S ECONOMIC resilience is encouraging, but growth should not lead to complacency ('Economy is resilient, but risks remain', IE, August 28). Inflation, weak global demand and uncertainty in international markets can still affect employment and investment. Policymakers must therefore focus on strengthening domestic demand, improving productivity and creating stable jobs. Fiscal discipline remains important, but essential spending on infrastructure, education and health should continue. Sustainable growth requires attention to risks as well as achievements.

SP Suganya Devi, Coimbatore



FRAZER MASCARENHAS SJ

THE FREEDOM of Religion Act, better known as the anti-conversion law, appears to lend itself to allegations of conversion by force, fraud, or inducement. Such a law cannot be shown as required because nowhere in the country has anyone provided data on large-scale conversions. The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita can address criminal acts of conversion by illegal means. The new Maharashtra law is dangerous because it makes the offence non-bailable and the onus is on the accused to prove innocence — on par with the UAPA, an anti-terror law. We have seen how such laws, including the PMLA, have allegedly been misused to create a situation where the judicial process is the punishment — persons facing accusations remain in jail for years, without anything being proved against them. The Maharashtra law is even more problematic because accusations can be made by third parties or family members of the person who, in fact, may have converted or her/his own free will as per the Constitution. Inducement, too, has not been clearly defined, potentially bringing under it any educational, medical or other social services.

Christian groups, especially from the Catholic Church, have been, for decades, providing some of the best education in the country

This law can disrupt not only the freedom of a person to choose the religion s/he wants to profess but also all humanitarian activities for the most disadvantaged communities



SUCHITRA DURAI

IN JUNE this year, after a 52-year gap, the blue-clad Leopards of the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) participated in the FIFA World Cup. Few would have realised the travails that the DRC football team would have undergone to reach this milestone. Since its independence from Belgium in 1960, it has witnessed political instability and civil strife and is one of the poorest countries in Africa.

Since 2021, in eastern DRC, there has been a raging conflict between the M23, an armed rebel group, and government forces. The conflict has resulted in the deaths of thousands of civilians and the displace-

A law that could criminalise compassion

(certified) so by government agencies like the UGC, excellent medical facilities and other social services — many of them in the country's remotest parts. This flows from the Commandment to Love given by Jesus. I have been involved in higher education for 28 years and have served, through teaching and administration, thousands of Indians from all faiths and cultures. Our institutions also give financial help to deserving students and patients without religious restrictions. The officials disbursing such funds on the institution's behalf are often from varied faiths.

The new law can be used to criminalise such activities. Those who make unjustified allegations about a person who does not include a safety clause: If the allegation is found false, the accuser will face a jail term? Several marriages today are inter-religious. The Catholic Church, in part of the country, has recorded 30-40 per cent inter-religious marriages. It allows this and does not require the partner of another faith to convert to marry a Catholic. It appears the state has not taken note of this reality. This law seeks to deter inter-religious marriages through a public declaration weeks before the event. False allegations of an attempt to convert can easily arise.

In Mumbai and its suburbs,

there have been attacks by non-state actors on prayer meetings held in private halls or homes. Small communities of evangelical Christians have borne the brunt of such intrusions and, curiously, the police have confirmed that FIRs have been filed mainly against those attacked — indicating the apparent impunity with which the attackers function. These prayer groups are now attempting to protect themselves against unjust accusations by asking for a declaration to be signed by those who come for the meeting — hardly necessary if law and order is impartially enforced. In the Christian tradition, prayers for healing are a normal part of worship. It is common to pray by laying one's hands on the head of a community member in need of any type of healing. This may be extended to people of other faiths if they so ask. The new anti-conversion law could call this, too, into question.

This law can disrupt not only the freedom of a person to choose the religion s/he wants to profess but also all humanitarian activities for the most disadvantaged communities — those who cannot pay for private education, good health and other social services. Are the disadvantaged in Maharashtra to be left to fend for themselves or to depend on doles?

The writer is former principal, St Xavier's College, Mumbai

When Ebola and conflict feed on each other

In a neglected public-health system. There is also mistrust and suspicion of health workers, particularly foreign health workers, who are viewed as representatives of an extractive and exploitative system. Frontline health workers have also been the target of attacks for being denied an opportunity to participate in funeral rites, which are suspected of being super-spreader events. The WHO declared the situation to be a public-

As Covid has shown, an epidemic anywhere could become a worldwide pandemic if the global community does not come together

health emergency of international concern on May 17 and has stationed over 160 health experts in the DRC. The Africa CDC and partners have deployed experts to help in surveillance, established laboratories and treatment centres, and delivered essential supplies. NGOs and individual countries, including India, have contributed. But the global response, particularly that of the West, has been muted. The dismantling of USAID, the withdrawal of the US from the WHO, as well as donor fatigue, are all contributing factors.

In late May, India supplied 45 tonnes of essential medical aid for distribution to eastern DRC. The supplies included diagnostics, therapeutics, infection prevention and control materials. In June, India also pledged \$10 million at a virtual African Union (AU) summit. While much of India's

partnership has been at the governmental level, it might be useful to encourage triangular cooperation initiatives with the Indian private sector. Local capacities could be strengthened through training programmes for African medical professionals and biotechnologists in Indian R&D centres and vaccine manufacturing companies. As Covid has shown, an epidemic anywhere could become a worldwide pandemic if the global community does not come together. For the campaign against Ebola to be successful in the DRC, the roadmap for peace will also have to roll out in tandem.

The writer is former high commissioner of India to Kenya and former permanent representative of India to the UN Environment Programme

Bihar decides to drop 'fail' from Class 10, 12 marksheets, to replace it with 'eligible for skills'

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 28

STUDENTS APPEARING for the Bihar Board's Class 10 and 12 examinations will no longer have the word "fail" printed on their marksheets, with the state Education Department deciding to replace it with the term "Kaushal ke liye patra (eligible for skills)".

Education Minister Mithlesh Tiwari announced the proposed change at a review meeting on Thursday night, saying the move would be aimed and the Bihar School Examination Board will issue necessary instructions. He said a student's inability to secure the expected marks in an examination should not be treated as a reflection of his or her talent. "It is necessary to maintain the morale of children," he said, adding that words such as "fail" would therefore not be used on certificates.

The department plans to introduce special classes for students appearing for the Matric supplementary examination. "These classes will be conducted for a month to provide students with additional preparation and improve their chances of clearing the examination," an official said.

The announcement comes amid a series of changes in the state's school education system

aimed at giving greater space to activities beyond conventional classroom teaching. Earlier this month, the Education Department announced government schools would operate for a shorter period on Saturdays, with the day designated as a "no bag day". Under the arrangement announced on August 6 in line with Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary's announcement, government schools will remain open from 9.30 am to 1 pm on Saturdays, compared with 9.30 am to 4 pm on weekdays.

"The no-bag day is intended to expose students to theatre, music and other creative activities," the official said, adding that teachers proficient in art and music would be appointed.

Teachers, meanwhile, are required to spend an hour after classroom duties on activities including lesson planning, laboratory management and remedial classes, as required, he said.

Tiwari made the announcement during a meeting that reviewed preparations for the September Teachers' Day function. "One teacher selected from each district will receive a state award. Children from 10 model schools in Patna selected as Saraswati Vidya Niketan schools will also be invited, along with teachers from DIETs, SCERT and teacher-training centres," the official said.

RIFTS IN BIHAR NDA

In his pitch for SC sub-quotas, Manjhi son faces Chirag counter

Santosh Singh
Patna, August 28

THE HINDUSTANI Awam Morcha (Secular) president and Bihar Minister for Minor Water Resources, Santosh Kumar Suman, triggered a debate by calling for a review of the quota policy, backing sub-categorisation of the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and the Scheduled Tribes (STs) in the reservation regime.

The HAM (S) is an ally of the BJP-led NDA in Bihar as well as at the Centre.

An MLC, Suman has argued that "reviewing reservation does not mean ending it but rather ensuring that its benefits reach the most vulnerable and historically marginalised communities that have been left behind".

Suman, the elder son of Union Minister and HAM (S) founder Jitan Ram Manjhi, told reporters: "We are in favour of SC/ST sub-categorisation. We are simply asking for a review of the SC/ST quotas. We want quota benefits to reach the least privileged among us. What we are saying is in sync with what the Supreme Court has already said." In a landmark judgment on August 1, 2024, the SC Constitution Bench allowed states to sub-classify the SCs/STs to ensure grant of quota to more backward castes in these groups.

The central government and the political leadership across a broad spectrum have

supported the apex court's ruling allowing states to ensure internal equity for marginalised sub-castes through "quota within quota", even as they have opposed the exclusion of creamy layer.

HAM (S) spokesperson Danish Rizwan told *The Indian Express*: "We have always supported sub-categorisation among SCs/STs. The quota benefits (among Dalits) do not extend beyond leading SC groups of Ravidas and Paswan. HAM (S) wants to know why there is no IAS officer from Mushahar community."

Rizwan said: "The HAM (S) has been talking about the quota review because it is the right time to discuss it. After all, the RSS had earlier also talked about the issue of quotas."

The Jitan Ram Manjhi family is from the Mushahar group (SC). Among the most backward Dalit groups, Mushahar and its allied caste Bhuviyan account for about 4% of the SC population in Bihar, behind 5.3% Ravidas and 5.2% Paswan.

Chirag opposes

Another NDA ally, LJP (RV), the leading Dalit outfit in Bihar, has been opposed to the apex court's verdict on the SC/ST sub-categorisation and the exclusion of creamy layer.

LJP (RV) chief and Union Minister Chirag Paswan told *The Indian Express*: "We have



Santosh Kumar Suman. FILE

been against... for the simple reason that quotas for the SCs/STs were given on the basis of their untouchability or social discrimination and not on economic criteria. When there can be discrimination against AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge in this country, the talk of sub-categorisation does not make any sense. And, Jitan Ram Manjhi too, had complained about social discrimination."

A row erupted over a "purification" ritual organised in Uttar Pradesh's Haldwani after Kharge's visit. The Congress alleged that those who organised the "shuddhikaran haven" were linked to the BJP, which distanced itself from the event.

Chirag asserted that his party has been opposed to the SC/ST sub-categorisation also because they would remain a social block if they remained non-categorised. "Is there enough inter-caste marriages

in the country? Do people give enough respect to even well-educated Dalits and feel comfortable with marrying their daughters to Dalit boys? We oppose sub-categorisation mainly because of social discrimination," he said.

The LJP (RV) has 19 MLAs in Bihar and five Lok Sabha MPs, while the HAM (S) has five MLAs and only one MP.

BJP stance

Treading cautiously on the issue, BJP national spokesperson Guru Prakash Paswan said: "Our position is clear. As long as social discrimination exists, reservation must continue. Reservation is a constitutional instrument of social justice, not against merit. The SCs sub-categorisation judgment must be considered in light of empirical data. Our approach will be guided by constitutional principles and ensuring equitable distribution of benefits. There is no ambiguity. We remain firmly committed to reservation and social justice."

HAM(S) play

The HAM (S) has also found "flaws" in the existing "Mahadali" framework. The party has contended that despite 18 of 22 SC groups categorised as "Mahadali" in 2008, "internal disparities" have remained and that only their sub-categorisation could address it.

• BRIEFLY



Rescue operation in progress to bring out the girl from a defunct borewell at Purwamir village, in Kanpur district on Friday. PTI

UTTAR PRADESH

16-yr-old falls into borewell as she reaches to tie rakhi on brother, dies

A 16-YEAR-OLD girl, about to tie a rakhi on her brother's wrist on Friday morning, died after falling into a nearly 20-foot-deep defunct borewell at her home in Purwamir village after the ground covering it caved in. Chhatri Shukma was standing on the soil covering the abandoned borewell in the courtyard as she reached out to tie the rakhi, the ground beneath her suddenly gave way, and she fell into the pit. Commissioner of Police Raghubir Lal said a rescue operation involving NDRF, SDRF and fire department teams was carried out. She was brought out and rushed to a Health Centre, where doctors declared her brought dead, officials said. PTI

3 girls drown while bathing in river in Bihar

THREE GIRLS drowned while bathing in a river in Bihar's Bhagalpur district on Friday, officials said. The deceased have been identified as Karishma Kumari, 18, her sister Chanda Kumari, 16, and their eight-year-old cousin Abhishika Kumari. According to officials, the girls drowned after getting caught in the strong currents of the river while bathing at Margang Ghat. Locals recovered two bodies, while a team of State Disaster Relief Force (SDRF) fished out the body of another girl. "The bodies have been sent for post-mortem," Pirpainti Circle Officer Chandrashekhar Kumar said. PTI

Goa: Casino director escapes attempt on life

THE DIRECTOR of an offshore casino in Goa escaped unharm after two assailants opened fire at him near a hotel in Porvorim, near Panaji on Friday night, said police. Srinivas Nayak, Director of offshore casino Majestic Pride, was leaving the hotel 'Neo Majestic' in Porvorim in North Goa. A senior police officer said, "As he was about to enter his car, two assailants fired two to three rounds at him. One of his bodyguards also fired three shots in defense, but the accused managed to flee." Police said no one sustained injuries in the cross-firing. The motive for the shooting is yet to be ascertained. ENS

Areeb Majeed to face additional section under UAPA in IS case

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 28

AREEB MAJEED, who is facing trial for allegedly travelling to Iraq and Syria to join the Islamic State in 2014, will face an additional section under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. On Friday, the court rejected his plea seeking that the charge under Section 17 UAPA not be invoked against him. The charge pertains to punishment for raising funds for a terrorist act, with a maximum penalty of life imprisonment. Last month, with the trial at the age end, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) filed the fifth supplementary chargesheet against Majeed.

Majeed opposed the filing of the chargesheet stating the agency sought to frame an additional charge against him. However, the court took cognizance of the chargesheet noting the NIA only wanted to record a sanction order and electronic evidence, not frame the additional charge.

In the order on Friday, special judge C S Baviskar said the prosecution cannot be denied the opportunity to establish the case against him and that framing the additional charge would cause no prejudice. The court said that Majeed would receive an opportunity to rebut the prosecution's claim.

In May 2014, Majeed, who was 21 then, and three youths from Kalyan, near Mumbai, left India for Baghdad under the pretext of a pilgrimage and allegedly joined the banned terrorist group.

A girl, interrupted: Why a critically ill 14-yr-old is at heart of tribal protests in Maharashtra

Ankita Deshkar
Nagpur, August 28

MORE THAN a fortnight after she was bitten by a snake at a residential school for tribals in Gadchiroli, Samruddhi, 14, is fighting for her life at the Paediatric Intensive Care Unit at Government Medical College (GMC), Nagpur — unaware that her case has become a catalyst, for protests over conditions in tribal schools and for government promises of change.

Samruddhi was among six tribal schoolgirls who were bitten by a common krait on August 10 night, as they slept on the floor of Japtalai Ashram School in Japtalai village of Gadchiroli. The school had no beds. Three of the girls died, two recovered. Doctor Say Samruddhi, who was initially treated at District Hospital in Gadchiroli, had intracranial bleeding, for which she needed brain surgery. She continues to slip in and out of consciousness, and needs ventilator help to breathe.

Her father Suresh Naitam sits quietly on a cot, refusing to leave her side. His wife Archana, her brother Roshan Madavi and some of Samruddhi's teachers take turns to relieve him, all of them hoping to be there for the brief moments that the 14-year-old opens her eyes. Madavi says Samruddhi struggled to do even that at first. "Now she opens her eyes and looks around."

Dr Avinash Gawande, Medical Superintendent at GMC, says Samruddhi's condition is gradually improving, though she



Japtalai Ashram School, where Samruddhi studied. EXPRESS

struggles to be off ventilator for long. She also remains paralysed, barring some response on her left side.

"It will take some time, but we are hopeful she will recover. Given Samruddhi's young age and the fact that her body is still growing, we are hopeful of a good recovery," says a hospital official.

What may have made a difference for Samruddhi and her dead schoolmates was a simple initiative to equip tribal schools with furniture — conceived eight years ago, in 2018-19. Under the 'Kaya Palat Abhiyan', the Maharashtra Tribal Development Department undertook the improvement of living and learning conditions in government-run ashram schools and hostels across the state.

Manisha Verma, now Additional Chief Secretary, Maharashtra Skill Development, Em-

ployment and Innovation Department, had been instrumental in the planning of the scheme. A field officer and project officer with the Integrated Tribal Development Project in 1997-98, when she worked in remote tribal and forest areas, Verma says that a memory that stayed with her from that time was the frequent deaths of children from snakebites, and the unhygienic conditions for students in schools due to absence of basic furniture.

When Verma became Secretary of the Tribal Development Department, her insights provided the framework for Kaya Palat Abhiyan. "We undertook with painstaking planning and execution. The Tribal Development Department's Nagpur Circle has begun inspections of 133 government-aided ashram schools across Nagpur, Gadchiroli, Gondia, Bhandara, Chandrapur and Wardha districts.

The licence of Samruddhi's school has been permanently cancelled. Tribal department officials said the process to relocate the students is underway.

On Wednesday, Maharashtra Tribal Development Minister Ashok Uike had a five-hour

meeting with tribal students protesting in Pune — as a hunger strike by some of them entered the 15th day. He promised that the government was committed to addressing all their concerns, including the snakebite deaths at Japtalai.

From a young age, Samruddhi wanted to join the police force, says Suresh. "The police recruitment exam requires proficiency in the local spoken language (Marathi)," he says, and this is why he sent his daughter to Japtalai Ashram School, located about 20 km from their home in Ranghi; the family speaks a local tribal dialect. One of Samruddhi's cousins studied at the Japtalai school, and this was another factor for her parents.

She had been there only a month when the snake bit her and she landed in hospital.

While the family waits for her to recover, Suresh also worries about what awaits him in the village, where his son, younger to Samruddhi, is with his grandmother. "My crop has been completely destroyed. I rushed here without fencing the farm, and cattle entered the field," he says. The family owns a 1.5-acre paddy field, which is their only source of income.

With no place for attendants at the GMC, Samruddhi's parents and relatives sleep on the floor outside the ward. As Suresh sits inside, Archana watches on a mat pushed against the wall, a small bag containing their clothes, bed sheets and other essentials beside her.

lack of ash or smoke in his lungs. Through it all, police believed that the victim was Kurup, and a funeral was held for him.

Then came another breakthrough: the victim was Chacko, who had sought a lift in the car to reach home.

The hunt

Soon, police found Kurup was alive and had been camping in Kochi. They also found that he had life insurance of Rs 8 lakh.

By the time they caught up, however, Kurup had fled, although the police soon arrested his accomplices — brother-in-law Bhaskara Pillai, and two others, Nonnapan and Shahu.

While Shahu was made an approver in the case, the other two were sentenced to life terms and were eventually released

after completing their sentences.

Meanwhile, the hunt for Kurup continued: other police departments across India were approached, and Interpol was alerted, but these efforts remained unsuccessful.

Then, in 1988, the police found what they thought was a reported sighting: a young nurse from Kurup's home village Cheriyandur allegedly came across a man who looked like him at a hospital in Bokaro. The man had reportedly come in complaining of a cardiac ailment and had sought admission under the name Joshi. However, he was found missing from the hospital.

What the channel showed

On Thursday, Malayalam

NEPAL FLOODS

'He called an hour before the floods hit': 16 NRIs from Telangana missing

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 28

DAYS BEFORE he was to head to Kathmandu for a tour to Kalash Manasarovar, Sai Prasad Somayajulu spent hours climbing up and down 14 flights of stairs to his apartment complex in Hyderabad. "He is an ardent Shiva Bhakt," his nephew Praveen tells *The Indian Express*. "He wanted to make sure he could trek through the difficult terrain."

The 60-year-old Canadian who moved to Hyderabad about two years ago is one of 16 NRIs from Telangana who have been missing since flash floods in Tibet and Nepal. The death toll in the disaster, triggered by an earthquake and an avalanche, stands at 579, with hundreds missing and rescue efforts ongoing.

According to the Indian Ministry of External Affairs, some 320 people, mostly of Indian origin had been reported missing. Back in Hyderabad, his family is worried. "The last contact with him was one hour before the floods hit. He

was at the immigration office at the Nepal-China border."

For several others who have foreign passports, their families have been troubled by bureaucratic red tape. But Indian officials say efforts continue to track down the missing, although this has met roadblocks. "It is becoming increasingly difficult as the Nepal authorities are in touch with only the US embassy regarding their whereabouts since they are US passport holders. But their families are reaching out to the Telangana government for assistance," an official in-charge of the NRI cell in Telangana said.

Despite this, some of those who were stated to be untraceable have since been able to get in touch with their families. Among them is 35-year-old Ali Ilashah, a businessman in Hyderabad. "He called to say he had moved about 40 km ahead of where the landslide hit," his sister A Vanaja told *The Indian Express*. Search continues in the neighbouring state of Andhra Pradesh. In Andhra, around 10 people are still believed missing.

42 years on, Sukumara Kurup mystery returns with Brunei 'sighting' — and a photo twist

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 28

ON JANUARY 21, 1984, Sukumara Kurup allegedly smothered a stranger, put him behind the wheel and set it ablaze in a paddy field in Alappuzha — all in a bid to secure his considerable Rs 8 lakh life insurance claim. This week, the case that had eluded the police for years and had even inspired the 2021 Dulquer Salmaan-starrer 'Kurup' returned to the limelight after a television channel claimed he was "sighted" in Brunei.

The news has caught the state home department off guard — it comes at a time when the crime branch wing of the police was about to close the case,

assuming that Kurup, who had been in his late 30s at the time of the crime, might have died by now.

For his part, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala told the media that the reports will have to be checked. "There have been rumours about this. I have asked ADGP (crimes) H Venkitesh to probe into the report. The state police will approach Interpol to ascertain the facts," he said.

The Chacko murder case of 1984

A native of Cheriyandur village in Kerala's Alappuzha, Kurup worked at a petroleum firm in Abu Dhabi and had been home on a break at the time of the murder.

On January 21, 1984, Kurup allegedly abducted and killed a

man called K J Chacko, then 31 years old, with the help of three accomplices — including his brother-in-law Bhaskara Pillai. The four were scouting for a victim who resembled Kurup when they came across Chacko, a representative of a film distribution firm who asked them for a lift home. He was married a year earlier and his wife Santhamma was six months pregnant with their son Jithan, who, along with his mother, is still waiting for justice.

The then allegedly abducted Chacko, smothered him to death and then set the car, which belonged to Kurup, alight in a field in Alappuzha's Mavelikara police station limits. By the time the police found him, the body had been buried beyond recognition.

The police probe eventually



Sukumara Kurup

found several clues in the field — a matchbox, a rubber glove and multiple footprints — that indicated the presence of other people. But the breakthrough was the autopsy report, which allegedly showed that the victim had been killed before the car was set alight, pointing to the

The Big Picture

SATURDAY, AUGUST 29, 2026



Minal (left) and Meena as teenagers at the weekend retreat in the late 1990s



Meena (left) and Minal reuniting after the DNA match earlier this year.

Dear sister, that missing piece of my puzzle

In the early 1980s, two infants made separate journeys from Mumbai to Amsterdam, into the arms of families who made them their own. Yet, both craved for something that tied them to their past. VIDHEESHA KUNTAMALLA talks to Meena and Minal on growing up as girls who "looked Indian and felt Dutch" — until they found their answer in a DNA test



Baby Meena with her parents Joke and Henk Geltink at Schiphol Airport, Amsterdam, in 1983

Baby Minal with her parents Brigitte and Jan at Schiphol Airport, Amsterdam, in 1982.

ALL PHOTOGRAPHS SOURCED FROM MEENA GELTINK & MINAL TUSSEN

ON OCTOBER 25, 1983, Joke Geltink stood behind the glass window at Amsterdam's Schiphol Airport in her red sweater, arms crossed, watching the tarmac where an Air India plane had landed.

Minutes later, a stewardess in a pink sari walked down the arrivals corridor with a small green-and-white striped bundle that she placed in Joke's arms.

Baby Meena was now Joke's. On a photograph that her husband Henk captured of this moment, Joke later wrote in Dutch, "Op deze foto heb ik je vast om je nooit meer los te laten. Nu ben je onze dochter (I am holding onto you to never let go of you again. Now you are our daughter)."

The previous year, another Dutch couple had stood in the arrivals hall of the same airport. Baby Minal was three-and-a-half months old when she arrived in the Netherlands from India. The photograph is hazier, but has Minal safe in her mother Brigitte's arms, her eyes shining from under a blue hood. Beside them stood Minal's father, Tjissen, a red-haired, bearded man, his hand resting lightly on his wife's back.

Meena Geltink and Minal Tjissen. Born in India and given up at birth, they had found homes and families in a faraway country.

They grew up less than a two-hour drive away from each other, in almost entirely white Dutch neighbourhoods. Meena in a village called Wilp, Minal in Made town, neither aware of the other's existence.

And then, one day, they found each other — a brief friendship that all but fizzled out, until, 15 years later, in May 2026, a DNA match on a family history platform confirmed that they were sisters.

Coming home to Netherlands

Meena and Minal's story sits inside a much larger transnational adoption network across India and the Netherlands. Between 1995 and 2006, the period when Meena and Minal were brought to the Netherlands, at least 594 children were adopted from India, according to the government agency Statistics Netherlands (CBS).

A 2021 CBS study, part of a Dutch government investigation into inter-country adoption from 1967 to 1998, surveyed 3,454 adult adoptees from India and seven other countries. At 20% of all adoptions, Indian babies formed the largest cohort. Nearly half of the India-born adoptees (479%) had actively searched for their origins, hoping to find birth relatives. Yet, only 15.1% found what they were looking for.

Four months after Meena was born — she doesn't know the date, except that it was in Mumbai in 1983 — she arrived at Schiphol airport with five other Indian infants, each delivered into the arms of a waiting family.

She was the only one of the six infants who got to keep her birth name. "My parents told me, 'You've already lost so much... we don't want to take away your name,'" says Meena in a conversation with *The Indian Express*. Meena, 43, now celebrates October 25, the day she was handed over to Joke and Henk Geltink, as her birthday.

Four years later, the Geltinks adopted another child, Ashok, from Goa. A photograph of Meena, her hair tied in pigtails and standing behind a glass window at Schiphol, much like her mother Joke had some years ago, has a caption in Dutch that reads: "The airplane has landed. Just tell Dad and Mom that Ashok is on that airplane."

Growing up, Meena was surrounded by all good things — family, friends, school and sport. She played competitive volleyball and tennis and did gymnastics at a higher level. In the photographs from Meena's childhood, the life around her looks untroubled, calm — the family doing what families do.

In one, Meena is with her mother and brother at a roadside stop, eating sandwiches out of a cooler, her knees drawn up to her chest, the last bite frozen in her hand. In another, she is with her father ("he was my world") and brother on a rowboat. A wooden footbridge curves over the canal behind them. Meena and her brother are grinning, she through the gaps left by a few missing baby teeth.

There are many more — of her lying in the crook of her father's arm as he reads out

to her; one of Meena resting her head on her mother's shoulder, but stealing a glance at the camera, in the middle of a tiring orchestra performance.

Despite the unconditional love she got from home, Meena says her growing up days were "quietly disorienting".

"I was really angry about my adoption," she says. "Very busy with my identity... It was hard, I felt really lonely because I didn't have anyone to talk to about it," she says.

It didn't help that she stood out in the white neighbourhood. "I was dealing with my skin colour because of all the white people around me. The music I loved was also different. I couldn't see myself in my parents. And they were not like me."

At 19, she travelled to India for the first time as part of a trip organised by the adoption agency. The trip did not get her any answers but deepened what she felt as a teenager. "I am an Indian woman, but in India, I was always feeling really Dutch. Strangers on the street looked at her clothes, her camera. She began saving food from her breakfast to hand out on the streets, overwhelmed by guilt she couldn't fully name."

"Someone saw my photo, adopted me and took me to the Netherlands," she remembers thinking. "But what if I hadn't been adopted? Maybe I would have been here on the streets."

That trip included a futile attempt to search for information about her birth family. She knew no more than what her adopted parents had told her — that her birth mother was young and unmarried, and that Meena was born with a heart condition for which she was sent to a nursing home in Mumbai before eventually being transferred to an orphanage.

Her brother, however, took a different route. Though he was aware of his adoption, he told himself that the Geltinks were his biological parents and was content.

A few villages away, in Made, Minal grew up with her mother, a primary-school teacher, and father, who managed a family car garage. Like Meena, she had a younger brother, whom the Tjissens had adopted from an orphanage in India. She also excelled at many of the same sports that Meena played.

"My adoptive parents were really gentle. I had friends at school and it was all nice. I

did not think about my roots as much when I was younger, but the feeling started sinking in as I grew older," says Minal, 44, speaking from her home in Quimper, a city in Brittany, northwestern France, to where she moved over a decade ago.

"I felt different not because I was adopted, but because I didn't look like the other Dutch girls or boys. Even shampoos and other products in Dutch stores were made for blonde hair... People thought I was a cute, small person, the little dark one on the hockey field. But I would have preferred not to be the different one."

Her parents never hid the adoption. "There were no secrets," she says. "They would call me eagerly whenever there were Indian programmes playing on television."

But Minal would hide instead. "I didn't want to see it, because it was like, I won't be able to go to India anyway."

While Meena spent her adolescence trying to find the country and people she had come from, Minal spent hers trying not to think about them. She carried her questions deep inside her. Neither knew that the answer was less than two hours away.

Both girls also had a shared physical burden: sickle cell disease, inherited, as they would later discover, from their birth parents.

Meena was diagnosed at age 16. By 33, doctors in the Netherlands determined she could no longer hold her job as a teaching assistant for children with disabilities.

Minal was told at 15 that she had only inherited a genetic trait, not the full disease, and would likely be spared its worst effects. She works roughly 24 hours a week as a special-needs teaching assistant, alongside volunteering and part-time work as a hockey coach.

'We called each other's'

In the late 1990s, the two girls, now teenagers, met at a weekend retreat organised by the Dutch agency that had facilitated their adoption — one of the annual gatherings the agency still holds over a weekend that ends in a day at the amusement park. Minal was 15 when her mother signed her up, hoping it might eventually prepare her for a trip back to India if she ever decided to.

"I did not want to go, so I brought a friend along to keep me company," Minal says.

Meena, too, arrived with a friend.

Meena first spotted Minal in the shared shower building where a group of teenagers was washing up before dinner. She noticed the nose, the laugh, the way Minal moved —

all uncannily familiar to her.

"I saw her, she saw me, and we giggled and laughed and thought, 'Oh my gosh,'" says Meena.

Minutes later, seated across from each other at the dinner table, Meena couldn't stop staring. Minal, for her part, had spent years averting her eyes from Indian faces on television. Now here was an actual Indian face, sitting a few feet away, staring back. It was unsettling.

Her friend leaned over and said, "Minal, she really looks like you." Meena's friend said the same to her. So did some of the older teenagers, who suggested that the girls go look at themselves in a mirror.

The following day, the two exchanged addresses, said their goodbyes and went their ways. From then on, they called each other "sis" — a playful nickname that stuck.

"Meena told us she met a girl who looked like her. She even showed us a picture of them together. They did look alike, but we never thought it was remotely possible that they could be related. We never acted upon it, regrettably," her mother Joke, now 77, says.

Over the next several years, the girls wrote each other a couple of letters and made the occasional phone call. Then, life happened and like most teenage friendships, theirs faded away. By their early twenties, the two young women were in separate countries.

The years apart

Meena is now a mother to three — 15-year-old Noah, Femm, who is almost 13, and seven-year-old Jazz, whom the family calls Delhi. After separating from her husband, Meena now lives with her children and partner Jeroen.

Holding on to her newborn son for the first time, Meena says, she found herself thinking of the woman who had given her up. "Oh my gosh, how can you give up a child like that?" she recalls thinking. "I looked at Noah and thought, 'I don't know if I can live with the fact that I can't see you anymore.' I was not angry with my biological mother, but I felt so sad for her. The pain she must have felt while she was walking away... Maybe she was forced to do it. I don't know."

Meena then resolved to draw a boundary around how much of her emotional life she would let India occupy, "otherwise I don't

know what will happen".

A DNA test, taken in 2017 and logged with a genealogy database, became her way of staying tethered to the possibility of finding family without letting the search consume her family life. When years passed without a match, she gave up, and deleted the app to free up space on her phone.

Minal's arc ran its own course. She married a Frenchman, Eric, a plumbing teacher whom she met in France. In 2007, she moved to the French village of Quimper. The couple have two sons, 14 and 16.

Minal's first trip to India came in 2004 when she was 21, a tour organised by the adoption agency, the trip that finally cracked open the questions she had spent her adolescence deflecting.

The group visited her orphanage but all she came back with was a suggestion the staff there gave her, "Don't look back. Look to the future..." she recalls.

The memories resurfaced last year, in 2025, when Minal and her family visited Mumbai, Madurai and parts of Kerala.

While visiting her parents in the Netherlands this past April, she finally took a DNA test on MyHeritage, a platform that uses algorithms to scan their database and find matching blocks of DNA between users.

A reunion

Minal's DNA results came on May 20. The system cross-referenced her genetic markers against its full database, matching her to a 2017 file containing Meena's details.

Minutes later, on the evening of May 20, Meena stared at the message that had slid into her phone: a screenshot of a DNA-match notification from MyHeritage captioned *Sœur*, 'sister' in French.

The French word swam past her but she recognised the profile photo — Minal, the girl from the teenagers' weekend retreat 15 years ago. A text followed, "Hi Meena, do you remember me? It's Minal."

Was Minal saying the app had matched them as sisters? Meena tried logging back into the MyHeritage app to check for herself. She had deleted the app years earlier. "My hands were shaking so bad, I typed the wrong password many times," Meena says.

When she finally logged in, there it was: a DNA-match notification of her own. A 100% probability of a full-sister relationship — 36.5% shared DNA, the precise percentage of two people who share both a mother and a father.

"I broke down on the couch and called my mother," says Meena.

After the DNA match, Meena and Minal, and their partners, met at a park in Den Bosch, a city in southern Netherlands.

For Meena, the reunion resolved a long-standing question. "I found that missing piece of my puzzle," she says. She is still curious about her birth parents, "but now, I feel so much rest. If it stays this way, I am happy with that too."

For Minal, the reunion came with a tinge of regret. "I'm very happy to be here now, but also very sad. Why did I not have this before? I could have been there for

Meena. For myself too. I have always felt lonely. Now I know it was my sister who I needed, and that she needed me."

The two families spent the next two weeks together, watching as their children fell into an instant, unforced comfort with each other.

"They look exactly the same... All the children. My daughter Femm resembles both me and her aunt (Minal). The kids went swimming together and played beach volleyball like they had known each other forever," Meena says.

On a text message from Wilp, Meena's mother Joke Geltink, says, "Meena was super happy. She has found peace. She found a big piece of her past."

Her husband Henk, who was with Meena when she first met Minal at the weekend retreat decades ago, died on June 17, 2021, after battling Alzheimer's disease. "My father could not live to see us reunite," says Meena.

Since life, both spectacular and prosaic, must go on, the two sisters are now back with their families — Meena in the Netherlands, Minal in France. They hope to someday travel to India together, to walk side by side down the streets of Mumbai.

"I was not angry with my biological mother. The pain she must have felt while she was walking away... Maybe she was forced to do it. I don't know."



SCAN FOR EXCLUSIVE PHOTOGRAPHS FROM MEENA GELTINK AND MINAL TUSSEN'S GROWING UP YEARS

JIO HAS OVER 524 MILLION SUBSCRIBERS ACROSS INDIA

Jio gets SEBI nod for Rs 38k-crore IPO, set to be India's largest listing

The proposed IPO of Jio Platforms has been one of the most closely watched developments in India's capital markets

Georg Mathew
Mumbai, August 28

JIO PLATFORMS Ltd, the digital and telecom business of Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), is set to enter the capital market with a mega public offer that could redefine the scale of India's initial public offering (IPO) market. The company has received clearance from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to proceed with its IPO, which is expected to mobilise about Rs 37,000 crore, or close to \$4 billion.

The Jio IPO, which is likely to be the largest IPO to hit the market so far, will be a fresh issue of 27 crore equity shares of face value of Rs 10 each at an issue price of Rs 135 per share, as determined through the book building process. Of the issue proceeds, Rs

27,500 crore will be utilised to repay debt and the balance will be used for general corporate purposes not exceeding 25% of the proceeds.

RIL holds 66.43% stake in JPL, while Meta Platforms of the US, founded by Mark Zuckerberg, has 9.98% and Google 7.73%.

Not less than 35% of the net issue will be available for allocation to retail individual investors, according to the DRHP.

With Jio now announcing its IPO plan, two mega IPOs will raise over Rs 67,000 crore from the market in the coming months. The National Stock Exchange (NSE) had also submitted its IPO documents. SEBI is expected to clear the NSE IPO soon. Market estimates suggest the NSE offering could raise around Rs 30,000 crore



Since its launch in 2016, Jio has transformed the Indian telecom sector through rapid growth and expansion. REUTERS

through an offer for sale.

The proposed IPO of Jio Platforms has been one of the most closely watched developments in India's capital markets, largely because of the company's dominant position in telecommunications and its rapidly expanding digital ecosystem. Since its launch in 2016, Jio has transformed the

Indian telecom sector through aggressive pricing, widespread 4G and 5G adoption and large-scale investments in network infrastructure.

Jio has over 524 million subscribers across India. Jio's network leadership in 5G continued to attract subscribers with a total 5G subscriber base reaching 268 million as of

March 2026. Customer engagement also remains robust with 5G now accounting for 55% of total wireless traffic, the company said.

Speculation about a public listing of Jio intensified after Jio Platforms attracted billions of dollars in investments from global technology majors like Meta Platform, Google and Intel in 2020. The fundraising exercise brought in strategic investors who valued the business at levels that placed it among India's most valuable unlisted companies. Meta invested \$5.7 billion to acquire its 9.98% stake in Jio in 2020.

Among large IPOs, Hyundai raised Rs 27,870 crore through its IPO in October 2024, surpassing the Rs 21,008-crore issue of Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) in 2022. Other landmark offerings include Paytm's Rs 18,300-crore IPO in 2021 and Coal India's Rs 15,475-crore issue in 2010. Reliance Power raised around Rs 11,500 crore through its 2008 IPO.

Industrial output up 6.7% in July, economy's strong start to FY27 continues

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 28

INDIA'S INDUSTRIAL sector maintained its strong start to 2026-27 despite the headwinds caused by the West Asia conflict, with its output rising 6.7% year-on-year in July, aided by robust double-digit growth in production of capital goods.

This suggests investments were strong, a positive sign for the economy that has been waiting for the private sector capital expenditure cycle to take hold.

While July's growth rate was lower than June's upwardly-revised figure of 8.8%, Rajani Sinha, Chief Economist at Care Ratings, pointed out that "industrial activity has been largely resilient" this fiscal in the face of global uncertainties and elevated energy prices.

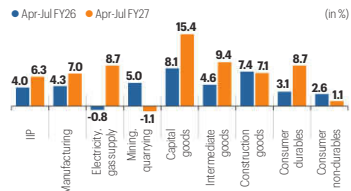
According to data released Friday by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), industrial growth, as measured by the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), in the first four months of 2026-27 was 6.3%, well above the 4% recorded in the corresponding period of 2025-26.

The IIP growth figure for June has been revised sharply upwards to 8.8% from the provisional estimate of 7.3%. In July 2026, growth was 5.4%.

"July IIP data confirms that growth momentum in the economy remains strong," said Rajni Thakur, Chief Economist at L&T Finance. "Even though the headline growth number at 6.7% is softer than in June, it is largely on the back of weather-related slowdown in the mining sector," Thakur added.

Mining output in July was 0.9% lower compared to last year. Rains impede mining and quarrying activity, which adversely impacts the sector's

Capital goods lead charge in FY27



NOTE: DATA FOR SELECT SECTORS, GOODS. SOURCE: MOSPI

output. Manufacturing output grew 7.3% last month. While lower than the 9.5% growth recorded in June, it was higher than 5.1% in July 2025. The sector accounts for three-fourth of the IIP.

Within manufacturing, 19 of the 23 industry groups – such as textiles, chemical products, furniture, among others – recorded higher production in July compared to last year, pointed out Devendra Pant, Chief Economist of India Ratings & Research. The four that saw a contraction in output in July on a year-on-year basis were tobacco products, wearing apparel, chemicals and chemical products, and basic pharmaceuticals products and pharmaceutical preparations. These saw lower production primarily due to weak demand from abroad.

Apart from manufacturing, the electricity and gas supply sector saw its production rise 8.7%, while that of "water supply, sewerage, and waste management" was 7.4% higher.

The IIP data for July comes before the release of GDP numbers for April-June on Monday. While the Reserve

Bank of India has forecast GDP may have grown 7% in the first quarter of 2026-27, some economists think growth may have been as high as 8%.

In terms of the goods, double-digit growth was recorded by three different categories: capital goods, intermediate goods, and consumer durables. While capital goods output was up 16.1%, production of intermediate and consumer durable goods rose 10% and 10.5%, respectively. Infrastructure goods output was up 6.9%.

One note of concern was the performance of consumer non-durable goods, where production was down 1% in July and up a mere 1.1% over April-July.

"In short, the capital goods and infra goods did well," said Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda. "This is a positive sign for the revival in manufacturing which has been on the cards for sometime. The push pulled by government to infra in the first four months has forged strong backward linkages," Sabnavis added.

Tellingly, this is the sixth time in seven months that production of capital goods has increased by more than 10%.

LIC Housing flags Rs 1,322.39-cr exposure in Chandra-linked loans

Georg Mathew
Mumbai, August 28

LIC HOUSING Finance Limited (LICHL) has said it had sanctioned financial facilities under two loan accounts in which Essel Group founder Subhash Chandra is the personal guarantor, and that it continues to retain all rights over the secured assets. LICHL reportedly had an admitted claim of Rs 1,322.39 crore in the insolvency proceedings against Chandra. Under the approved repayment plan, however, LICHL is set to receive just Rs 38.09 lakh.

The statement comes after HDFC Bank on Thursday said it was "exploring an appeal" against an order of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) approving a repayment plan submitted by Chandra in his capacity as a personal guarantor. The plan entails a substantial haircut for creditors on their admitted claims. However, it did not refute the admitted claim mentioned in the reports. "The media reports state that LICHL has an admitted claim of Rs 1,322.39 crore in the said proceedings against which the repayment plan provides for payment of Rs 38.09 lakh to LICHL," LICHL said in a statement.

"LICHL continues to hold and enforce its security interest over the secured assets against

which the financial facilities were granted, which have been duly charged/ mortgaged in favour of LICHL," the company said. "Accordingly, LICHL continues to hold and retain all its rights, security interests, enforcement remedies and recovery avenues over the said secured assets in accordance with applicable provisions of law," it said. "We clarify that the recent NCLT order pertains to the insolvency resolution process against the personal guarantor Subhash Chandra, under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016, and does not in any manner adjudicate, discharge, dilute or impact the corporate liabilities of the principal borrower entities in anyway," it said.

The NCLT has approved Chandra's proposal to pay Rs 6.25 crore against total guarantees signed for Rs 22,000 crore. "Total claim against Subhash Chandra as a personal guarantor, in the personal insolvency proceedings is only Rs 3,992 crore by the objectors of the plan and not Rs 22,000 crore," Subhash Chandra's office said in a press statement issued on Thursday.

HDFC Bank said its admitted claim accounted for 3.2% of the total claims and that it was inherited from erstwhile HDFC Ltd prior to the merger of the two entities. "With regard

to the referred NCLT matter, HDFC Bank's admitted claim was only 3.2% of the total admitted amount. The bank inherited this facility, which was previously provided by HDFC Limited. HDFC Bank had opposed this settlement and voted against the resolution, which was approved by the majority. The bank is exploring an appeal at NCLAT," the lender said in a statement Thursday.

The NCLT verdict saved the case from going into bankruptcy. The proceedings concerning personal guarantees given by Chandra for borrowings of Essel Group-linked companies. When a promoter gives a personal guarantee for corporate loans, the lender can, subject to the applicable legal process, pursue the guarantor when the underlying borrower defaults.

The case therefore goes beyond Zee Entertainment Enterprises. It concerns Chandra's personal liability arising from guarantees linked to corporate debt. There is a separate corporate insolvency proceedings involving companies associated with the Essel Group, or with regulatory proceedings involving Zee Entertainment and its executives.

Warsh signals Federal Reserve may raise rates if inflation stays elevated

Reuters
Wyoming, August 28

"THE US central bank will 'have work to do' if policymakers don't get the confidence they need that inflation is heading down to 2%, Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh said on Friday, coming closer than he has to acknowledging interest rate hikes may be needed to ease price pressures.

"Here is my standard: We must be confident that underlying inflation is moving to our objective, clearly and at sufficient speed. Otherwise, we have work to do. That's our job ... our mandate ... and our charge to keep," Warsh said in the keynote speech to the Fed's Jackson Hole economic symposium in Wyoming.

The remarks drew applause from an audience of global central bankers hungry for more than the vague promises to deliver price stability that have been a feature of Warsh's previous remarks.

Markets also heard the message, raising bets on a rate hike next month that had previously been priced in as more of a long shot. "We're moving up on six years where we've been above target" on inflation, former Philadelphia Fed Presi-



Fed Chair Kevin Warsh. REUTERS

dent Patrick Harker said. "You can't keep saying this is our job and then not act, he added. "As the old saying goes, actions speak way louder than words."

While much of Warsh's 516-page address focused on large issues, like the influence of artificial intelligence, that he feels will be critical in the long run, it also included some key acumen – including that "short-term interest rates are the predominant tool to achieve the dual mandate."

Notably, Warsh said the recommendations of five task forces he has commissioned to study longer-term issues "will come later and have no bearing on decisions we make in the current policy conjuncture."

Stocks post weekly loss on US Fed jitters, closing auction

Mumbai: Indian shares ended higher on Friday, but posted a third straight weekly loss, their longest falling streak in five months, on concerns over a new closing-auction mechanism and caution ahead of the Federal Reserve Chair's speech.

On Friday, the Nifty 50 rose 0.35% to 24,175.65 points, while the BSE Sensex added 0.43% to 72,264.51. The IT index jumped 3.5%, supported by upbeat quarterly results from US chip-maker Nvidia. For the week, the Nifty and Sensex fell 0.3% and 0.4%, respectively.

India's new closing auction session, which determines the official closing price of futures and options-eligible stocks, remained in focus following sharp moves on monthly derivatives expiry days.

The Nifty's indicative price dropped from negative 0.24% to negative 1.4% on Tuesday while on Thursday, BSE derivatives turnover hit an 11-month expiry day low with its indicative close briefly falling more than 3% during the closing auction. REUTERS

BRIEFLY

NBFC body asks RBI to ease restrictions on revolving credit

Mumbai: The representative body of India's non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) has urged the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to reconsider the proposed blanket restriction on revolving credit products offered by NBFCs, according to a letter seen by Reuters. Earlier this month, RBI proposed to curb NBFCs from offering revolving loan products, unless they are authorised to issue credit cards. REUTERS

Govt achieves 78% of FY27 divestment aim

New Delhi: The government has achieved about 78% of the FY27 budgeted divestment and asset monetisation target of Rs 80,000 crore within five months of the financial year. The government has raised Rs 55,757 crore so far this fiscal through minority stake sale in 9 PSUs, including the big ticket ones like LIC and Coal India, as well as strategic sale of Indian Medicines Pharmaceuticals Corporation Ltd and remittances from SUUTI. PTI

MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
72,264.51	24,175.65	₹1,59,578	₹95.39
330.92	84.80		
0.43%	0.35%	Silver	Oil
		₹243,892	₹89.52

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA. GOLD PER 100, SILVER PER KG, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 27, 2026

India, Canada aim to conclude trade talks by 2026-end

Press Trust of India
Washington, August 28

IN A bid to deepen bilateral economic and financial cooperation, India and Canada have said they are looking to conclude negotiations on a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement by the end of 2026 and initiate talks on a Bi-

lateral Investment Treaty at the earliest.

At the inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue in Toronto on Thursday, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Minister of Finance and National Revenue, Francois-Philippe Champagne of Canada agreed to support engagement to relevant

authorities and stakeholders to explore opportunities relating to cross-border remittances and merchant payments.

They welcomed the opportunities to broaden the use of United Nations Electronic Payments Interface (UPI) in Canada through partnerships with payment service providers.

The dialogue builds on the

commitment made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney during their meeting in New Delhi in March 2026 to strengthen bilateral economic and financial cooperation.

The two sides also reaffirmed their shared commitment to conclude negotiations

for a Canada-India Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement by the end of 2026.

Discussions are aimed at supporting financial and commercial linkages between the two countries and advancing the leaders' shared goal of expanding bilateral trade to CAD 70 billion, or around Rs 4.65 lakh crore, by 2030.

• THE MLFF, OR BARRIER-LESS TOLLING SYSTEM, IS CURRENTLY OPERATIONAL AT SIX TOLL PLAZAS

MLFF tolling: 4 months on, how many vehicles crossed without valid FASTag?

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, August 28

IN A step to decongest highways, especially near the toll plazas, the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) launched its ambitious multi-lane free flow (MLFF) or barrier-less tolling system in May, with Choryasi in Gujarat's Surat becoming the first toll plaza to have this facility implemented.

This put India in the league of select nations like the US, Taiwan, Singapore, Australia and European countries to have this advanced tolling system.

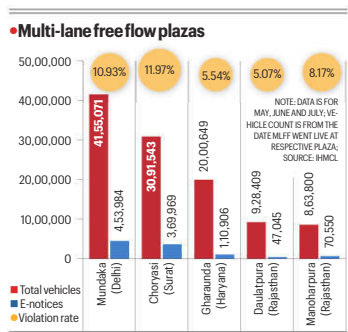
An analysis by *The Indian Express* of monthly reports from five MLFF toll plazas shows that nearly one in every 10 vehicles crosses the barrier-less toll plaza with a faulty or invalid FASTag, thereby not paying the user fee.

According to data from Mundaik toll plaza in Delhi, Choryasi in Gujarat, Gharuanda in Haryana, Daulatpura and Manoharpura in Rajasthan, a total of 10.52 lakh e-notices were issued between May and July to vehicles that crossed the toll plaza without paying the user fee. During the period, a total of 1.10 crore vehicle crossings were recorded since MLFF went live on respective toll plazas, meaning nearly 10% of vehicles were issued e-notices for

non-payment of the toll. The MLFF is currently operational at six toll plazas, with system going live at Choryasi on May 1, Mundaik on May 11, Daulatpura on June 19, Gharuanda on June 25, Manoharpura on July 1, and Shahjahanpur in Rajasthan on August 1.

How does it work?

In MLFF, the vehicles do not need to stop at the toll gate to pay the user fee. The high-performance Radio Frequency Identification (RFID) readers and Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) cameras installed at the toll gate gantry read the FASTag and Vehicle Registration Number (VRN) to deduct the toll amount even at the speed of 100 kmph.



However, if there is insufficient balance in the FASTag, or if it is invalid, faulty or non-functional, highway users are issued an e-notice for non-payment of the user fee immediately after crossing the toll gates. The toll amount must be paid within 72 hours, failing which defaulters have to pay double the toll amount.

Senior highway official said that the total realisation of the amount against e-notices is around 40%. "The highest recovery has been recorded at Choryasi with over 60% share and lowest at Mundaik, where around 20% of the amount is being recovered," said the official.

The official also said that since the system is linked with National Vehicle Registry

(VAHAN) and the banks have validated the VRNs or license plate numbers linked to the FASTags, the repeated violations and non-payment of user fee may result in blacklisting of FASTag and cancellation of other vehicle-related services like PUC (pollution under control certificate) etc.

Where are the most violations?

The data analysis of five toll plazas show that the violation rate (total e-notices issued out of total vehicles crossing) is highest at Choryasi at 11.97%, followed by almost 11% at Mundaik, 8.17% at Manoharpura, 5.54% at Gharuanda and 5.07% at Daulatpura.

numbers, Mundaik toll plaza in Delhi recorded the highest 4.54 lakh e-notices, despite the MLFF system going live there after Choryasi, which issued 370 lakh e-notices over the last three months.

There are some reduction in violations as well. The violation rate of non-payment of toll at country's first MLFF toll plaza Choryasi has dropped from 15.33% in May to 9.73% in July.

The data shows that 11.04 lakh vehicles passed the plaza in May, of which 1.69 lakh e-notices were issued. Similarly, 1.09 lakh e-notices were issued against 10.49 lakh vehicles in June, and 91,240 e-notices against 9.38 lakh vehicles in July.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• GLOBAL

Behind Nepal floods, rising risk of glacier collapse

Arav Shah
New Delhi, August 28

THE FLASH floods that swept through parts of Nepal and Tibet this week have been attributed to a glacial collapse in the Himalayas. It sent ice and rock debris hurtling into the Lhunde Khola and Bhotokoshi river system, eventually reaching inhabited valleys.

Generally, a glacial collapse refers to the sudden detachment of a large mass of ice, rock and water from a glacier on a steep mountain slope. Geological factors like earthquakes, temperature changes, or other physical changes unfolding within a glacier can influence such events.

How glaciers collapse

A glacier forms when snow accumulates and survives over several melting seasons. These deposits are compressed into a layer called firm — the midpoint between fresh and glacial snow — before recrystallising into solid ice as part of a glacier.

Once this glacial mass achieves sufficient weight, it can flow outward. "Mountain gradients on which ice moves in a steep flow are the cause of glacial collapse," glaciologist Iqbal S Hasnain told *The Indian Express*. "Warming temperatures cause lots of melted water to get collected in subglacial channels. These channels open up after the glacier's lower portion collapses, leading to water gushing through in large volumes," he added.

As this mass flows through uneven terrain, the accompanying acceleration creates stress that exceeds the strength of the glacial structure holding the ice together. Sustained movement can ultimately fracture the ice. Structural weakness also comes from surface melting on a glacier. Water can pool inside cracks over cycles of melting and freezing. Eventually, this water pushes hard, splitting the ice all the way through.

Rising frequency

In cases of glacial collapse like the recent one, what sits under the glacier also plays a role. When glaciers rest on soft mud or clay, trapped water moves through the networks of cracks within the glacier to travel downwards. "In these wet base glaciers in the Himalayas, water is collected at the base of the glacier in large quantities and is also occasionally connected by tunnels," said Hasnain.

When such glaciers collapse, it causes a sudden rush of water that mixes with loose dirt, rocks and riverbed materials. This volatile mixture can race down narrow mountain valleys at great speeds. Another complication is posed by the piles of rock and ice that get left behind, which can block narrow river channels and form temporary natural dams. When such a temporary dam breaks under continuous pressure, a second round of flooding can be unleashed — something also witnessed in Nepal this week.

In recent years, the incidence of glacier breakages has increased, owing to the faster warming of the Himalayas due to climate change. As physical conditions become more challenging, this can affect how future search-and-rescue missions are conducted. Advanced preparation via remote seismic monitoring and high-altitude early warning systems then takes on greater importance.

Experts also note the need for correctly zoning critical infrastructure like hydropower plants so they are not erected in high-risk areas. Events like the Nepal floods also point to the need for international cooperation so that upstream glacial instability is communicated downstream before disaster strikes.

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• DIPLOMACY

PM visit to Uzbekistan, Kyrgyz Republic: Why Central Asia matters for India

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 28

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi is headed to Central Asia over the weekend. He will be in Uzbekistan from August 29 to 30 on a bilateral visit and in the Kyrgyz Republic for the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit from August 31 to September 1.

While several Indian Prime Ministers, right from Jawaharlal Nehru, have visited Central Asia, India began its focused engagement with these five countries — Kazakhstan, the Kyrgyz Republic, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan and Turkmenistan — only in 2012 when it framed the "Connect Central Asia" policy. The policy got a fillip when Modi became the first Indian Prime Minister to travel to all five Central Asian countries in July 2015. Modi's visit marks a continuation of this outreach.

What Central Asia offers

Central Asia has always been seen as

Russia's backyard. It has a 20-30% Russian population and the language is also commonly spoken.

The fact that Chinese President Xi Jinping chose to visit Central Asia in September 2022 and visited four of the five Central Asian countries — his first overseas trip after two years of disruption due to the Covid-19 pandemic — speaks volumes about the strategic importance of this region. The region is considered to be extremely rich in mineral and natural resources.

KAZAKHSTAN has one of the world's biggest reserves of uranium. It has other minerals too: coal, lead, zinc, gold and iron ore.

THE KYRGYZ REPUBLIC has gold and hydro-power.

TURKMENISTAN has one of the world's largest reserves of natural gas.

TAJIKISTAN also has huge hydro-power potential and Uzbekistan has gold, uranium and natural gas.

Understandably, the world wants to enter this region to tap into the vast po-

tential it offers.

Battle for strategic space

For India, engagement with the Central Asian countries is important for a variety of reasons — security cooperation in the wake of the Taliban takeover of Afghanistan, countering China's influence, connectivity plans including the International North-South Transit Corridor, energy needs (Kazakhstan has uranium reserves and Turkmenistan is part of the proposed Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-Iran gas pipeline), old cultural links and potential for trade.

India considers Central Asia its extended neighbourhood, and its outreach is aimed at security, political and economic benefits. Another sign of its outreach came in January 2022, when New Delhi invited Central Asian leaders for the Republic Day celebration.

China has also made major investments in the region with its Belt and Road initiative. India doesn't want the post-Sov-

iet space to be captured by the Chinese, and the PM's engagement is a key mechanism in Delhi's toolkit.

The challenges

While the economic benefits for India are clear from the vast reserves of mineral resources it can tap, the lack of overland transport access to Central Asia — Pakistan blocks India's access — remains a major challenge.

This is one of the major reasons for India's engagement with Central Asia. It wants to integrate the International North-South Corridor with the Chabahar port in Iran to access this resource-rich region.

The Central Asian region is widely seen as the northern boundary of the Islamic world, and with the Taliban's ascent in the region, the threat of radicalism and possible regrouping of the Islamic State poses a serious security challenge for these countries as well.

But the complication of the Russia-Ukraine conflict may also cause some

local churn in these Central Asian countries. Reports suggest that some Russians — who have the money and the skills, but cannot move to the West — are moving to these Central Asian countries for the time being. While the region may benefit from the inflow of talent and funding into their local economies, this may create some tension within the countries.

Civilisational, cultural links

There has been a deep cultural and civilisational connect between India and Uzbekistan for centuries. The only Buddhist monastery known in Central Asia is in Kara Tepa, Termez, Uzbekistan. This was an important centre in the Kushana era, when the Buddhist influence had spread further to Central Asia. There are close to 3,000 shared words in Hindi and Uzbek. There are similarities in cuisine, like *ghee-sariyok*, *samosa-samsa*, *naan-non* and *pulao-pilaf*.

India is also among the top 10 trading partners of Uzbekistan. The bilateral trade in 2025-26 stood close to \$1 billion.

SCO leaders' summit

PM Modi will visit Bishkek, Kyrgyz Republic, to participate in the 26th meeting of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization Council of Heads of State (SCO CHS), scheduled on August 31 and September 1.

The SCO comprises 10 member states, including India, Belarus, China, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, 15 Dialogue Partners (Azerbaijan, Armenia, Bahrain, Egypt, Cambodia, Qatar, Kuwait, Laos, the Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, UAE, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Sri Lanka), and two Observers (Mongolia and Afghanistan).

India has been a member of the SCO since 2017.

This year also marks the 3rd edition of the SCO's format meeting. Apart from SCO Member states, Azerbaijan, Armenia, Vietnam, Laos, Mongolia, Togo, Turkey, Egypt, Turkmenistan, along with multi-national bodies like the UN and the Collective Security Treaty Organization are expected to attend the SCO's Meeting.

• META'S \$17-BILLION SETTLEMENT OVER ADDICTIVE DESIGN

How social media hooks children

Endless feeds, recommendation algorithms, notifications and 'likes': Social media design can severely affect mental health of young users

• IN META SETTLEMENT, A BLUEPRINT FOR INDIA?

AS CONCERNS around young users' exposure to social media increasingly enter policy discussions in India, Indian regulators are closely studying Meta's recent settlement with US states over addictive design.

THE SETTLEMENT is being examined at a time when the Centre is weighing a range of possible interventions around children's access to social media, including age-based restrictions, limits on the hours they can use such platforms and stronger parental consent requirements. These discussions are still at an early stage.

BUT THE US case could offer Indian policy makers a blueprint — instead of relying only on platforms' voluntary safety features, regulators have secured enforceable restrictions on how one of the world's largest social media



NEW YORK TIMES/FILE

companies can design and operate its services for minors.

THE SETTLEMENT could consequently feed into the wider debate in India over how much responsibility should rest with platforms themselves — rather than parents or children (which has effectively been tech companies' pitch so far) — for limiting potentially

harmful or compulsive use.

THE BROAD interest is not only in the payout, which is up to \$17.1 billion, but also in the product-level changes, including usage caps, overnight restrictions, stronger age assurance and parental controls. Several of these ideas are also being discussed in India.

- SOUMYARENDRA BARIK



RINKU GHOSH

META, THE owner of Facebook and Instagram, has agreed to pay up to \$17.1 billion in penalties and make major changes to its products over claims that it endangered children with addictive social media design and violated child privacy norms.

Under the landmark settlement in the US, it will have to make a range of changes to its products: From time limits and non-personalised feeds to parental controls and features to reduce constant engagement (see accompanying story).

These changes will only be applicable to under-18s in US states and territories that participated in the case. However, it comes at a time when calls for banning social media use for children are gaining traction across the world, with the precedent set by landmark Australian legislation that went into effect last year. India, too, is exploring graded, age-based, restrictions.

What is interesting about the settlement is how it forces the company to focus on the very design of its products. Dr **Johannes Thrun**, Associate Professor, Department of Mental Health, Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health, said the development reflects a growing recognition that platform design can influence mental health outcomes, particularly for young users.

"I think this is a step in the right direction. The design requirements are more concrete than any other regulation I've seen in the US and include default nighttime blocks, daily limits and tested age assurance," said Dr Thrun in an interview.

Excessive social media use

Several studies show that mental health concerns among young people appear to be associated with excessive or problematic social media use.

"What we have seen in our research is that social media use disorder is related to loneliness, depression and anxiety in young people. We have also found that reducing social media use or taking a break can improve mental health," says Dr Thrun.

Dr Thrun conducted a study involving 2,990 high-school students in Saudi Arabia and found that those with excessive social media use reported greater loneliness and mental distress than their peers.

They also cited loss of control, continued use despite negative consequences,

Are Meta's changes enough?

Some critics say Meta's changes may not be enough because they do not completely address the recommendation algorithms that encourage users to keep scrolling.

Dr Johannes Thrun of Johns Hopkins believes it is 'a real step in the right direction'.

But he cautions that Meta is only a single company and it remains to be seen if other platforms accept equivalent obligations.

interference with everyday life and negative effects on sleep. "Nearly a third of students screened positive for loneliness, and over 40% screened positive for depression or anxiety symptoms," he said.

A 2025 systematic review of 34 studies involving children and adolescents also found that off-task social media and smartphone use was generally associated with lower academic achievement, suggesting that frequent checking or scrolling can interfere with schoolwork and staying focused.

Addictive design

There is reasonable support to show that social media features designed to maximise user engagement can contribute to anxiety, depression, low self-esteem, sleep problems or other mental-health concerns among adolescents. "Appearance-based social comparison, quantified feedback such as visible like counts, and overnight notifications have clear mechanisms of impact," said Dr Thrun.

The American Psychological Association specifically identifies features such as likes, recommended content, unrestricted time limits and endless scrolling as features that should be carefully considered when designing platforms for adolescents. A 2024 meta-analysis of 143 studies involving more than one million adolescents found that greater social media engagement was associated with higher levels of anxiety and depression.

Research has also found that the impact of social media depends partly on platform design, meaning that responsibility cannot be placed entirely on teenagers and their parents. The US Surgeon General has recommended that technology companies prioritise children's health and safety when designing their platforms and that governments introduce stronger safety standards.

Limiting social media use

There is experimental evidence supporting the idea that reducing social media and screen time can improve aspects of young people's mental health, particularly anxiety, depression, loneliness, sleep and emotional difficulties. A 2025 randomised controlled trial studied 220 young people with emotional distress. The group that reduced smartphone-based social media use to about one hour per day for three weeks experienced greater reductions in depression, anxiety and fear of missing out, as well as improvements in sleep.

A 2026 randomised controlled trial found that young people with symptoms of anxiety or depression, who reduced social media use by about 78 minutes per day, experienced a significant reduction in loneliness.



ANAGHA JAYAKUMAR

META ON Wednesday agreed to pay more than \$17 billion to several US states over the next decade to settle claims of addictive platform design, misleading the public about associated harms and improperly collecting data from children under 13. As part of the settlement with 47 US states (as well as Washington DC and other territories) the company has promised to place strict limits on how teenagers use Facebook and Instagram.

The background

The settlement comes amid a much wider set of lawsuits over alleged harms caused by social-media platforms to children and teenagers. In March, a Los Angeles jury in *KGM v. Meta et al* held Meta and Google liable for \$6 million in damages after finding that features of their platforms contributed to a young user's mental-health harms.

Central to these cases is the design of these platforms themselves. Plaintiffs have pointed to endless feeds, recommendation algorithms, notifications and social metrics such as likes and views as features designed to keep young users engaged.

What Meta agreed to change

For the first five years of the settlement, Meta has agreed to impose a combined two-hour daily limit on Facebook and Instagram for users under 18, with direct messaging excluded from the limit. A verified parent can change the limit.

Teen users will also be blocked from most parts of the platforms between midnight and 6 am, with most push notifications disabled between 10 pm and 7 am. Notifications will also be muted between 8 am and 3 pm on school weekdays. Direct messaging will remain available during the nighttime block.

The agreement also provides for a non-personalised feed option, hides likes and reactions by default, restricts cosmetic-procedure filters, and requires stronger age-assurance, parental controls and safeguards around harmful content. These provisions address an issue that had already surfaced during the earlier litigation: whether safety measures work when teenagers have to activate them themselves. At the *KGM* trial, a Meta document showed that only 1.1% of teen users used its existing daily-use limit.

The settlement makes some of these safeguards default settings, while others remain optional. Robbie Torney, Senior Director of AI Programs at Common Sense Media, said that distinction could determine how widely they affect teenagers. "I'd expect the time and night-mode limits to have a real effect simply because they're universal by default," Torney told *The Indian Express*. "The recommendation and engagement changes will likely reach fewer teens because a parent must go into the settings menu to enable them."

According to Carolina Rossini, Professor of Practice at UMass Amherst's School of Public Policy, the settlement is the first instance in the US where a major platform has been forced to change the "architecture of its product", rather than its policies alone. "The dollar figure will get the headlines, but the consequential terms are these changes in design," she told *The Indian Express*. "A safety tool a teenager has to find and turn on is fundamentally dif-

• NEW CURBS FOR KIDS

- A default two-hour daily time limit, cumulative across both apps and across multiple accounts, that only a parent can lift
- A block on app access between midnight and 6 am and muted notifications during school hours (8 am to 3 pm), except direct messages
- Usage prompts after every 15 minutes of continuous scrolling
- The option of a non-algorithmic, non-personalised feed
- The ability to turn off autoplay and for parents to set the default to "off"
- Hidden 'like' counts by default
- Blocks on cosmetic surgery and extreme makeup filters
- Strengthened age-detection systems for under-13 accounts

ferent from a constraint built into the product itself, and this agreement finally recognizes that distinction."

Accountability is key

Under the settlement, Meta must hire an independent auditor to assess compliance with the safeguards for five years. Whether these are effective in reducing harm remains to be seen. "Compliance and harm reduction are different questions, and we should refuse to let the first substitute for the second," Rossini said. "The real test is whether independent researchers get enough data access to measure outcomes: sleep, wellbeing, compulsive-use patterns, not feature checklists."

Torney also cautioned against using screen time alone to judge whether the safeguards have worked. "Time spent on screens is a proxy, not the primary outcome that matters. The real question is what happens during the time teens are still on the app," he said. Torney pointed particularly to recommendation systems. "My biggest question is how turning off algorithmic recommendations changes what teens are shown and re-engage with," he said.

The settlement also gives Meta a financial interest in seeing similar safeguards adopted elsewhere. About 30% of the \$17 billion is contingent on YouTube and TikTok adopting comparable protections and making matching payments. If Snap, TikTok and YouTube all adopt comparable safeguards, stricter restrictions would follow, including a 60-minute daily limit on each platform.

Legal implications

However, the consent judgment explicitly states that the settlement is not an admission of wrongdoing by Meta and does not establish a standard of care or serve as precedent in any non-participating US state or international jurisdiction.

The settlement also leaves a major legal question unresolved. Before the agreement, Stanford Law professor Nora Freeman Engstrom said Meta's attempt to invoke Section 230 immunity against claims targeting platform design could eventually reach the US Supreme Court. While an outcome in the states' trial would not have formally bound the roughly 2,900 other cases in the multidistrict litigation, it could have shaped settlement expectations and litigation strategies.

But Rossini cautioned against treating litigation as a substitute for regulation. "The settlement proves the design-accountability strategy works. It also proves we shouldn't have to litigate our way to it, one company at a time."

Anthony Bourdain, served warm

Shalini Langer

IN HIS memoir *Kitchen Confidential: Adventures in the Culinary Underbelly*, Anthony Bourdain writes, "Good food very often, even most often, is simple food."

From what we know of what followed in that celebrity chef and writer's life, and all that has been spilling out lately from the closets of famous restaurants plus successful TV shows (*The Bear*), kitchens are anything but simple.

Canadian filmmaker Matt Johnson, who has also co-written *Tony*, takes Bourdain's advice — telling simply the story of a not-too-complex young man figuring out his way in the world. And who, but for one black eye and bucketfuls of water poured down on him to wake him up every morning, doesn't have it all that bad.

It all goes down like comfort food, a story that could belong to other misbegotten youth who have found the right mentors at the right time. *Tony* is maybe not haute cuisine, but it's a dish served with warmth.

Inspired by the initial chapters of Bourdain's above-mentioned memoirs, *Tony* is set in the summer of 1975, when alanky, awkward, college-going Bourdain (Dominic Sessa) has his heart set on earning a writing fellowship and winning over Nancy (Emilia Jones). With both out of reach, he steals some money from home and heads out to Provincetown, Massachusetts, where Nancy is spending that summer.

Money runs out soon, and he lands up in the hammock of a kindly restaurant owner known only as Chef (Antonio Banderas). The latter allows Tony to crash out on his porch — well, it's a seaside home, with ocean breeze and star-filled skies — in return for working in his kitchen.

Even as Tony reluctantly takes up his assigned tasks of dishwashing and — with experience, let's just say he is lucky that he gets given his place — one can see him absorbing it all in. The cruel pace of the kitchen, the abuses and minor intoxicants freely passed



around, the tiny details and the mighty egos, though Chef is above it all in true grand-and-gentlemanly Banderas way.

Leo Woodall plays Sal, the charismatic co-worker who has everything going for him, a relatively easy slot in the kitchen, good looks, lots of girls, easy morals and a drug habit. Known for his romantic roles, Woodall plays the rake well, and while he is around, you worry about what slippery road he will take next, and take Tony down with him.

The narrative drama driving the film is the wait for Tony realising that the kitchen is the place he wants to be, and stops telling himself and the world that he is a born star. That he would eventually be both, is too far

TONY

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Matt Johnson

CAST: Dominic Sessa, Antonio Banderas, Emilia Jones, Leo Woodall, Stavros Halkias, Michael Jibrin

away into the future.

Thin, tall, slightly hunched, his eyes watchful and cautious under long, curly hair, Sessa is almost like one of the white-eels Chef may turn into a dish soon — particularly when sprawled in his briefs in the hammock, his limbs dangling. Sessa is good, up to the point when the film wants him to convey the confusion and callowness of youth. However, his performance doesn't transcend that, nor does he allow himself to descend into the brash self-confidence that marked Bourdain by his own confession, even at that early stage of his life.

It's Banderas who simply lifts the film, apart from cinematographer Michael Bau-

man (fresh off the accolades of *One Battle After Another*). Provincetown was the ultimate '70s town, with nothing provincial about it, welcoming all kinds of writers, painters, artists to its white sandy beaches. Bauman captures the hustle and bustle of Provincetown well, as well as those quiet life-defining beach moments between Chef and Tony.

The breeze off the sea, the light off the bonfire, the thrill of freshly snared fish, all dance across Banderas's expressive and kind face.

If there was anything Bourdain wrote more about than food, it was travel. Chef's is a face well-travelled.

A Good Girl's Guide to Patriarchy

Shubhra Gupta

BABITA AKA Baby is your average Indian woman, trying to navigate politics at the workplace as well as in her domestic sphere. It could be the story played out in millions of households, but the thing that makes this film different is that Babita is a cop, elevated by circumstances into her position.

The fact that hers is a 'compassionate posting' keeps coming up a death in Baby's family empties up a spot at the police station, which she steps into, with her colleagues expecting her to earn her place over and over again. The fact that it parallels her home situation, as a wife and daughter-in-law, is not hidden either: dutiful *bahus* are expected to fill empty spots day after day, to keep the family happy.

This quality is captured deftly in Ambiecka Pandit's atmospheric film which threads societal ills through a police procedural, a well-established genre flourishing in the age of streaming. Arriving in small-town Rewa with husband Sharad (Anshuman Pushkar) for her sister-in-law's (Priya Yadav) *goth-bharaat*, Baby's focus is split between her domestic duties and the sordid murder of childhood friend Bansi (Barun Sobti).

It is when the director and writer Amita Vyas train their sights on the spikiness that happens within the *chaar-dinvar* — mother-in-law (Sunita Rajwar) ruling the roost, sister-in-law behaving like the entitled *nanad*, and husband doing the passive-aggressive act — that the film works best. Not this sari, that one; *haldi doodh* at the crack of dawn — all the petulance is saved for the daughter-in-law, who realises that she is being put upon but keeps soldiering on regardless.



BABITA SINGH REPORTING

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Ambiecka Pandit

CAST: Nimisha Sajayan, Anshuman Pushkar, Sunita Rajwar, Priyanka Setia, Priya Yadav, Barun Sobti, Ravi Jhankal, Geetika Vidya Ohlyan, Rajesh Kumar

STREAMING ON: Prime video

The ensemble cast is solid, led by a wonderful Nimisha Sajayan, as she goes about trying to keep everyone happy, pausing to check in on herself only when she can. But the performances can't paper over the weaknesses of the film. The victim is thinly written. We never really get a satisfactory sense of who he is. Why does Baby get so involved? Was there something between the two? Why would a woman, who is clearly not confident of her own abilities, go barreling into tricky situations which are clearly above her pay grade? This is where Baby, and the film, stumbles. Her attempts at understanding the weight of patriarchy and her tentative pushing back has more impact, than the unravelling of the mystery.

You may get reminded of *Sandhya Suri's Santosh* in the way an *anukampa* posting is used to prop up a woman who learns to learn on the job, as well as Rajwar's presence. But the small town woman, and the small town cop, sometimes one playing the other, are in the danger of becoming tropes, if they haven't already. Sudip Sharma (*Pataal Lok*, *Kohrra*) is co-producer here, and well-versed in creating atmospheric, grounded crime thrillers.

Having liked Pandit's short *Under The Waters* very much, I was waiting to see what she did with her debut feature. It lags, but there is also no doubt that there is a voice here.

On a Rampage

Alaka Sahani

THE SERIES opens with an injured man gasping for breath and crawling across the floor while a woman wearing a cat mask enters the house to fetch candies for children. It is Halloween night, and the streets of New York are crowded with revelers. But the boy dressed as a vampire refuses to accept the candies because they are not wrapped. She goes back inside to find the injured man now crawling down the staircase, perhaps looking for a way to escape. She thinks, "It's time," and injects him with something that makes him take his last breath. Once the deed is done, she sits beside him, holding the bowl of candies, and eating them.

By then, she has removed her mask. She, however, goes by different names and disguises throughout the eight-part series. The viewers eventually learn that her name is Catherine Grace (Lola Petticrew). To the cops, she remains a mysterious and calculating serial killer. The series soon introduces FBI Agent Alice Black (Emmy Rossum), who previously worked for the NYPD and solved crimes but now spends her days answering calls from paranoid callers. It is safe to predict that Alice will soon be on the hunt for the killer.

FURIOUS

★★★★

CREATOR: Elizabeth Meriwether

CAST: Emmy Rossum, Lola Petticrew, Scott McNairy, Quincy Tyler Bernstine, Jake Lacy and Steve Way

STREAMING ON: JioHotstar

The crime drama, created by Elizabeth Meriwether and loosely inspired by the 1987 film, *Black Widow*, which follows the stories of Alice and Catherine, has a *Killing Eve*-like feel. As it examines the system's failure to handle sexual-assault cases, and its lack of empathy towards survivors, it also becomes reminiscent of the riveting *Unbelievable*.

As the title *Furious* indicates, the series captures female rage in different forms. Rage becomes the common thread between a woman, who believes she and those close to her have been wronged and chooses to dispense justice in the only way she knows how, and another who is subjected to abuse only to be subjected to further

questioning and scrutiny. As Catherine and Alice pursue their own versions of justice and their paths begin to converge, the boundaries between right and wrong become increasingly blurred.

At the core of *Furious* are the brilliant performances of Rossum and Petticrew. Alice's rage and trauma remain largely under the surface. We get glimpses of it when she turns to self-harm as a way of coping with her pain, or when seemingly ordinary daily activities trigger memories of her torment. In contrast, Catherine's rage is far more pronounced. Yet, she remains protective towards the people she loves. One of them being Aliden (Steve Way). Catherine's home-healthcare aide client as well as supporter.

While Petticrew lends her character a chameleon-like quality, Rossum remains steadfast in her portrayal of a cop who has endured abuse and, later, workplace bias. Petticrew uses her baby face and petite frame to her advantage when dealing with men who are physically imposing and who she believes must pay for their past deeds.

Rossum finds able support in Scott McNairy, who plays Danny Kelly, an NYPD cop who has been a loyal friend and seeks her help in investigating the killings, and Nora Washington (Quincy Tyler Bernstine), a veteran FBI officer who helps the new agent navigate a male-dominated profession and its deep-rooted patriarchal ways. When it is revealed that the crimes Alice is investigating are linked to the sex-trafficking ring Nora had previously stumbled upon, the series begins to point towards the wrongs that can remain unchecked for years, perpetuating a cycle of abuse and crime.

In spite of dealing with a grim subject, *Furious* emerges as one of the most engaging dramas of this year, powered by excellent writing and performances. Meriwether, who created compelling dramas like *The Dropout* and *Dying for Sex*, definitely knows how to tell layered and insightful stories with women at their centre.

STREAMING WATCHLIST



The Whisper Man
NETFLIX

THIS PSYCHOLOGICAL thriller, based on Alex North's bestselling novel, follows a crime writer whose eight-year-old son is

abducted, prompting him to turn to his estranged father, a retired detective, for help. The disappearance takes a disturbing turn when it appears to be linked to a decades-old serial killer case. Directed by James Ashcroft, it features Robert De Niro and Adam Scott.



Bandar
ZEE5

DIRECTED BY Anurag Kashyap, the film features a compelling performance by Bobby Deol as Samar Mehra, a once-popular television star whose life unravels when a former partner accuses him of rape. As the allegations trigger a media frenzy and a bruising legal battle, Samar finds himself trapped in a system where public opinion arrives before the truth. The cast also features Sanya Malhotra and Sapna Bhabhi.



The Last Salute
NETFLIX

AT THE heart of Operation Sagar was the MiG-21, the fighter aircraft flown during the Kargil War. *The Last Salute* is a documentary that brings together untold stories and never-before-seen moments celebrating the aircraft's enduring legacy. It features Air Chief Marshal AP Singh, alongside pilots who flew the MiG-21 across decades of service.



Anbe Diana
SONY LIV

SET IN the neighbourhood of Perambur in Chennai, this cross-cultural romantic comedy follows a young man whose life is turned upside down when he falls for an Anglo-Indian woman. Their romance brings two different worlds together, leading to a lively and often chaotic journey. Parvathy Elavazhagan, who plays the lead, has also written and directed the Tamil film, which also features Ramya Ranganathan in the lead.



Michael
JIOHOTSTAR

THE 2026 biographical drama *Michael* chronicles the life and career of pop icon Michael Jackson, from his childhood in Gary, Indiana, and his early years with the Jackson 5 to his meteoric rise as a solo artist and the height of his fame during the Bad World Tour in the late 1980s. Directed by Antoine Fuqua and written by John Logan, the film stars Jackson's nephew Jaafar Jackson in his acting debut, with Julianne Moore portraying him as a child. The supporting cast includes Nia Long, Kei-Lyn Durrell Jones and Lara Harrier.

ALAKA SAHANI

Fury consumes the fairy and its tale

Shubhra Gupta

"SO YOU think I'm a bad guy? No, I think you're toxic!"

This exchange comes at a point in the film by which time it has been clearly established that Raya (Yash) is the kind of Alpha male who thinks blood spatters are best accessories ever, especially when they spurt from freshly torn and broken limbs.

So is that even a question? No, it's entirely rhetorical. It's exactly the thing that defines this post-independence gangster saga, all three hours 15 minutes of it, for an audience primed for as much gore as the leading man can dish out, especially when he is seen how it got lapped up in his previous mammoth hits (*KGF 1 and 2*).

Like that double bill, *Toxic* is also a period film, in that it opens in Goa in 1947, and rolls through 20 years or so, borrowing from the classic gangster beats of Hollywood classics like *Godfather* — men in sharp suits and sideburns and fedoras, and women in shiny sheaths and slim cigarette holders and smoky night-clubs — as well as dropping big nods to *Animal*. Can it be any other way for our A-listers playing oversexed, emotionally stunted men sporting thick beards?



TOXIC: A FAIRYTALE FOR GROWN-UPS ★★

DIRECTOR: Gattu Mohandas

CAST: Yash, Kiara Advani, Nayanthara, Huma Qureshi, Tara Sutaria, Akshay Oberoi, Rukmini Vasanth

Macau and elsewhere, where mobsters and corrupt forces combine to push crime, and where faceless armies of gun-toting goons keep popping up, shooting and scooting through one set-piece after another, all more exhausting than exhilarating.

It's only when the women appear, all of whom are defined by the relationship to the men they are attached to — it may be Mohandas at the helm, but it is finally, and irrevocably, a *Rocking Star* Yash film — that the film stops to catch a breath. Nayanthara is Raya's protective older sister. Huma Qureshi is a rival gangster's moll. Tara Sutaria is the daughter of said gangster, who has feelings for our Raya. Rukmini Vasanth shows up once the coast is clear, and takes over. Of the array, it is Kiara Advani as the gorgeous, grieving circus trapeze artist who arouses a softness in the hard-edged Raya, who leaves the most impact: If there's anyone who makes this film, it's her.

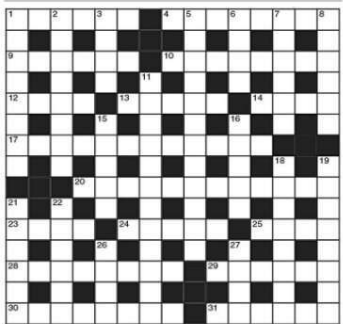
Standing in the middle of all this maximalist murder and mayhem is Yash, who is given such lines as "I don't like violence but violence likes me." The film would like us to believe that he is a gangster because of his circumstances, and not a monster. But to appease the constituency which likes their hero to be rough and tough with his women, Raya has no compunction about spouting coarse, sexist dialogues each time he drops his pants, which is a lot. And every time he did it, the mostly young male audience in my first day show, hooted and cheered.

There's also a father-son angle, and when it locks in, the film comes together, at least for a while. It becomes the heavily stylised fever dream that, perhaps, it was aiming more fully for, but it comes in too late. The rest of it is Yash nursing his toxic self through choppy, rushed scenes, plowing through pliant female flesh, hacking and shooting humans, with the body count piled so dizzyingly high that you lose count almost as soon as it opens.

How can a fairytale be so hollow? The attempt to interrogate wounded masculinity and its consequences is thin, at best. *Toxic* revels much more in its sexualised male gaze, and dialogues (one involves a crude mention of "breaking beds"), for it to lay claim to any kind of meaningful subversion. Too much sound, too much fury, signifying very little.

CROSSWORD

6080



- ACROSS**
- 1 Decorative wood thought likely to be cracked (6)
 - 4 Scratch game (8)
 - 9 Cipher may be a problem in a murder case (6)
 - 10 In the end the tomb inscription may be (8)
 - 12 It's purely symbolic (4)
 - 13 Hit back about old city painting (5)
 - 14 The burden is on America (4)
 - 17 Get a move on and stamp out garrituity? (4,2,3,3)
 - 20 A butchery firm owned by a combine? (5,7)
 - 23 Measure from the back door (4)
 - 24 Come in to ward off an evil spirit (5)
 - 25 He's got to go inside (4)
 - 28 Forget how to take charge (8)
 - 29 A fine trap (6)
 - 30 Push the boat out and depart (5,3)
 - 31 Packed with cargo and ready to go off (6)
- DOWN**
- 1 Breezy girl of a nautical tour (8)
 - 2 Struck for some means of identification (8)
 - 3 Some favour Dutch as a language (4)
 - 5 Study perfume of the valley that's getting better (12)
 - 6 A credit note for some land (4)
 - 7 Like cattle and, note, like sheep as well (6)
 - 8 Describing one with the most experience of life (6)
 - 11 Postponing a mistake on the green? (7,2,3)
 - 15 He gives the fellow an alternative (9)
 - 16 We have to be careful to take them (5)
 - 18 Given — and ideally shouldn't be paid back (8)
 - 19 Crooked men about to plot in underground vault (8)
 - 21 They sweep right inside harbour bars (6)
 - 22 It's worn by a woman for a dance (6)
 - 26 A shade indelicate (4)
 - 27 Game explorer (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6079 ACROSS: 1 Roman, 4 Outback, 8 Owl, 9 Boycotted, 10 Audible, 11 Icons, 13 Traits, 15 Agenda, 18 Spasm, 19 Steamer, 21 Copyright, 23 Nap, 24 Singles, 25 Assay **DOWN:** 1 Riot Act, 2 Melodrama, 3 Nabob, 4 Oxygen, 5 Tooling, 6 Act, 7 Kudos, 12 Ornaments, 14 Tumbrel, 16 Atrophy, 17 Usages, 18 Sects, 20 Extra, 22 Pen

JUMBLE WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles for make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given cup.

Nothing is really work unless you would rather be doing — Marston Bates (9,4)

RVEEE **IOOLNT**

AIOSS **ELPGHM**

Nothing is really work unless you would rather be doing — Marston Bates

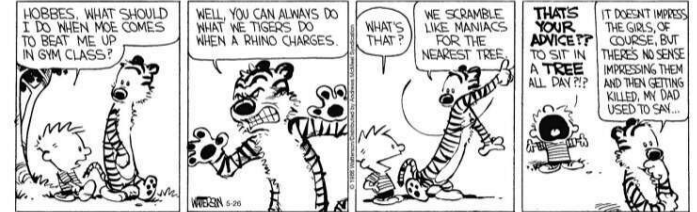
OVER THE HEDGE

BY MICHAEL FRY & LEWIS



CALVIN & HOBBS

BY BILL WATTERSON



MARVIN

BY TOM ARMSTRONG

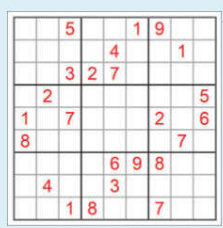


DIFFICULTY LEVEL 4s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

- ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20):** Today you feel a strong need to relate to others. Your emotions are heightened with the Moon in your sign, which can make things a little tricky. You can be emotionally giving, but also emotionally demanding. Tonight: You win.
- TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21):** You might be tempted to withdraw from the demands of people and duties around you because you want to avoid something. Probably, you don't feel like socialising. Tonight: Enjoy time alone.
- GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21):** Today your contact with friends and members of groups is important. This is why you might feel more protective and supportive to someone. You might even feel a bit jealous if this person pays more attention to someone else. Tonight: You're popular.
- CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23):** People will notice you more than usual. Keep this in mind in case you're tempted to have a public argument with a loved one. Be aware that people seem to know details about your private life today. Tonight: You're admired.
- LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23):** You want to shake things up today. You want some adventure. You need a change of scenery. Change your daily routine. Go somewhere you've never been before. Tonight: Explore and learn.
- VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23):** Your emotional experiences are more intense than usual, this might be reflected in your encounters with others. It's because you feel possessive about something, or it could be related to memories from your past. Tonight: Check your finances.
- LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23):** Your attention will likely turn to your most personal relationships because you feel the need to express your feelings today. If you have conflict with a spouse, partner or close friend, it will be more emotional. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.
- SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23):** You might have to put your own emotional considerations second to those of someone else today. Don't worry; you're not being a martyr. This is just what's happening. Take a moment to focus on your health. Tonight: Get better organised.
- SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22):** This is a lovely day for romance, socialising, enjoying a vacation and expanding your world through the theater, movies and the entertainment world. You also might feel protective and nurturing to children or a romantic partner. Tonight: Socialise.
- CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20):** This is the perfect day to retire by yourself somewhere and enjoy your own privacy. Make an effort to do this, even if for a short time. Read a book; watch TV; indulge yourself. Tonight: Relax.
- AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19):** Today you feel a strong need to talk to others. The key is you have to find someone who is willing to listen to you, genuinely. You don't want to simply chat with someone about something inconsequential. Tonight: Discussions.
- PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20):** It's easy to identify with your possessions today, which is why you might feel more possessive than usual about something. Perhaps you don't want to lend something to someone. Tonight: Check your belongings.

THE ANDHRA PRADESH STATE SEEDS DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
D.No. 4-150, Prasadampada, Ramavarampattu Post, Vijayawada - 521102
No.APSDC/PROOF/Material/Tenders/1107/2026-27 Dt: 28.08.2026

C-TENDER NOTICE

Tenders are invited from the registered registered Manufacturers for supply of DWTG, HOPE, Non-woven bags and Labels i.e., packing material for seeds packing to APSDDL units in the districts of A.P. state. Last date for submission of bid is on 09.09.2026, 01:00 PM through <https://tender.apseeds.gov.in> e-procurement platform and for further details please login to website www.apseeds.ap.gov.in

Sd/- C&E MANAGING DIRECTOR

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Gujarat Energy Limited (Erstwhile Gujarat Gas Limited), desires to invite bids against Tender(s) under two bid system through e-tendering portal from eligible and interested parties for the following categories:

Tender ID	Tender Description	Link for accessing the Tender Documents
337505	Rate Contract For Supply Of Various Sizes Of PE Pipes Across GEL Locations	
334663	Supply, installation, configuration of CCTV-Video Monitoring & Surveillance System including all components like camera, PoE, non-PoE switches, NVR, Display Monitors, Video Management Software and all related Licenses across CHG stations, Stores and locations of GEL.	geltender.nprocure.com https://www.gujarat-energy.com/gel-current-tender/
336465	Appointment of Direct Marketing Agency for Domestic and Commercial segment for various GEL locations.	
337501	Annual Maintenance Contract For Fire Extinguishers Across GEL Locations	

Any revision, clarifications, corrigenda, addenda, notifications etc. related to this tender will be updated on the above referred websites only. Interested parties should regularly visit websites to keep themselves updated.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
PUBLIC WORKS ROADS DEPARTMENT
O/O THE CHIEF ENGINEER (EAP)
ARR&TI CAMPUS, FATASIL AMBARI, GUWAHATI-25,
Email-id: as-ce.asbip@assam.gov.in

RFB No. CE/EAP/ARRBP/BRZ/4/13

REQUEST FOR BIDS (RFB)

E-PROCUREMENT NOTICE - Open Competitive Bidding (Two-Envelope Bidding process with Procurement)

The Government of Assam through Government of India has received a loan from the World Bank towards the cost of the **Assam Resilient Rural Bridges Program (ARRBP)** and intends to apply part of the proceeds of the loan to the eligible payment under the contract. Bids are invited online from the eligible bidders from India for the 5 (Five) packages in the district of Cachar and Morigaon. Details may be seen at website <http://www.assamtenders.gov.in> and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours.

The bidding documents are available online on <http://www.assamtenders.gov.in> from 29/08/2026 to 18/09/2026. Bidders will be required to register on the website which is free of cost. For submission of the bids, the bidder is required to have Digital Signature Certificate (DSC). Bids must be submitted online on <http://www.assamtenders.gov.in> or on before 14:00 Hours on 18/09/2026. Other details can be seen in the bidding document. The method of paying Bid Security, Tender Processing fees as indicated in the table of this e-procurement shall be required to be submitted online on <http://www.assamtenders.gov.in> by selecting "Pay Online" option.

Chief Engineer, (EAP) PWRD
Assam, Fatasil Ambari, Guwahati-25
DIPR/CF/XP/1381/29-AUG-26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC)

84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Anil @ Chorlic S/o Prakash Banskari R/ Jhuggi No. A-522, Kamal Nehru Camp Kirti Nagar Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 204/2023 U/s 379/411 IPC at PS: Vijay Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Anil @ Chorlic can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Anil @ Chorlic has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Anil @ Chorlic of FIR No. 204/2023 U/s 379/411 IPC at PS: Vijay Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.09.2026.

By order
Shagun
Judicial Magistrate First Class
North West, Room No.109, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, New Delhi
DP/1212/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Ibran Alam, S/o Md. Ali, R/o F-176, Shahbad Dairy, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 209/2018, U/s 457/380/411 IPC, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Ibran Alam cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Ibran Alam has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Ibran Alam accused of FIR No. 209/2018, U/s 457/380/411 IPC, P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 03.10.2026.

By Order - Ms. Bharti Benival
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05 (North)
DP/12054/ON/2026 Room No. 114, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Ramu, S/o: Bachu Singh, R/o: Village Dayalpur, P.S. Mursan, PO Mursan, Uttar Pradesh has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No.: 019098/21, U/s: 379/411 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Ramu cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Ramu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Ramu of P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.09.2026.

By Order
Ms. Upasana Satija
CJM, North-West, Room No.108, 1st Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/11964/NW/2026

Cochin International Airport Limited

CIAL/COMM/SW/76 TENDER NOTICE 29.08.2026

Online Item Rate Tenders are invited from reputed agencies for the work mentioned below at Cochin International Airport.

Sl.No	Name of Work	Estimate Amount	EMD	Completion Period
1	SITC of Hygiene-Covered Infrastructure Solution at CIAL	Rs. 35 Crores Inclusive of taxes	Rs.20 Lakh	6 Months

Interested firms may register themselves on the online E-tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> and then download the Tender documents. For eligibility criteria and other details, visit our website www.cial.aero.

Sd/- Managing Director

ONGC

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Limited

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

Pre-Qualification criteria (PQC) for hiring of Catering and Housekeeping Services for CPP- LQUP Platform

ONGC, Eastern Offshore Asset, Kalkanda invites for submission of Pre-Qualification criteria (PQC) documents from prospective bidders having experience in catering and housekeeping (combined services) for hiring of the mentioned services at CPP/LQUP platform for a period of three (03) years.

Prospective service providers having the requisite experience may submit the documents as per PQC clauses and queries through email addressed to email IDs mentioned in PQC document.

Last date for receipt of PQC documents: 12.09.2026 by 17:00 hrs. IST. For further details and PQC document, please visit - <https://etenders.gov.in>

कार्यालय आयुक्त, नगर पालिक निगम, ग्यालियर

दर 12/08/2026 (ग.सं. 118/2026)

निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना दिनांक: 27/08/2026

नगर निगम ग्यालियर आयुक्त नगर में अन्नान कुली की जलसंधारण निगम हेतु प.स.स. प्रोजेक्ट (नगर सड़क संशोधन एवं मरम्मत) के अन्तर्गत अन्नान कुली में जलसंधारण के लक्ष्यित श्रवण लाने का कार्य 20 वर्गमीटर पर अन्नान कुली प्रोजेक्ट निगम ग्यालियर आयुक्त नगर निगम ग्यालियर में 4-दस्ता के माध्यम से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है - विवरण निम्न है :-

क्रमांक	विवरण	विवरण	विवरण	विवरण	अनुमानित मात्रा	
01	Sanitization & Anti-rabies work for Birth Control of Street Dogs for 2 locations on an employment basis. Year 2026-27	2026, UAD \$2009.1	25/08/2026	25/08/2026	28/08/2026	1.33 करोड़

निविदा सूचना के माध्यम से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।
अधिक जानकारी के लिए: नगर निगम, ग्यालियर

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY

E-Auction Notice

No. IZN/C/e-Auction/2026/08 Date: 27.08.2026

The bids are invited from registered entities on IREPS by S: DCM IZN (ACCO) through e-Auction for the award Advertisement and NFR contracts. The Catalogue has already been published on IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in. The detail of upcoming e-Auctions of IZN railway division is as under:-

Category	Catalogue No.	Asset Detail	Auction Start	Auction End
ADVT/ IZN-ADVT/	8-26	Commercial public rights to layout advertisement at 18 locations i.e. stations Area LC Gate LC Gate Area Overhead Water Tank and inside station building over Izn railway Division N.E. Railway.	07.09.2026	07.09.2026
NFR	NFR-MFC/ BC-26-3	Development, Operation and Maintenance of Multi-Functional Complex (MFC) at Bareilly City Railway station area over Izn railway Division N.E. Railway for the period of 15 (Fifteen) years.	11.09.2026	11.09.2026
NFR	MFC-KGM/ SI109-P	Renovation, Operation and Maintenance of MFC shop no. 9 at the Kathgodam Railway station over Izn railway Division N.E. Railway for Five (5) years.	14.09.2026	14.09.2026

1. Bidders are advised to visit website www.ireps.gov.in for more information related to e-Auction. 2. The bids have been invited through e-Auction. 3. All the e-Auction related information as eligibility, scope of work, contract period, terms & conditions of contract etc., are available on IREPS. 4. Bidders can participate in e-Auction only as per the date & timing as indicated above. 5. All the prospective bidders are requested to visit website www.ireps.gov.in regularly for any corrigendum related to above e-Auctions.

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0040875087-2

I, Lakshman Singh S/o Hansaraj Singh resident of 2C- 7A Kalpana Sector-2 Vaisali Ghaziabad-20110 Uttar Pradesh, have changed my name from Lakshman Singh to Laxman Singh. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of Laxman Singh for all future purposes.

0040875087-3

I, Madhuri Kumari Goel W/O Suresh Chandra Goel R/O 178, 3rd Floor, Despal Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Madhuri Goel.

0040875087-3

I, MOHD. FARMAN ANSARI S/O AHAMAD HUSSAIN R/O HOUSE NO.E-37/67 BLOCK NO.27, SANJAY CAMP, TRILOK PURI, DELHI-110091, inform that my father's name has been wrongly written as MOHD. AHAMAD ANSARI in my Education Certificate. The actual name of my father is AHAMAD HUSSAIN.

0040875087-1

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GRAND CHESS TOUR CHAMPION

Praggnanandhaa, the bona fide all-rounder of Indian chess

With his dynamic play, the Indian Grandmaster can produce results across formats in different conditions

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, August 28

IN LESS than three months, a pilot event born from the partnership between FIDE and Norway Chess, the Total Chess World Championship, will be played in Budapest. But with chess already having separate World Championships in Classical, Rapid, and Blitz, the point of this new brainchild is to determine who is the most complete player at present.

While the Total Chess World Championship will try to settle that question in a span of 10 days, the Grand Chess Tour has already done the job over a gruelling four-month, six-tournament gauntlet. Emerging from it is the Indian prodigy R Praggnanandhaa, who put the disappointment of São Paulo 2025 behind him, trailing the unfinished business of becoming the first Indian to win the GCT.

Proving his mettle across all three formats in different conditions, Praggnanandhaa has now established himself as the bonafide 'all-rounder' of chess, a player one can bank on to deliver results in any conditions with his dynamic play.

The 2026 GCT Finals were historic in every way. On one side stood Fabiano Caruana, looking to complete a never-before-seen three-peat of the GCT title. Facing him was Praggnanandhaa, aiming to become the first Indian to lift the prestigious trophy.

When the organisers, the Saint Louis Chess Club, ran simulations to predict the winner, Caruana emerged as the clear favourite. After 15,000 tournament simulations, the computers gave the American a 54.9% chance compared to Praggnanandhaa's 45.1%.

It wasn't irrational. Caruana was the defending champion, the third-highest Elo-rated player in history, and was pedigree. It was his backyard, he only had to repeat what he had already performed twice.

The simulations skewed further when Caruana struck first in the opening Classical match, taking a six-point lead. He carried that advantage into the Rapid segment after Praggnanandhaa failed to strike back in the second Classical match with reversed colours.

It wasn't that the Indian could not find weaknesses in Caruana's defence, but playing the GCT finals means enduring the long, fatiguing journey of the tour, which is bound to take its toll.

After squandering a winning chance, Praggnanandhaa entered the Rapid segment trailing 3-9, with 16 points on offer across six shorter-format games. The good part for Praggnanandhaa was that even Caruana was standing at a crossroads. Just one step away from the title but equally exhausted and prone to errors, the Indian unleashed his inner beast, undoing everything Caruana had built.

Outplaying Caruana

Praggnanandhaa turned his self-claimed weakness into strength, outplaying Caruana in the first Rapid game to cut the lead by four points. He repeated the feat in the second Rapid game. Caruana, who had led throughout the finals, was suddenly trailing by two points heading into the final Blitz.

Here, intuition takes over calculation. In an area where Indians generally struggle, Praggnanandhaa thrived. He drew the first Blitz game, lost the second, and won the third,



R Praggnanandhaa became the first Indian to win the Grand Chess Tour title. LENNART OOTES/ICGL

● PROGRESS CARD

- In the Super Chess Classic Romania, he won one, lost one, and drew seven matches to finish tied fifth.
- In Saint Louis, he won Rapid and Blitz, gaining 13 tour points.
- In the Sinquefeld Cup, he won three, but a loss to Vincent Keymer meant he tied for first place with Wesley So. The American took the

title in tiebreaks.

- In the Super Rapid & Blitz Croatia, he finished the Rapid segment joint top with Alireza Firouzja, but his Blitz performance pushed him to tied third
- He finished the tour with the highest points (35.5), ahead of So, Caruana, and Keymer.

maintaining the quid pro quo.

Praggnanandhaa was far from his best, but Caruana was even farther. It all came down to the last five-minute match. A win for the Indian would seal the deal and a loss would force a tiebreak.

The American never looked in control, and Praggnanandhaa forced a threefold repetition in a winning position to reign supreme.

There has never been an iota of doubt about Praggnanandhaa's calibre in Classical chess, even with the disappointment of a middling 2026 Candidates performance. He offset that poor campaign in Cyprus by rocking the world at Norway Chess, where he became the first Indian to win the title.

With the GCT win on his back, backed by a Saint Louis Rapid and Blitz victory, he has also attested to his shorter-format skills. Like every other major year, 2026 also demanded attention in Classical chess, especially being a year of the Candidates, the World Championship, and the Chess Olympiad. But there had to be a point where Praggnanandhaa needed to divert some time to his shorter-format chess.

The seeds were sown in Kolkata in January this year, when he managed only a mid-table finish in the Rapid and Blitz categories of the 2026 Tata Steel Chess India.

His trainer Vaibhav Suri says that the event proved to be a key data point. Since then, the duo have been actively working, taking small steps to iron out any chinks in the armour.

Gill passes test, but his captaincy chops are still a work in progress

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 28

PASINDU SOORIYABANDARA was on 92 and had spent much of the fourth afternoon refusing to let India's spinners settle. He swept, reverse-swept and used his feet against Manav Suthar, helping Sri Lanka chip away at the 213-run deficit and forcing Shubman Gill to keep changing his fields.

Then Gill went to Suthar with an idea. Sooriyabandara, he felt, might come down the pitch. Suthar saw him advance, floated the ball wider, and Rishabh Pant completed the stumping. "I spoke with the captain, and he told me that maybe he could step out. So I was ready for that. All kudos to the captain as well because he told me that maybe he could step out. As soon as I bowled that ball, he stepped out, and I got the wicket," Suthar said later.

It was only one delivery in a series India won 1-0, but it said something about Gill's captaincy. He changed bowlers, moved fields and kept searching for ways to dismiss batsmen.

But the three spinners in both Tests, that tendency showed in how he handled them. Sometimes, as with Sooriyabandara, the change brought a wicket. During Sri Lanka's resistance on the final day in Colombo, India kept searching but did not find regular breakthroughs.

The difference between Galle and Colombo gave Gill plenty to think about. His approach worked at Galle and produced moments such as Sooriyabandara's dismissal in Colombo, but there were also stretches when changing things did not lead to anything. For a young captain, one of the harder parts of the job will be knowing when to make a change and when to stay as a bowler or a plan for longer.

Gill also did not seem to have a fixed order among his three spinners. At Galle, Suthar was brought on in the eighth over of the first innings, ahead of Kuldeep Yadav and Ravindra Jadeja. He was given long spells and attacking fields, with slip, short leg and leg gully used at



Shubman Gill. CHEMAS/BCCI

different stages. The preference was even clearer in the second innings. Suthar took the new ball and bowled 23.4 overs, Jadeja 23 and Kuldeep only 11.

Suthar finished with ten wickets at Galle. By the end of the series, Gill was calling him "the pick of our bowlers" and his "go-to bowler."

"Even when things are not happening, he's been our go-to bowler," Gill said. "He's created chances, which is what I want as a captain." That was something Gill clearly valued: the feeling that a bowler was always capable of creating an opportunity. Suthar provided that more consistently than the others.

Colombo was a different story. Kuldeep's illness brought Saranah Jain into the XI, but Gill showed similar trust in the debutant. He came on in the 11th over with slip and leg slip. As Gill spoke to him, a short leg was added, before two slips and a short leg were stationed for Kamindu Mendis.

Jadeja had an 11-over spell, while Suthar and Jain also bowled extensively. Gill said the rotation kept all three fresh because tired fingers meant fewer revolutions.

"Spinners especially — we take them for granted — but their fingers also get tired. As you keep bowling, you don't get the same revs that you get when you're fresh. The idea be-

hind having three spinners was to rotate them consistently," he said. After India enforced the follow-on, Sooriyabandara and Mendis attacked the spinners with sweeps, reverse sweeps and advances down the pitch. By the 43rd over, India had spread the field for Suthar, who was bowling over the wicket and well outside leg. Sooriyabandara slog-swept him for six.

Gill went back to pace. Prasad Krishna returned with a short-ball plan and, on the first ball, Mendis misused a pull that the skipper ran back and caught superbly. It captured Gill's instinct as captain: if one plan stopped working, try another.

Limitations exposed

Colombo, though, also showed the limits of that approach. Against Sonal Dinusha and the lower order, Gill rotated his spinners, changed fields and returned to pace without finding regular breakthroughs.

By the end, Suthar had bowled 41 overs in the innings, Jadeja 38.3 and Jain 37. Gill felt the slow turn with bounce on the surface took the bowled and lbw out of the equation. Against batsmen intent on survival, the changes were made to manufacture a chance rather than waiting for one to arrive.

"Our thinking was that if we keep changing the bowlers, it gives us a better chance of taking wickets," Gill said. "Once the batsman is set and we feel we're not creating enough opportunities, we have to rotate."

He will have more opportunities to find the balance between when to attack and defend. India have seven Tests left in this WTC cycle — two in New Zealand and five at home against Australia.

New Zealand may test Gill's handling of his fast bowlers. Against Australia at home, his use of the spinners could once again be crucial. Sri Lanka was another part of his learning curve. The next seven Tests will show how quickly he can turn those lessons into better decisions — and whether those calls can help take India to another WTC final.

England rip apart Pakistan's batting to take 180-run lead

Associated Press
London, August 28

ENGLAND CAN anticipate finishing day two against Pakistan in the Lord's Test, which started on Friday. England was all out for 290 in the morning and its four seam bowlers then tore through Pakistan for 110 in 37.2 overs for a first-innings lead of 180. Ollie Robinson had 4-1 off 13 overs, including six maidens.

Jofra Archer had 3-26 from 11.2, Josh Tongue had two wickets and a luckless Gus Atkinson none. Arian Awaiz was easily the standout for Pakistan. The novice opener, after scoring 0 and 9 in the first test defeat in Leeds last week, lasted to the 35th over, digging in against 102 balls to score 46. He

was out top-edging a pull to the boundary. Awaiz's innings was remarkable considering the next best runs in Pakistan's scoreboard was 20 extras.

He was the second-to-last man out at 106-8. Pakistan was effectively nine down because Awaiz's opening partner Imam-ul-Haq couldn't bat due to a low grade left calf tear sustained while fielding on Thursday.

Pakistan lost its most in-form batter Abdullah Shafique right on lunch, taken at 16-2 in 14 overs. Captain Babar Azam, coming back from a finger injury that made him miss the first test, walked out after lunch, hit a couple of boundaries through the covers then edged Tongue to third slip.

Saud Shakeel was the only

batter other than Awaiz to reach double figures. He had 16 from 16 balls when he was pinned by England on his back leg. After a 30-minute rain delay, Mohammad Rizwan was also out lbw to Robinson. The wickets fell in a hurry from that point.

Ali Usman played Archer out of his stumps. Khurram Shahzad edged Robinson to second slip and Awaiz finally fell. Archer missed claiming Mohammad Ali, who was dropped by Joe Root at leg slip, but the fast bowler bowled Mohammad Abbas to end the innings.

BRIEF SCORES: England 290 all-out lead Pakistan 110 all-out in 37.2 overs (Azaan 46; Ollie Robinson 4-11, Jofra Archer 3-26) by 180 runs at Day 2 tea.

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 28

AFTER IMRAN Khan's sons, Kasim and Sulaiman, confirmed their concerns about their imprisoned father's health in Pakistan's notorious Adiala jail, in a Sky Sports interview to Mike Atherton, the Pakistan Cricket Board deliberated on not taking the field during the second Test against England in Lord's. The PCB, whose head Mohsin Naqvi is also Pakistan's minister of the interior affairs, had requested the broadcasters to not air the interview but the broadcasters went ahead with it, even if slightly delayed. They later lodged a formal complaint to Sky Sports.

In fact, according to English media, the Sky Sports commentators on eschewing the interaction, before they eventually

decided to go ahead. According to Guardian, "aggravated Pakistan are understood to have also raised the issue with the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office." The interview almost entirely centred around the deposed former Prime Minister, the country's Islamic cricketer, his deteriorating health and the alleged ill-treatment at the hands of the current dispensation.

The most serious allegation was their fear over his life. "It's very, very clear what they're doing, which is they're just blatantly trying to kill him in there," Kasim claimed. "They just want to keep him in there as long as possible and hopefully just silence him," he added. He had earlier mentioned about the assassination attempts when bullets hit his legs, in 2022.

It was also the last time they



Michael Atherton (L) interviews Imran Khan's sons. SCREENGRAB/SKY

saw him, sentenced to 14 years to go for one reason or another, maybe out of fear that we're going to be active and try to support the efforts of getting him out from over there," Kasim said. The broader family in Pakistan too have not seen him in the last ten months, Kasim said.

"failures". They just don't want us to go for one reason or another, maybe out of fear that we're going to be active and try to support the efforts of getting him out from over there," Kasim said. The broader family in Pakistan too have not seen him in the last ten months, Kasim said.

"Until last week, no one's been able to see him, been allowed to see him for 10 months, despite them going to the jail every week to attempt to see him," he elaborated. Until the end of 2025, visitors were regularly allowed, before they were abruptly restricted, presumably due to fears that his supporters would mobilise against the regime. It spun rumours that he had died (or was killed), which though turned out to be false.

Their phone calls have been brief, lasting up to six minutes, where Imran is inquisitive about their well-being. He complained of his health, especially the loss of vision in an eye. "He had an eye issue. I think he's lost about 80 percent of the vision in one of his eyes. So he told us about that. He told us that he complained about it for months."

● TENNIS: NEW WONDERKID

How Nadal's workload advice shaped Jodar's rapid ascent

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, August 28

AS RAFAEL Nadal took on his Madrid mate Martin Landaluce at the Next Gen ATP Finals in Jeddah last year, another Spaniard watched intently from the stands. Rafael Nadal, retired in 2024, later spent time with the up-and-coming duo and had special advice for Jodar.

He (Nadal) told me to try not to play too many tournaments, because I think there are players who try to play every week, and it's not good for your health," Jodar said to *Tennis Channel*. Nadal perhaps knew what he was saying. After all, who knows the tour's grind and toll it can have on the body better than the 22-time Major winner?

vice seriously and only turned pro in January 2026 after "deep reflection". He has since risen from world number 168 to 13th; he is on track to break Boris Becker's 41-year-old record for the fastest rise from outside the top 100 to the top 10.

Becker made the leap in 210 days; the teenager, already Spain's second-highest-ranked player behind Carlos Alcaraz, is closing in on the record after seven months after entering the top 100.

During this period, Jodar has claimed his maiden ATP title on Marrakech's clay and reached a hardcourt final in Washington. He reached the French Open quarter-final and has made one semi-final and two quarter-final appearances at Masters 1000 tournaments.

His new heads to Flushing Meadows, where he already has wonderful memories to look back upon, having won the US Open Junior Champion-



Rafael Jodar. REUTERS

ships two years ago. He stayed off eight of 11 break points in the final, rebounding from a break down in the deciding set to topple top seed Nicolai Budkov Kjaer.

Jodar has earned praise from contemporaries and legends alike for his gameplay and

● Number Plate

221

- Days it took for Rafael Jodar to reach his career-best 11th rank after turning pro.

near-unprecedented ascent. Alcaraz has referred to him as an "outstanding player," Janik Sinner wrote "What a player" on the camera lens after beating the youngster at the Madrid Open. Becker loves his "composure and maturity," and has said that "Spain is lucky to have another diamond in its arsenal".

Roger Federer singled out Jodar and Brazilian João Fonseca as the players he most enjoys watching on the circuit. "I like Rafael Jodar; his rise has been incredible. I wouldn't have imagined it a few months

ago, and I think nobody imagined it either. So, I think it's amazing how he manages to maintain his level," the Swiss great told *ESPN Brasil*.

New Rafa

Jodar has done enough to earn the affectionate nickname reserved for Federer's friend-adversary. He has been deemed the 'new Rafa' by fans and is working hard to live up to that lofty expectation.

"Spain has been a country with many great players. Rafa Nadal is the benchmark because he has reached the very top. He is no longer just a benchmark for Spanish tennis, but for world sport. I feel very proud to share these traits and many of the characteristics on the court," Jodar said in an interview with Spanish radio network *Cadena SER*.

Though 20 years younger than Nadal, Jodar was not named after the left-handed

heartthrob. He shares his name with his grandfather as well as his father, the latter a high school physical education teacher who learned tennis to be able to coach his son. "My dad, he has been my biggest support my whole life. He wants the best for me, so that's why he always takes care of me in the best way possible," Rafa Jodar junior told the ATP Tour website.

The red-hot right-hander will take on Australia's Thanasi Kokkinakis in the US Open first round and is in the same half of the men's singles draw as top seed Alexander Zverev and No. 3 Félix Auger-Aliassime. If he does go deep, Alcaraz might await in the final. Jodar has a long way to go before he can match up to the six-time Major winner, but has most of the ingredients that make Sincaraz who they are: agility on both court ends, powerful returns of serve and explosive shotmaking.

Asian Games-bound Abhishek served notice for doping violation

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 28

ASIAN GAMES-bound long distance runner Abhishek Pal has been served notice by the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) for an apparent doping violation, according to sources.

Pal has not, however, been handed a provisional suspension yet by the NADA, it is learnt.

He has been named in the 72-member Indian athletics team for the upcoming Asian Games in Japan to run in 5000m and 10,000m races.

A banned substance has been found in a very small amount in his dope sample and he has been served a notice by the NADA, a source privy to the development told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

It is learnt that the banned

substance could be a female fertility drug.

"The banned substance is also something surprising. I am sure he will request the NADA for an investigation," the source added.

The development will make it difficult for him to compete in the Asian Games, though he is likely to approach the NADA for a quick resolution of his case. Pal, who also has trained in the USA, won a gold and a silver in 10,000m and 5000m races respectively at the National Inter-State Championships in June. He had also won a 10,000m bronze in the 2023 Asian Championships.

Before this, two wrestlers Mukul Dahiya (86 kg freestyle) and Deepanshu (130 kg Greco-Roman) were also in the doping net with the 86 kg going unrepresented.

Neeraj books DL finale berth; Pathirage throws 92.07m



Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage will be the favourite at the Diamond League Final. REUTERS

Express News Service New Delhi, August 28

INDIA'S DOUBLE Olympic medalist javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra has qualified for the 2026 Diamond League Finals on Thursday despite missing three of the five meets in the calendar.

Chopra qualified for the finals slated to be held in Brussels on September 4 and 5, even after missing the Zurich Diamond League on Thursday. Commonwealth Games champion Rumesh Pathirage secured his top spot among the six finalists after winning the event in Zurich with another massive throw. The Sri Lankan stole the show with a whopping 92.07m effort, his second-best behind a 92.67m throw in the Rome Diamond League in June this year.

Besides Pathirage, who accumulated 39 points and Neeraj, who sneaked in at sixth place with 12 points, Anderson Peters, Keshorn Walcott, Curtis Thompson and Julius Yego have made the javelin final.

Neeraj came second at the Lausanne Diamond League last month with a season-best throw of 88.05m, finishing behind Pathirage. Chopra led the javelin throw after two throws from all nine competitors, thanks to a season-best throw of 88.05 metres.

But Chopra's stay at the top was short-lived. In the third round of throws, Pathirage produced an event-winning effort of 88.14 metres, a lead which was never even threatened. "I didn't realise it was only nine centimetres (apart), it was really close, but I'm happy with the 88-metre throw," Neeraj said afterwards. "To be honest, it didn't feel like it was 88 metres. I felt very relaxed. I tried really hard and later focused on my technique. With every competition, I feel that I'm coming back."

Injury issues

Chopra spent nine months out of the sport with injury before making a comeback at the Doha Diamond League in June where he had finished fourth with a best of 85.69m.

After the Commonwealth Games silver, Chopra had posted a long emotional post on his social media accounts about finishing second and what it meant for him personally. "There are throws that travel far, and then there are moments that carry the weight of an entire journey. This one means so much more than the distance. The past 10 months have tested me in ways I never expected."

'I think the culture has changed... biggest task was to create a unit'



What went into coaching the women's team to best World Cup finish in 52 years

Mihir Vasavda Mumbai, August 28

SJOERD MARJINE took over a side, at the start of this year, that had lost twice as many matches as they had won in 2025. The confidence was at the nadir. There were cracks in the dressing room. Almost a dozen players were injured.

Eight months later, the same team embarked on an inspired run at the World Cup, losing just once in six games, holding their fort against powerhouses, and recording their best-ever finish in 52 years — fifth. In an interview with *The Indian Express*, Marjine explains how he turned around the team's fortunes. *Excerpts:*

What did you tell the players in the huddle after the win against Germany?

I said to the girls, listen, we are now number five in the world (as per the World Cup standings), be very proud of yourself, but also it doesn't stop here. We now have a next tournament, so be really happy and take that confidence with you to the Asian Games. Also take a good rest in the following days, but we can do even better than this.

When you joined the expectations were very different from this team. What has changed?

I think that culture has changed for them and also the way they can and must behave. That means like moments to relax and have fun with each other and enjoy what you're doing. Those are the changes we have made in the team after I did this. I think that culture has changed for them and also the way they can and must behave. That means like moments to relax and have fun with each other and enjoy what you're doing. Those are the changes we have made in the team after I did this.

You said you did research about the team over the last few years. So what did you find out?

The most important thing is they weren't a unit. A lot of things happened amongst them. I don't want to go too deep into it because it's a period I was not there. And I can't talk about previous coaches, what they did or whatever. I don't want to be negative about that. For me, the assignment from Hockey India was, "Spend, you have to create unity and they must show the outside world that they are enjoying and that they are a team."

When you took over, many players were injured. While at the World Cup, what stood out was that they



Sjoerd Marjine, who guided the Indian women's team to a fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics, returned in January this year. ■

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"Against Germany, towards the end of the match, we had a four against one (situation) and we didn't score because of a poor pass. The Netherlands would definitely have scored that goal. I want them to understand this is what we need to do to really win games."

could match other teams physically...

I think 11 or 12 players (were injured). The moment I got the assignment, actually before that, I told Hockey India, "I need Wayne Lombard (strength and conditioning expert) in the staff. He's overseeing the whole medical and physical side."

I leave that 100% to him. He's the guy who's responsible for this. We brought them step by step back to the level that we want and even higher. That's also what you can see against Germany; we kept pushing, pushing, pushing. The girls also feel very confident with Wayne. If he says you can run more, the girls will run more. And he has a very good team with Rodet Yila and Clara Yila (both scientific advisors).

Was the technical part of coaching them easier compared to the physical part, given that there were injuries and they had to reach a certain level?

It's always a combination. I

must say that India has the technical capabilities, but not always the right ones. Like, for instance, India is very focused on individual dribbles and that is not what you need at the highest level.

If you watch the Netherlands, they are the closest to the men's hockey game. What also makes the Netherlands different, besides the physical part, is the individual skill — the passing and trapping. The ball is always fast. They only need two touches. That's what I keep telling them (Indian players): "Listen, it's not about your dribbles. It's about these things."

Like against Germany, towards the end of the match, we had a four against one (situation) and we didn't score because of a poor pass. The Netherlands would definitely have scored that goal. I want them to understand this is what we need to do to really win games.

Despite this team still being a work in progress, did it surprise you that they lost just one match in the

• HI ANNOUNCES 50 LAKH AWARD

HOCKEY INDIA on Friday announced a cash award of Rs 50 lakh for the Indian women's team in recognition of their historic fifth-place finish at the FIH Hockey World Cup.

Salima Tete's side sealed the milestone with a 3-1 win over World No. 5 Germany in the 5th/6th place classification match in Amsterdam on Thursday, marking India's best result at the tournament since they finished fourth at the inaugural edition in 1974.

The team went through the campaign with just one defeat,

holding higher-ranked sides China, England and Australia to draws and recording a 6-1 win over South Africa, before completing their run under Chief Coach Sjoerd Marjine with the win over Germany.

Congratulating the team on the achievement, Hockey India President Dilip Tirkey said, "This is a historic result for Indian women's hockey. To finish fifth at a World Cup after 52 years is a testament to the hard work, resilience and fighting spirit this team has shown throughout the tournament." PTI

entire tournament?

No, the fight doesn't surprise me because they know I want more and more and more, and that I don't accept when we don't fight. But that is the most difficult part, to also control the game in ball possession and not only non-ball possession. So, our non-ball possession was really good this tournament. Now, we also have to create more and execute more.

What do you think that the level was?

I think we did really well. Only in the third quarter, they were better. But the rest, we controlled the match and we had to win that match. I was a little disappointed at the end that we didn't get three points. Everybody was happy with the draw because it was a long time and felt like, 'Hey, we are close to them, we can win against them.' But yeah, then we also have to execute.

Is the execution from the attackers the next step this team will have to take?

No, for me, the last match against Germany, I was happy

for more reasons.

Not only the result, but also what we have shown in ball possession and what we have created. I think that'll need to be better. But that is the most difficult part, to also control the game in ball possession and not only non-ball possession. So, our non-ball possession was really good this tournament. Now, we also have to create more and execute more.

In your last stint as the coach, good results came towards the end of the stint at the Tokyo Olympics. Now, the good results have come at the start of your journey. Is that more encouraging?

If they let me do my thing, what goes really well, I will beat my best. I am working in the best environment right now and I am really happy the way it is going now. It's always been like that in my career. The less interruptions from the outside world, the better it is for me and the team.

Revival mantra: Crystals, threads, and sense of belief



The women's team's 5th place was their best since 1974. HOCKEY INDIA

Mihir Vasavda Mumbai, August 28

SAVITA PUNIA remembers holding the stone in her hand. During a camp in Bengaluru, every member of the Indian women's hockey team was given a tiger eye crystal by coach Sjoerd Marjine. The players were asked to hold it, feel it and squeeze it as Marjine spoke about what the Indian team was, what it could become and where it wanted to go.

A few months later, India produced their best World Cup performance in years, finishing fifth and restoring a sense of belief around a team that had endured a turbulent period. For Marjine, that revival has been about much more than hockey. "It was a crystal stone. He gave it to the whole team, one by one, and said that you can keep it with you," Savita told *The Indian Express*. "There was so much boosting from inside."

The crystal eventually gave way to a thread worn around the wrist — something the players could carry with them all the time.

It might sound like an unusual team-building exercise. But for Marjine, it had a deeper meaning. And a reminder. Every time the players looked at the band, he wanted them to think of the team before themselves. "Okay, I have to do it for my team. I have to be there for my team. It's not about my individual goals. It's about the team goals," Marjine said, explaining the thought behind the exercise. The crystal, he added, was also about calm, strength and belief — "I need to believe and play with guts."

The symbolism was particularly significant given when the Indian women's team was coming from.

The period before Marjine's return had been turbulent. Under previous coach Harendra Singh, the team had struggled with results and, more worryingly, internal unrest. Players had written to Hockey India raising concerns over the environment within the group, with senior players eventually stepping in to flag issues. By the time Marjine returned, repairing relationships and rebuilding trust was as important as improving the state of play.

His brief from Hockey India was therefore remarkably straightforward.

"For me, the assignment from Hockey India was, 'Spend, you have to create unity and they must show to the outside world that they are enjoying themselves and that they are a team,'" Marjine said.

That is why the work has

"It was a crystal stone. He gave it to the whole team, one by one, and said that you can keep it with you. There was so much boosting from inside."

SAVITA PUNIA INDIA GOALKEEPER & EX CAPTAIN

gone beyond the tactical board. One of the key figures in that process has been Ben Wienk, whom Marjine prefers to describe as a performance coach rather than simply a mental coach. Wienk has helped the staff understand the players individually, beginning with questionnaires and then individual conversations. "Every player, every person in life has other drives and needs to be coached in another way," Marjine said. "Sometimes direct, sometimes a little bit easy."

The profiles, Marjine said, have also helped teammates understand one another better — why an introvert might react differently from an extrovert, or why different players make different decisions. That has helped create the sort of openness Savita identifies as the biggest change in the group. "Team unity," she said when asked what had changed the most.

The players are now eager to ask questions in meetings and feel worried about how the coaches might respond if something goes wrong. The staff, Savita said, have given them freedom — but also made clear that freedom comes with responsibility. "There is no fear that if I ask a question, how will the coach respond," she said.

Bringing back joy

There has also been a deliberate effort to bring joy back into the environment. After India's match against Germany at the World Cup, Savita noticed something she had not seen in the team for a long time: smiles.

Marjine believes that begins with the people around the team. "I like to make jokes with them. I have a staff that enjoys things very much. We have a lot of fun with each other," he said. "And I think when the staff enjoys with each other, and they're laughing, the girls also feel that."

And after a difficult period in which the team had seemed to be carrying more doubt than joy, that may be Marjine's most important contribution so far: reminding India's women that before they can play together, they first have to feel like a team.

• A GERMAN ICON

Julianne once chased the world No. 1 ranking, then she went incommunicado

Vanished from badminton a decade ago; a racquet bag left behind in a German training hall remains unclaimed

Shivani Naik Mumbai, August 28

MIRANDA WILSON came from a family of well-known musicians in Germany. She was captivated by the piano, the oboe, the violin, and might well have spent her life playing concerts among instruments she loved. Instead, last week, the 26-year-old was in Delhi with a different set of strings, treading a tougher road than the one her family had laid out, in something she loved even more than music: badminton.

Her reason traces back to a literal blast from the past, former World No. 2 Julianne Schenk of Germany. "Around 2013, Julianne completely disappeared from badminton. There was a controversy with the federation. I was still very

young when she was preparing for the 2012 Olympics, and we were at a juniors camp at the same centre and were completely impressed with her discipline in preparation and fighting spirit. She used to show I chose badminton, looking up to her," Wilson says, sending out an appeal for the former star to return.

In 2015, German media reported that Schenk had already retired, having forsaken her spot in main draws, or lost early on purpose, to fall out of the Top 10. She told *Rheinische Post* she couldn't continue, and would become a trainer instead, study at university, and write a book. Turning up for events was mandatory for top players, or they faced a heavy fine. So Schenk simply vanished from the circuit while

she decided what to do next, and nobody in badminton heard from her again.

Then, one day, she went incognito from the national training base in Mülheim, cutting off contact with anyone from the sport. "Her kitbag is still back there at the academy," says Bernd-Volker Brahm, a photographer with Mitteldeutscher Rundfunk, in Delhi for the Championships. The veteran badminton writer, who chronicled Schenk's rise as an unlikely elite star in an unlikely sport for Germany, has tried tracking her down.

"We were friends," he says. But without success. "There had been a controversy with the German federation backing in the day, over Julianne wanting her own coaching staff, which the federation refused to allow.



Julianne Schenk missed out on a bronze at the 2009 Worlds.

She had been a pioneer in Germany, but now she has completely cut herself off. Even her family doesn't know where she is," he adds.

Schenk's name has loomed large over this World Championships, with top European names, including Scotland's Kirsty Gilmour, crediting the German trendsetter, who would be 44 now, for their own



"Julianne was an outstanding player. She has some great international achievements to her name. She would certainly be eligible for an honour in the Hall of Fame"

HELMUT UFERMANN PRESIDENT OF CLUB DER DEUTSCHEN MEISTER

confidence jump-smashing in the women's game. The last World Championships held in

India, in 2009, had been a near-miss for Schenk, a bronze that slipped away when she lost 21-19 in the decider to Pi Hongyan.

Power and energy

But back when Hyderabad hosted that edition, and India's own badminton resurgence was just beginning under Saina Nehwal, Schenk had been a formidable opponent. She was feisty, kept high in the air, and thwacked down the shuttle like a hell-raiser in a metal band, scoring points with a power and explosive energy that was, then, unconventional.

The Chinese domination of that era still prized technical efficiency, balletic finesse and long fitness-driven rallies. Schenk, though, was in a hurry to break through the Asian amaze-maze that badminton tended to be.

The Danes at least had a system in place. Germany, despite a thriving club and league structure, had never dreamt of

elite ambitions until Schenk came along, promising to take on the Chinese. Not in success, but in fearlessness, she preceded even Carolina Marin. Officialdom eventually caught up with her, though, and drove her away from a sport she had once nearly ruled, while chasing the world No. 1 ranking.

The Club der Deutschen Meister, a group of German Champions) has been keen to induct Schenk into the German Hall of Fame, to celebrate her bronze at the 2011 London World Championships.

Club president Helmut Ufermann told *The Indian Express*, "Julianne was an outstanding player. She has some great international achievements to her name. She would certainly be eligible for an honour in the Hall of Fame. However, currently, we have no contact with her, and despite a few attempts, we can't reach her."

The kitbag left behind at

Mülheim, racquets still inside it, remains a painful reminder to the German badminton fraternity. "The way she just left them there in the practice hall was as if she said, 'I'm finished with everything to do with badminton.' She deserves to be in the Hall of Fame, because so many in Europe were inspired to work hard and aim high because of Julianne."

Soon after being left in the lurch by the German federation, she reached the final of the Indonesia Open, after just one training session with the Indian Badminton League.

She was presumed retired. But it has proven too quiet even for the German shuttlers and international stars who have tried, and failed, to reach her. So when Gilmour named her as an inspiration for the jump smash, and Wilson said she remained one step, the silhouette of Julianne Schenk rose again on the horizon. "Badminton misses her," Brahm says.